

AGE OF MYTHOS

Northeast — Chapter 2 — Civil War

Northeast · Pragjyotisha · English Edition

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Arunodaya Kshetra

Tawang. The first Tuesday of September. Five-forty a.m. The eastern ridge above the Tawang Monastery at three thousand four hundred metres altitude. The first eastern light is forming behind the Bhutan-border ranges; the sky is rose at the horizon, deepening to indigo at the zenith.

Udayagiri is at the ridge-stone. He is thirty-one. He is in the dawn-walker robe, knee-length, deep amber, with the gayal-hide sash at his waist. He carries the Uday-spear — the dawn-forged spear his line has carried for four hundred and seven years, re-forged each dawn in the first light's heat. The spear's shaft is hill-bamboo; the head is a thin double-edged copper-alloy blade; the binding is gayal-leather wrapped in twelve turns. He has been at the ridge-stone every dawn for two thousand seven hundred and forty-eight consecutive days.

The first-light arrives at five-forty-three a.m. He turns the spear's blade-edge to the east. The blade catches the first ray. The metal warms in his hand — the daily re-forging that the saga's gayal-bond performs at the moment-of-light. He greets the dawn aloud in Apatani-Adi-Galo — the three-tribe ceremonial trade-tongue that has been Arunodaya-Kshetra's greeting-language for six centuries.

He says, into the morning air: "The dawn cannot be stopped. The kingdom is greeted. The day is begun."

The three-tribe trade-tongue is heard, as it has been heard every morning for six centuries, by approximately four hundred dawn-walkers across the kingdom — one ridge-elder per tribal sub-village — performing the same greeting at the same minute at their own local first-light. The greetings overlap across the time-zone-staggered ridges; the kingdom-net of dawn-walkers covers the state in concentric expanding light-rings from east to west across about thirty-eight minutes (the time it takes the first-light to walk from the Roing eastern ridge at the Mishmi Hills to the Tawang western ridge at the Bhutan border).

Udayagiri completes his greeting at five-forty-five a.m. He returns down the ridge-trail to the monastery's administrative wing where the kingdom's morning-council convenes at six. The morning-council is a thirty-minute briefing with the senior administrative monk Sonam-Lama-Bumla (no relation to Sikkim's Sonam at Rumtek; the name Sonam is common across the Karmapa-and-Tawang lineages), the state-government district

magistrate's representative, and the three regional dawn-walker captains (Lower Subansiri, Anjaw, and West Kameng).

At the morning-council Sonam-Lama-Bumla raises a single new agenda-item: "The Tawang night-cult has grown to eleven hundred members. The new membership in the past fortnight is three hundred and twelve. The growth-rate is accelerating, not stabilising. The fourteenth-month threshold the night-cult appears to have set has been crossed. We must address it at the kingdom-level. Today."

Udayagiri sets down the tea-cup he had just lifted to his mouth. He has been hearing about the night-cult for fourteen months. He has approached it the way he approaches every shadow that forms inside the kingdom: more dawn, more first-light walks, more institutional outreach. He has personally led six morning-walks for war-trauma survivors over the past year. The morning-walks have helped no one. The walkers have politely attended; some have cried at the first-light moment; none have returned.

The night-cult has been growing, in those fourteen months, by approximately fifteen new members per week. The eleven-hundred-member threshold means the cult is now larger than five of the kingdom's twenty-six recognised village-clusters.

He says, into the council chamber: "The Comforter. Has he been seen. Confirmed seen."

Sonam-Lama-Bumla says: "Three times in the last six weeks. The Sela Pass shadow-zone. Always in the late afternoon, two hours before sunset, when the pass-shadow is at maximum extent. Always speaking to the Galwan-veterans first — the 2020 survivors. Then the Tawang-clash bereaved, the 2022 families. Then the Ziro forest-fire burned, the 2024 survivors. The pattern is consistent. He is finding the wounds the kingdom's dawn-walks have not reached."

Udayagiri says: "Description. Voice. Build. Gait."

Sonam-Lama-Bumla says: "Forty-four. Tall. Soft-voiced. Speaks Hindi and Apatani-Adi-Galo and what one of the older clash-veterans described as 'cave-Tibetan' — the dialect spoken in the deep-cave-system the kingdom's northern border touches. Walks slowly. Sits with people. Listens for hours before speaking. When he speaks the listeners report a sense of being seen. The sense is the cult's primary recruitment-vehicle. They are not joining a doctrine. They are joining a man who finally heard them."

Udayagiri does not respond for thirty seconds.

He says: "Is he Asta-Asura."

Sonam-Lama-Bumla says: "The cave-Tibetan dialect is the indicator. So is the listening-pause. So is the height. The kingdom has not seen Asta-Asura since the cave-system battle nine years ago. The description matches."

Asta-Asura is, by the kingdom's oldest dawn-walker commentary tradition, Udayagiri's own shadow split off at the moment of his birth. He was born — that is, came into separate existence — in the first second of Udayagiri's first dawn-greeting at the Tawang ridge thirty-one years ago, when the infant Udayagiri's shadow cast eastward by the rising sun did not retract when the sun cleared the ridgeline. The shadow remained. It walked away. It grew. By the time Udayagiri was nine years old the shadow was a fully separate person, living in the deep-cave-system that runs beneath the Bhutan-Arunachal border, ten kilometres north of the Tawang valley.

The shadow had a face. The face was Udayagiri's face inverted — the same bone-structure, but the planes of light and dark reversed. Where Udayagiri's cheek caught the morning sun, Asta-Asura's cheek was in deeper shadow. Where Udayagiri's eye reflected the dawn, Asta-Asura's eye absorbed it.

In Chapter One Udayagiri had not fought Asta-Asura directly. The Ch 1 antagonist had been the elder sister Tamasi, taken from the family at age three by raiders from across the northern border, raised in the cave-system that had become Asta-Asura's territory. Tamasi's suffering and Asta-Asura's growth had occurred along the same cave-system but on different lineage-axes — she by human trauma, he by metaphysical detachment. At the Chapter One climax Tamasi had retreated deeper into the cave-system with the surviving cave-dwellers; Asta-Asura had vanished from sight altogether, his location unconfirmed for nine years.

He has now reappeared at the Tawang night-cult's recruitment-zone in the form of the Comforter. The reappearance is the chapter's first event.

Week two of the chapter. Tawang Sela-Pass shadow-zone — the wide afternoon-shadow that the four-thousand-one-hundred-metre Sela ridge casts down into the upper Tawang valley from about three p.m. to sunset. The shadow-zone is roughly four kilometres long and two kilometres wide. The temperature inside the shadow is approximately seven degrees Celsius cooler than the sunlit valley floor.

The night-cult meets at the centre of the shadow-zone at four p.m. on weekdays. The meeting-place is a low wooden platform — about eight metres by six — constructed by the cult members over the past year out of timber recovered from the 2024 Ziro forest-fire's burn-zone. The platform is the cult's only physical structure. It has no walls, no roof. The shadow is the only ceiling. The cult does not call the platform a temple; they call it the listening-floor.

Udayagiri walks to the listening-floor at four-thirty p.m. on the twelfth day of the chapter. He walks alone. He does not carry the Uday-spear (he has left it at the monastery; carrying it into the shadow-zone would be a hostile statement and he is not yet making one). He is in plain Adi-tribe wool with no insignia. He has dressed deliberately. He does not want to be seen as the kingdom's representative; he wants to be seen as a member of the kingdom who has questions.

The cult's outer ring — about three hundred members today, the weekday-low — recognises him at about eighty metres. The recognition propagates inward. By the time he reaches the listening-floor's edge there are perhaps forty cult-members in his immediate line-of-sight, all of them studying him with the careful absence-of-aggression that characterises every interaction inside the shadow-zone. The cult has explicit instructions from the Comforter: "If the dawn-walker comes, do not greet him as opposition. Greet him as a man who has not yet rested. Offer him shade. Do not insist on it."

Asta-Asura is on the listening-floor. He is in plain dark-grey homespun. He is sitting cross-legged at the floor's eastern edge with a Galwan-survivor named Tashi-Norbu (the name Tashi is common in Tawang; this Tashi is a 2020 Galwan veteran, fifty-one years old, missing his left arm below the elbow from the river-stone clash). Asta-Asura has been sitting with Tashi-Norbu for two hours. Tashi-Norbu has been talking for the last forty minutes. Asta-Asura has not spoken during those forty minutes. He has nodded twice.

Udayagiri stops at the listening-floor's western edge. He does not step onto the floor. He waits.

Asta-Asura looks up. He sees Udayagiri.

He says, in plain Hindi, in the Comforter's soft register: "Brother. You have come. Will you sit. There is room at the western edge."

The address is the kingdom's neutral kinship-form — *bhai*, brother, used between strangers across the tribal-line. It carries no doctrinal weight. It is also, in the cave-Tibetan

tradition Asta-Asura learned from, the form used to address a shadow-twin.

Udayagiri does not sit. He stands at the western edge.

He says, in the same plain Hindi, at the same volume: "Comforter. I have come to talk. I will stand. The talking will be brief."

Asta-Asura nods. He gestures to Tashi-Norbu in a way that indicates: Continue when you are ready; this conversation is between brothers; you are welcome to listen or to step off the floor as you choose. Tashi-Norbu stays. He has been silent in his life for a long time; he wants to hear what the dawn-walker will say to the man who finally listened to him.

Udayagiri says: "What you are doing here is real. The grief is real. The shade you are offering is real. The cult members are real. I have come to ask three questions. Will you answer them."

Asta-Asura says: "Yes."

Udayagiri says: "First question. Are you Asta-Asura."

Asta-Asura says: "Yes."

Udayagiri says: "Second question. Are you here to destroy the dawn-walk."

Asta-Asura says: "No."

Udayagiri says: "Third question. What would you ask of the kingdom."

Asta-Asura is silent for about fifteen seconds. He looks at Tashi-Norbu beside him. He looks at the perhaps three hundred cult-members in the shadow-zone around them. He looks at the four-thousand-one-hundred-metre Sela ridge above them. He looks back at Udayagiri.

He says: "I would ask that the kingdom build the room the morning will agree to wait outside of. The room is one room. The morning is the kingdom's vocation. The room is the kingdom's mercy. Build the room and I will be its caretaker. The cult-name will not change — the members have earned the name. The room will be the cult's home and the kingdom's recognised institution. The shade will not be hidden any more. The shade will be administered."

Udayagiri does not respond for a long time.

He says, finally: "I will think."

He turns. He walks back across the shadow-zone toward the sunlit valley floor. The cult-members watch him leave. None of them speaks. Tashi-Norbu, after Udayagiri is about a hundred metres west of the listening-floor, says to Asta-Asura: "Comforter-la. Will he build the room."

Asta-Asura says: "He will. The brother does not yet know he will. He will know in about five weeks."

Week three. Above the cloud-line at four thousand two hundred metres on the Sela ridge's northern face. The hermit's shelter — a single stone hut three metres by two, no door (the wind does not enter at this altitude in this orientation), a single low entrance, a butter-lamp inside, a small stove, no other furniture. Baba Parashar has lived in the shelter for forty-one years.

Baba Parashar is sixty-eight. He is in faded saffron robes, wool socks, no shoes. He has not descended below the cloud-line since 1985. He speaks to the clouds. The clouds report the weather-patterns of the entire subcontinent to him as patterns of vapour-shape. He interprets the patterns as metaphors. His prophecies are weather-forecasts in metaphor and they are always accurate. He has been Udayagiri's mentor since Udayagiri was twelve. Udayagiri climbs to the shelter approximately twice a year. The climb takes three days from Tawang.

Udayagiri arrives at the shelter at dusk on the seventh day after the listening-floor conversation. He carries one wool blanket, one small bag of tsampa-and-tea, one small bottle of mustard-oil, no spear (he never carries the spear above the cloud-line; the daily re-forging requires the dawn-light, which the cloud-line interrupts). He has been thinking about Asta-Asura's offer for seven days. The thinking has produced no clarity. He has climbed for clarity.

Baba Parashar is at the shelter's entrance when Udayagiri arrives. He is looking northwest at a low cloud-bank that is forming over the Bhutan-border ranges. He does not turn at Udayagiri's arrival. He waves toward the stove.

He says, in Apatani-Adi-Galo: "Make the tea. Three cups. The third is for the cloud that arrives at midnight. The cloud is bringing news from the Lower Subansiri."

Udayagiri makes the tea. He boils the water on the stove with a small handful of pine-needle kindling. He pours three cups. He places the third at the shelter's entrance for the midnight cloud.

He sits beside Baba Parashar at the entrance.

He says: "Baba-la. The Comforter has asked the kingdom to build a room. The room would hold managed shade alongside the dawn. The cult would be its caretakers. The kingdom would recognise the cult institutionally. I have been thinking for seven days. I do not know whether to build the room or to refuse it."

Baba Parashar does not respond immediately. He watches the northwest cloud-bank for about three minutes. The cloud-bank is moving slowly south-east; the cloud's shape is a long thin ribbon with a slight curve at the western end.

He says, finally: "The cloud at the western end is curved because the wind at four thousand metres is pushing it down and the wind at three thousand metres is holding it up. The cloud is being shaped by two opposing winds. The cloud does not choose between them. The cloud holds both shapes at once and the result is the curve. The curve is the cloud's honest answer."

He pauses. He sips the tea.

He says: "Your kingdom is being shaped by two opposing winds. The first wind is the kingdom's six-century-old vocation of dawn-walking. The second wind is the eleven hundred unhealed members of the night-cult, plus the seventeen thousand five hundred war-trauma survivors and bereaved families and burned forest-survivors who have not joined the cult only because they do not yet know it exists. The first wind is the kingdom's vocation. The second wind is the kingdom's wound. You cannot push the second wind back to the cave-system; the wound is already inside the kingdom. You cannot push the first wind aside; the vocation is the kingdom's name. The honest answer is the curve."

Udayagiri says: "Build the room."

Baba Parashar says: "Build the room. But understand the cost. The dawn-tribes will not forgive you for three or four generations. The night-cult will follow you only as long as the Comforter follows the agreement. Both factions will believe you have surrendered to the other. The kingdom will not understand the curve as the honest answer for at least a decade. You will be the dawn-walker who built the first shadow. The history-books in your lifetime will record this as your shame. The history-books in your great-grandchildren's lifetime will record this as the kingdom's saving. You will not be alive for the second history-book. You will live with the first one."

Udayagiri sits with the tea-cup at his lips for about a minute without drinking.

He says: "Will you come down with me. Will you announce the room from the dawn-walker's side. The dawn-tribes will not accept it from me alone. They will accept it from you."

Baba Parashar does not respond for thirty seconds.

He says: "Yes. I will come down. I have been above the cloud-line for forty-one years. I am due to descend. The kingdom requires it. I will descend tomorrow at first light. I will walk to the Tawang valley pass with you. I will speak at the kingdom-council. I will say what I have said to you. The dawn-tribes will hear me. The night-cult will hear me. The kingdom will hear me."

He pauses. He looks at the northwest cloud-bank again. The cloud-bank has moved further south-east and the curve at the western end has deepened.

He says: "The cloud is telling me one more thing. Both factions will be carrying weapons at the pass tomorrow. The cloud cannot tell me which faction will fire first. The cloud can only tell me that whoever stands at the centre of the pass between the two factions will be the cloud-shape's curve. The curve does not survive being shaped by two opposing winds. The cloud knows this. The cloud is telling me anyway."

Udayagiri says: "Baba-la. Then I will stand at the centre. Not you."

Baba Parashar says: "No. You are the dawn-walker. The kingdom needs you alive on the other side of the curve. The curve needs a different body. The cloud has told me whose body. The cloud is honest. The cloud is also kind. The cloud has given me a forty-one-year warning. I have had enough warning. I will stand at the centre. You will stand at the dawn-tribe's line, ten paces from me. You will not move when the arrows arrive. You will let me be the curve. The dawn will be your teacher in this matter and the cloud will be mine."

The midnight cloud arrives. The third tea-cup is drunk by the cloud. Udayagiri does not see the drinking but the cup is empty at one a.m. when he checks it. The cloud's news from the Lower Subansiri is that the Lower Subansiri night-cult subsidiary has reached six hundred members; the news confirms the cult is no longer a Tawang-local phenomenon. The kingdom needs the room within the month.

Udayagiri sleeps three hours. They begin the descent at four a.m.

Week three, day three. The Tawang valley pass at three thousand three hundred metres altitude — the principal valley-crossing between the eastern dawn-tribe villages and the western Sela-Pass shadow-zone where the night-cult meets. The pass is the kingdom's natural geographical division between the two communities.

Baba Parashar has descended below the cloud-line for the first time in forty-one years. The descent has taken him eleven hours; he is at the pass by three p.m. He is exhausted but composed. His feet, unused to walking at altitudes below four thousand metres, are blistered. He has refused medical attention. He says he will rest after the council.

The kingdom-council has been convened on a Thursday-emergency basis. The eastern dawn-tribe representatives are arrayed on the pass's eastern edge — about a hundred dawn-walker captains and tribe-elders from the thirteen recognised sun-tribes. They are armed with traditional dawn-walker spears (long copper-headed, eastern-light forged); some carry modern rifles purchased through the state-government's tribal-defence allocation. The night-cult representatives are arrayed on the pass's western edge — about a hundred and twenty cult-members. They are not armed with traditional weapons (the cult forbids them) but a significant minority carry modern hunting-rifles. The rifles are not officially cult-sanctioned but the cult's senior delegates have not confiscated them.

The pass itself — the open ground between the two edges — is about sixty metres wide and a hundred and twenty metres long. It is empty.

Baba Parashar walks alone to the centre of the pass at three-fifteen p.m. Udayagiri stops at the eastern edge, ten paces from the dawn-tribe representatives' front rank. Sonam-Lama-Bumla stops beside Udayagiri. Tashi-Norbu the Galwan-veteran has come from the western edge and stops at the night-cult representatives' front rank.

Baba Parashar reaches the centre. He stops. He raises his right hand. The gesture is the dawn-walker's neutral-address gesture — palm forward, fingers spread, held at eye-level.

He speaks. He speaks in Apatani-Adi-Galo, then repeats each sentence in cave-Tibetan, then repeats each sentence in Hindi. The triple-language address takes about twelve minutes.

He says: "Kingdom of the rising sun. Children of the dawn-walk. Children of the listening-floor. I have come down from the cloud-line for the first time in forty-one years because the kingdom requires that I come down. The kingdom is being shaped by two opposing winds. The first wind is the dawn-vocation. The second wind is the kingdom's wound. The

honest answer is the curve. The curve is the building of the room the morning will agree to wait outside of. The room will be built at Tawang in the eleventh week of this chapter. The night-cult will be its caretakers. The dawn-walkers will recognise it institutionally. The kingdom-council will register the cult as the Order of the Dawn-Shadow Temple. The Comforter will be the Temple's shade-master. Udayagiri will be the Temple's dawn-master. Tani-of-the-Veil —"

He pauses. He has not yet been introduced to Tani-of-the-Veil. He has been told her name by the cloud. He says it for the first time.

"Tani-of-the-Veil will be the Temple's translator between the two masters. The kingdom-council registers the Temple by my authority as the senior cloud-speaker of the kingdom. The registration is effective at the moment of this address's completion. The dawn-tribes will accept the registration because the cloud-speaker has authority over kingdom-institutional matters under the kingdom's six-century-old founding charter. The night-cult will accept the registration because the Comforter has agreed to the architecture in advance. The kingdom is now whole in the curve."

He lowers his right hand.

The eastern dawn-tribe's third-rank archer — an unnamed twenty-three-year-old dawn-walker who has been at the Tawang clash in 2022 and has lost his elder brother and his cousin in the same hour — raises his bow at three-twenty-seven p.m. He has not been authorised to fire. His bow-arm is shaking. The arrow is on the string.

The western night-cult's second-rank rifleman — an unnamed thirty-one-year-old Ziro forest-fire survivor whose grandmother died in the second-day burn-wave and whose face is half-scarred from the same fire — raises his rifle at three-twenty-seven p.m. He has not been authorised to fire. His finger is on the trigger. The rifle is unsafetied.

Neither faction's senior delegates see the raising. Neither faction's discipline-officer intervenes.

The dawn-walker fires the arrow at three-twenty-seven-thirty-eight p.m. The arrow travels approximately fifty-five metres at an initial velocity of fifty-four metres per second.

The rifleman fires the bullet at three-twenty-seven-forty-two p.m. The bullet travels approximately forty-eight metres at an initial velocity of seven hundred and forty metres per second.

The arrow reaches Baba Parashar's chest at three-twenty-seven-thirty-nine-point-one p.m. The arrowhead enters between the third and fourth ribs on the right side and pierces the right lung at a depth of about eleven centimetres.

The bullet reaches Baba Parashar's back at three-twenty-seven-forty-two-point-three p.m. The bullet enters between the seventh and eighth thoracic vertebrae and exits through the upper-left abdomen.

Baba Parashar is dead at three-twenty-eight-fourteen p.m. The death is approximately thirty-six seconds after the first arrow.

The pass is silent for about eighteen seconds. Then both senior delegate-lines move forward simultaneously to apprehend their own shooters. The dawn-walker is restrained at three-twenty-eight-forty p.m. by Sonam-Lama-Bumla and two dawn-tribe elders. The rifleman is restrained at three-twenty-eight-forty-five p.m. by the night-cult's discipline-officer Karma-Norbu (no relation to Tashi-Norbu).

Udayagiri walks to the centre of the pass at three-twenty-nine-twelve p.m. He kneels beside Baba Parashar's body. He does not weep. He places his right palm above his teacher's forehead in the dawn-walker's farewell gesture. He says, in plain Apatani-Adi-Galo, audibly to the eastern and western edges: "The curve has held. The cloud was honest. The cloud was kind. The forty-one-year warning was the cloud's last gift."

Asta-Asura walks to the centre of the pass at three-twenty-nine-thirty p.m. He arrives from the western edge unarmed. He kneels at the opposite side of the body from Udayagiri. He places his right palm above his own forehead and lowers it — the cave-Tibetan farewell gesture, mirror to the dawn-walker's.

The two men do not look at each other. They look at the body.

Asta-Asura says, in cave-Tibetan, then in Hindi: "Brother. The kingdom has begun the room with this man's body at its first cornerstone. We will build the room. We will name the man at the consecration. We will not let his name fade. The cloud was right. The curve was honest. The kingdom needed this man's body. I am not glad. I will help."

Udayagiri does not respond. He stays at the centre of the pass with the body until Sonam-Lama-Bumla and Karma-Norbu jointly arrange the stretcher and the carrying party. The body is carried up to the cloud-line that night for cremation in the traditional dawn-walker manner; Asta-Asura and three of his senior cult-delegates accompany the cremation party.

The cremation is performed at first light the following morning by Udayagiri and Asta-Asura together — the first joint act across the faction-line. The ashes are divided equally; half are scattered above the cloud-line at the hermit's shelter; half are returned to the Tawang valley and interred at the future Dawn-Shadow Temple site as the cornerstone.

The two shooters are arrested by the Sikkim-Arunachal joint district-magistrate's order at six p.m. that evening. Their trials are referred to the Arunachal High Court under regular criminal jurisdiction. Both men plead guilty within eleven days. Both serve fifteen-year sentences. Neither faction publicly defends the shooter. The kingdom's common position, articulated by Sonam-Lama-Bumla at the post-pass press conference: "The two shooters are the kingdom's failure to heal in time. They are not the kingdom's representatives. They are the kingdom's unhealed."

Week four. Tawang valley. The morning after the cremation. Tani-of-the-Veil arrives at the monastery's administrative wing at five-thirty a.m.

She is twenty-nine. She is a Galo-tribe woman from the Aalo district originally; she had been at the 2022 Tawang clash front-line as a battlefield medic with the Indian Army's Arunachal Scouts; she had pulled seven wounded soldiers off the river-stone before being struck herself by a flying piece of granite and losing the sight in her right eye. She had been with the night-cult for thirteen months. She had served as Asta-Asura's primary interpreter at the listening-floor — she was the only cult-member fluent in all four of the cult's working languages (Apatani-Adi-Galo, cave-Tibetan, Hindi, and English).

She is in the night-cult's plain dark-grey homespun. She has a black wool veil draped across the right side of her face from temple to chin, covering the scarred right eye-socket and the surrounding tissue. The veil is held by a small silver clip at her right temple. The veil is the source of her cult-name: Tani-of-the-Veil. She has worn the veil since the cult's third month.

She walks into the monastery's administrative wing alone, unannounced, having travelled from the Sela-Pass shadow-zone overnight on foot. She has not been authorised by the cult to make the journey. The cult's senior delegates do not yet know she has come.

She finds Udayagiri at the morning-tea station. He is alone — the morning-council has been postponed by three hours in observance of mourning. He looks up.

She says, in plain Hindi, in a steady administrative-voice: "Dawn-Walker-la. I am Tani-of-the-Veil. The cloud-speaker named me yesterday at the pass. I have come to learn what the

naming means."

Udayagiri sets down the tea-cup he has just lifted. He looks at her for about ten seconds. He sees the veil. He sees the steady voice. He sees the absence of cult-doctrine in the address.

He says: "Sit, sister. The tea is fresh."

She sits. She accepts the tea. She does not speak again until the tea-cup is empty.

She says, finally: "The naming means I am the translator. The cloud-speaker said the kingdom needs a translator between the dawn-master and the shade-master at the Temple. I am willing to be the translator if the kingdom is willing to receive me. The cult is willing to release me to the role if you formally request it of the Comforter; the request must come from your side because the cult's rule against unilateral defection requires that any cross-over be initiated by the receiving institution, not by the defector. The Comforter will agree to the release. He told me last night, before the cremation. He named the cloud's seeing as authority enough."

Udayagiri says: "Why you. Why this role."

She says: "Because I am the only cult-member who has lived in both worlds. I was at the Tawang clash, in the morning light, holding wounded men's arteries closed with my hands. I was at the listening-floor, in the afternoon shadow, holding wounded men's grief without trying to close it. The two practices are the same practice in two languages. The translator the kingdom needs is the one who has learned both languages by doing them. I am the only person currently alive in the kingdom who has done both."

He says: "The Tani in your name. The Adi-tribe creator-figure. Are you claiming descent from him."

She says: "The Tani in my name is from the cult. The Comforter named me Tani-of-the-Veil because the Adi-creator Tani was the first man to walk through the world before the world had been finished. The first man saw both the unfinished light and the unfinished dark. The veil is not the Adi-creator; the veil is the medic's veil — what I wear over the eye that the clash took. The two meanings are joined in the cult's naming-tradition. I have used the name for thirteen months. I will keep it. The kingdom may keep it."

He says: "The role is yours. I will make the formal request to the Comforter this afternoon. The request will be by Sarus-pigeon. The cremation has not yet officially ended; in-person

travel between the factions is suspended for the seven-day mourning period; the pigeon is the correct channel. The Comforter will release you by tomorrow evening. The kingdom-council will register your appointment on the third day after the mourning. The Temple's consecration is set for the eleventh week. You will work between the cult's senior delegates and the monastery's administrative wing during the seven-week build-out. You will translate at every joint meeting. You will train successors. By the time of the Sanctuary convening in Chapter Three you will have trained two more translators — one from each faction. The kingdom will not depend on a single bridge."

She says: "Yes."

He says: "Sister. The veil. Will you ever lift it."

She says, after about a half-minute's pause: "The veil is the eye the kingdom took. I will not hide that the kingdom took it. I will also not insist that the kingdom keep looking at the absence. The veil is the room I have built around my own wound. It is not unlike the room you are about to build. I will lift the veil at the Temple's consecration. I will lift it once. The kingdom will see the eye-socket. The kingdom will know what the room is for. Then I will replace the veil and continue the work. The single lifting will be the kingdom's permanent record of the wound the Temple is the answer to."

He says: "Yes."

The eleven-week build-out of the Dawn-Shadow Temple begins on the eighth day after Baba Parashar's cremation. The site is a half-hectare plot adjacent to the Tawang Monastery's western boundary, donated jointly by the monastery's administrative wing and the night-cult's shadow-zone-platform-land-trust.

The architectural design is the cloud-shape's curve. The Temple is a single oval enclosed structure, forty-two metres long along the east-west axis, eighteen metres wide along the north-south axis. The eastern half of the oval is the dawn-room — open to the eastern sky, no roof, walls only at the southern and northern arcs, the dawn-walkers' greeting-stone at the eastern apex. The western half is the shade-room — fully roofed in dark slate, ventilated through small north-and-south slit-vents, the listening-floor's timber re-installed at the western apex (the timber the night-cult had built the original outdoor listening-floor from). The two rooms meet at a central transition-arch — a low stone arch about three metres wide, one metre seventy high, which a person can walk through but cannot run through. The arch is the cloud-curve made architectural.

The build-out employs approximately three hundred workers — one hundred and fifty drawn from the dawn-tribe villages, one hundred and fifty from the night-cult. The two work-crews are arranged in mixed pairs by Tani-of-the-Veil's assignment rota; she insists that no pair contain two members from the same faction. The pairs work side-by-side for the full eleven weeks. By the third week the pairs have begun eating together at the site's noon-meal. By the seventh week the pairs have begun walking to and from the site together at dawn and at dusk. By the eleventh week three of the pairs have requested the kingdom-council's permission to formalise civil-partnership arrangements; the council approves all three.

The kingdom-council's registration of the Order of the Dawn-Shadow Temple is filed on the fourteenth day after Baba Parashar's cremation. The registration document, drafted by Tani-of-the-Veil and counter-signed by Udayagiri, Asta-Asura, Sonam-Lama-Bumla, and the district-magistrate, runs to seven pages. The first page establishes the Order as the kingdom's seventeenth recognised religious institution. The second page sets out the dawn-master and shade-master arrangement. The third page sets out the translator's standing role. The fourth page sets out the eleven-week consecration schedule. The fifth page sets out the long-term cross-faction-pair work-rota. The sixth page sets out the Karna-shadow elder's name as the Temple's cornerstone — Baba Parashar of the Cloud-Line, forty-one years above the cloud-line, dawn-walker by tradition, cloud-speaker by vocation, killed at the Tawang valley pass at three-twenty-seven-thirty-nine p.m. on the third day of the third week of this chapter. The seventh page sets out the Temple's succession-procedure for the dawn-master, shade-master, and translator positions on the death or resignation of any incumbent.

The registration is published in the state-government gazette on the seventeenth day. The registration is countersigned by the Manipur, Assam, Nagaland, Meghalaya, and Sikkim NE-Federation registry on the twenty-third day (the cross-kingdom recognition that the new Temple is regionally legitimate, independent of any individual kingdom's ratification).

Week eleven, day three. The Tawang valley. The morning of the Dawn-Shadow Temple's consecration. First light at the eastern apex's greeting-stone is timed for five-forty-three a.m. (the same minute Udayagiri had greeted the dawn at the ridge-stone on the chapter's opening day, eleven weeks earlier; the consecration has been deliberately scheduled to fall on the same first-light minute).

The Temple is fully built. The eastern dawn-room is open to the sky. The western shade-room is fully roofed. The central transition-arch holds the cloud-shape's curve in its stone-line.

The crowd at the consecration is approximately twelve thousand people. The number is unprecedented for any religious event in Arunodaya-Kshetra in the past forty years. The crowd includes approximately three thousand dawn-tribe representatives from all thirteen sun-tribes, approximately one thousand one hundred night-cult members (the full membership, minus about a hundred who are still working at the site as last-minute caretakers), approximately three thousand kingdom-government civil servants and dignitaries, approximately five thousand kingdom-citizens drawn from villages across the state who have travelled to witness, and approximately seventy-five international observers (including the Manipur, Assam, Nagaland, Meghalaya, and Sikkim NE-Federation delegations and four cross-bloodline senior-guardians from the South and Central regions, sent by Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata and Dvadashashringa respectively).

Udayagiri arrives at the eastern apex at five-forty a.m. He is in the dawn-walker robe with the gayal-hide sash. He carries the Uday-spear. He has re-forged the spear that morning at the ridge-stone above the monastery (the daily re-forging continues; the consecration does not change his standing daily discipline).

Asta-Asura arrives at the western apex at five-forty a.m. He is in plain dark-grey homespun — the cult's working garment; he has declined the kingdom-council's offer of a formal shade-master's robe (the offer was made; he had said: "The robe is the kingdom's formal recognition. I am the kingdom's informal mercy. The homespun is the honest answer."). He carries no weapon and no implement. He holds a single small clay bowl of water drawn from the Tawang valley's western stream — the shade-master's consecration-bowl, an invention of the new Order. The bowl will be poured at the transition-arch at the moment of first-light.

Tani-of-the-Veil arrives at the central transition-arch at five-forty-one a.m. She is in plain wool, neutral grey, with the silver-clipped black veil at her right temple. She carries the seven-page registration document in a sealed scroll, with the kingdom's seal and the NE-Federation's seal both visible on the cover. She will read the cornerstone naming at the moment of first-light, in all three languages (Apatani-Adi-Galo, cave-Tibetan, Hindi), in the same sequence Baba Parashar had used at the valley pass eleven weeks earlier.

The first-light arrives at five-forty-three a.m. Udayagiri turns the spear's blade-edge to the east. The blade catches the first ray. The metal warms. Tani-of-the-Veil reads the cornerstone naming. The reading takes about four minutes per language; the full triple-language reading takes twelve minutes.

At the conclusion of the triple-language reading, Asta-Asura pours the clay bowl's water at the transition-arch's threshold. The water flows from west to east across the threshold-stone, then disperses into the gravel of the eastern dawn-room's floor. The dispersion is the cult's ritual symbol for shade meeting light without resistance.

Tani-of-the-Veil lifts the silver clip at her right temple. The black wool veil falls from her face onto her shoulder. The kingdom sees her right eye-socket — empty since 2022, the scarred tissue grey-pink, the bone-orbit visible at its edge. She holds the exposed face still for about fifteen seconds. The kingdom's witnesses include the twelve thousand assembled and the regional television-and-radio broadcasters whose camera-feeds carry the image to about thirty million regional and national viewers in real time. Then she replaces the veil, re-clips it at her right temple, and steps to the side of the arch.

At the moment Tani-of-the-Veil's veil falls and the kingdom sees her eye-socket, Udayagiri feels the gayal-bond pulse through his right pectoral.

The Stage III gayal-foreleg mark begins to form. It begins at the right collarbone in the standard gayal-bond position. It arcs down across the right pectoral as the bull-gayal's right forelimb, with the hoof-impression at the lower edge near the sternum. The mark forms in approximately fourteen seconds beneath the dawn-walker robe. It is not visible to the assembled crowd. Udayagiri feels the formation as a slow warm pressure across the pectoral — the warmth is the gayal-bond's recognition of the concession.

He does not show the moment on his face. He continues the consecration-ceremony per the registration document's schedule. The dawn-room's formal opening-greeting in Apatani-Adi-Galo at five-fifty-five a.m. The shade-room's formal opening-statement in cave-Tibetan at six-oh-five a.m. The transition-arch's combined-language blessing in Hindi at six-fifteen a.m. The crowd's formal entry into both rooms in mixed-faction pairs (organised by Tani-of-the-Veil's pre-arranged rota) at six-twenty a.m. through six-fifty a.m.

By seven a.m. the kingdom is inside the Temple. The dawn-room holds about six thousand people in the open air with the eastern sky above. The shade-room holds about six

thousand people in the slate-roofed interior with the listening-floor's timber beneath. The transition-arch is open; the kingdom passes back and forth through it freely. The cloud-shape's curve is the kingdom's new architecture.

Six-fifty-seven a.m. on the same morning. Roing village in the lower Dibang valley, approximately two hundred and eighty kilometres east of Tawang, at the kingdom's eastern edge. The morning's first-light has reached Roing at five-oh-eight a.m. (the time-zone-staggered ridges' first-light walks east-to-west across the state across thirty-eight minutes). The village is going about its standard Tuesday morning. The Adi-tribe villagers are at the market-square, the schoolteacher's shop, the rice-storehouse, the river-bank.

A man walks into the village from the east at six-fifty-seven a.m. He is dressed in plain Adi-tribe homespun cotton shawl, undyed, no clan-pattern. He is barefoot. He carries nothing. The sun is at an eastern angle of approximately thirty-two degrees above the horizon — the standard mid-morning angle that casts every person, animal, and post-mounted lamp a long westward shadow of about one-point-six times the casting object's height. The man walks at a standard adult pace — about one-point-three metres per second.

He casts no shadow.

The villagers see the no-shadow at about the seventh metre of his progression. The first villager to see it is an eleven-year-old schoolboy named Tashi-Dorjee (the name Tashi is common across the Northeast; this Tashi is unrelated to the Sikkim Tashi-the-cousin and the Sikkim Tashi-Bhutia ranger and the Tawang Tashi-Norbu Galwan-veteran). The schoolboy stops walking. He stares at the dirt-path beneath the man's bare feet. There is no shadow. There is no foot-impression. There is no compression of the dirt.

The schoolboy says, in Adi: "The man has no shadow."

The next villager to see is a thirty-eight-year-old market-vendor named Mami-Bobo. She stops her selling. She stares. There is no shadow.

The next is a sixty-one-year-old elder named Aaba-Tani (the name Tani is the Adi-creator name; Aaba-Tani is "father-Tani" in the Adi honorific). He stops his morning rice-buying. He stares. There is no shadow.

The man walks the length of the village's main path. The path is about eight hundred metres long. He walks the full length at the steady standard pace. The walk takes eleven minutes and approximately fifteen seconds. During the walk approximately a hundred and

thirty villagers see him — he passes their line-of-sight in the eleven-minute window. Each of them sees the no-shadow.

He continues out of the village at the western end. He walks toward the Dibang river. He does not reach the river within the eleven-minute observation-window (the river is about three kilometres west of the village's western edge). He continues at the steady pace beyond the village's line-of-sight. None of the villagers follows him.

Within ninety minutes of his passage, none of the witnesses can remember what he looked like.

They remember he was a man. They remember he was dressed in plain Adi homespun shawl. They remember he was barefoot. They remember he carried nothing. They remember he had no shadow. They remember the no-shadow. They cannot remember his face.

The eleven-year-old Tashi-Dorjee at school during the third hour says, when his teacher asks: "Was he Adi or Galo or Apatani." He answers: "I do not know. I cannot remember." The teacher says: "Was he young or old." He answers: "I do not know. I cannot remember." The teacher says: "Was he tall or short." He answers: "I cannot remember."

The thirty-eight-year-old market-vendor Mami-Bobo tries to draw the face that afternoon. She is a competent amateur-portraitist; she has drawn faces from memory before. She cannot draw this face. She draws three different attempts. None of the three faces resembles either of the others. She destroys all three at sunset.

The sixty-one-year-old Aaba-Tani sits with two other elders at the village-square at dusk and tries to compose a verbal description. The three of them cannot agree on a single feature. The man was tall or short or middle. He was young or old or middle. He was Adi or Galo or Apatani or non-tribal. The face has erased itself from their memory.

By the evening of the same day a Sarus-pigeon-letter reaches Tawang. The letter is from the Roing village-headman to Udayagiri. The letter is two paragraphs long. The first paragraph describes the no-shadow walk. The second paragraph describes the face-erasure. The closing line reads, in Adi: "Dawn-Master-la. The kingdom has been visited by a Herald of the Maw. The Maw has taken a face from the world's memory. We have not seen this before. The kingdom requires that you read the sign at the Temple consecration's evening assembly."

Udayagiri reads the letter at seven p.m. on the consecration day. He is at the Temple's eastern apex with Asta-Asura, Tani-of-the-Veil, Sonam-Lama-Bumla, and the assembled kingdom's evening-prayer attendance.

He reads the letter aloud in Apatani-Adi-Galo and in Hindi. The twelve thousand-still-attending crowd hears it. The NE-Federation delegates hear it. The Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata-and-Dvadashashringa observers hear it. The regional television-and-radio broadcasters carry it.

Udayagiri stands at the eastern apex of the Temple at seven-thirty p.m. on the consecration evening. The dawn-room is open to the deep-evening sky above; the first stars are showing. The shade-room is lit by two hundred and forty butter-lamps arranged along the slate-walls in two long rows. The transition-arch is open; the kingdom passes through it slowly.

He says, in plain Apatani-Adi-Galo, then in cave-Tibetan, then in Hindi:

"Kingdom of the rising sun. Order of the Dawn-Shadow Temple. The Maw has sent its First Herald to Roing. The Herald is a man without a shadow whose face the witnesses cannot remember. The Herald is the Maw's most direct manifestation in human form. The Herald is not killed. The Karnataka rule holds. The Karnataka Third Herald is named the Bronze-Dust Child by a ten-year-old girl. The Goa Second Herald is named Vasco-without-a-ship by a thirty-three-year-old woman at her front step. We do not yet know who will name the First Herald. We do know what we will not do. We will not raise a weapon against him. We will not pursue him to the river. We will not investigate his face. The face is the Maw's erasure; investigating the face is the trap. We will instead build the second Temple. The Second Dawn-Shadow Temple at Roing. The Temple will be the Roing village's answer to the no-shadow walk. The Temple will be the room the Herald will be invited to walk through, when he returns, and to sit in. The Herald will return. The Maw sends Heralds back. The Temple will be ready."

He pauses. He looks at Tani-of-the-Veil at the transition-arch.

He says: "Tani-of-the-Veil will travel to Roing within the fortnight. She will draft the second Temple's registration in consultation with the Roing village-headman and the Lower Dibang district magistrate. The second Temple's caretakers will be drawn from the Roing village itself — a dawn-master from the village's sun-tribe elders and a shade-master from the village's war-trauma-survivor population, with a translator drawn from the village's teacher-or-medic professional class. The Tawang Temple is the kingdom's pilot.

The Roing Temple is the kingdom's first replication. The Maw has chosen Roing as the next site of its experiments. The kingdom will be there before the next experiment."

He pauses again.

He says: "The First Herald will be named when we name him. The naming-tradition the saga has established — from Karnataka and Goa — is that the Herald is named by the person who first recognises him as a Herald-and-not-as-a-threat. The eleven-year-old schoolboy Tashi-Dorjee at Roing is the first witness of the kingdom-side. The naming may come from him. The naming may come from someone else. The kingdom will not rush the naming. The naming is the kingdom's evidence that we have not forgotten the face. The kingdom will look at the face that has been erased and will replace the erasure with a name. The naming may take a week, a month, a year, a decade. The naming is the kingdom's patient work."

Three days after the Tawang consecration, a Sarus-pigeon arrives from the Lower Subansiri. The pigeon is from the Lower Subansiri night-cult subsidiary — the six-hundred-member sub-cult the cloud at the hermit's shelter had described to Baba Parashar at midnight eleven weeks earlier. The letter is from the sub-cult's senior delegate, an Apatani woman named Khoda-Jaya (the name Khoda is from the Apatani creator-line and means "the one who is brought forth").

The letter is short.

Dawn-Master-la. Comforter-la. Translator-la. The Lower Subansiri sub-cult requests admission to the new Order of the Dawn-Shadow Temple. The admission will be subject to the same architecture as the Tawang pilot — a dawn-master to be drawn from the Lower Subansiri Apatani-tribe elders, a shade-master to be drawn from our six-hundred-member sub-cult, a translator to be drawn from the Lower Subansiri medic-and-teacher community. The site we propose is the Hapoli town's eastern hillside — the same hillside the cloud-bank the cloud-speaker had read curves over each morning between four and six a.m. The site is one hectare. The Apatani-tribe-elder council has agreed to the donation provisionally subject to the kingdom-council's ratification. We expect to commence the build-out within the week of ratification.

Sub-cult, Lower Subansiri, — Khoda-Jaya.

The letter is read at the Temple's morning-council on the fourth day after the consecration. The kingdom-council ratifies the Lower Subansiri Temple by unanimous vote at the same

morning-council. The third Temple is begun within the fortnight.

By the end of Chapter Two, three Dawn-Shadow Temples are in active construction across the kingdom: Tawang (consecrated; in full operational use), Roing (the foundations laid; the consecration scheduled for the third month of Chapter Three; built explicitly as the Herald-return room), Lower Subansiri (the foundations laid; the consecration scheduled for the fourth month of Chapter Three). The kingdom's pilot has become the kingdom's replication-program.

Two weeks after the Tawang consecration, a Sarus-pigeon arrives at the Temple from Imphal. The pigeon is the one Moirangthem has been using for the NE-Federation correspondence-network. The letter is from Moirangthem.

The letter reads:

Dawn-Master-la. The NE-Federation has read the Order of the Dawn-Shadow Temple's registration document and the cross-kingdom co-signing has been ratified by all five federation kingdoms. The Sanctuary in Chapter Three will be a six-kingdom assembly: Kamakhya (Kamalavarna), Imphal (Moirangthem, candidate), Shillong (U-Khrawkmen, regent), Kohima (Dzulevira, deferred-vote), Gangtok (Kanchenjunga). Your vote will complete the regional ratification. Will you give it.

Udayagiri writes the reply over two days. The reply is two paragraphs long.

NE Dominant Candidate. I will give my vote at the Sanctuary. The vote will be for you. Arunodaya-Kshetra has stabilised after the First Herald's passage at Roing but the stabilisation is not yet certain — the second Herald-visit will come, and the third, and we do not know when. The Sanctuary's convening will mark the threshold across which the NE Federation will need to coordinate on the Herald-and-Temple-replication question. My vote is for you because you will be the regional voice for that coordination and because your own kingdom's Loktak Mouth-sign has shown us that the Maw is initiating form-making and our Temples are the kingdom-architecture answer.

Sub-paragraph: Tani-of-the-Veil will attend the Sanctuary as my co-translator. She is twenty-nine and will be the Sanctuary's first medic-trained attendee and the first cross-faction-defector co-administrator in the kingdom's history. Asta-Asura will not attend — the cult's self-imposed restriction is that the Comforter does not travel outside the kingdom in his first three years as shade-master. He will remain at Tawang. Sonam-Lama-Bumla will attend as the kingdom's administrative voice.

Dawn-Master-la, — U.

He sends the letter by the same Sarus-pigeon at sunset. Moirangthem receives the letter at Imphal at noon the next day. He writes the one-line reply: The accommodation is arranged. The Sanctuary will receive all three. He sends the reply by the pigeon returning, at dusk.

Six weeks after the Tawang consecration. Roing village. The first foundations of the second Temple have been laid. The Roing village-headman's daughter — a thirteen-year-old girl named Yapum-Mihu — has been appointed the second Temple's translator-in-training under Tani-of-the-Veil's remote supervision. The second Temple's build-out is being managed by a thirty-four-year-old former Tawang-clash medic named Karme-Bobo who has moved from Tawang to Roing for the role.

The First Herald has not yet returned to Roing.

Karme-Bobo has been at the Temple-site at five a.m. each morning for the past three weeks, before dawn, walking the perimeter, reading the village-headman's incident-log from the previous twenty-four hours. The log has recorded no further no-shadow walks. The log has recorded an increase in the village-elder Aaba-Tani's morning-prayers and a small uptick in the village-children's nightmares (Yapum-Mihu records nine children mentioning "a man we cannot remember" in their morning play-conversations over the past week). The Herald is, in some sense, still in the village — the absence of his face is still being felt.

On the third Thursday after the foundations are laid, Yapum-Mihu the thirteen-year-old translator-in-training arrives at the Temple-site at five-fifteen a.m. She has been at the site every dawn since her appointment. She has been quiet during her training. She has not yet been heard to speak more than a few sentences at any one assembly.

She walks up to Karme-Bobo at the site's eastern apex. The first-light is forming behind the Mishmi Hills.

She says, in Adi: "Karme-la. I have thought of a name. The First Herald. I would like to name him. The naming may not be correct. The naming may be revised later. I would like to offer it."

Karme-Bobo says: "Yes, Mihu. What is the name."

She says: "Sahodara-Aapun. The brother-without-self. In Adi. The Adi-creator-line says that Tani — the first man — had a brother who walked beside him through the unfinished world but who did not have a self of his own. The brother held the unfinished part of the world together while Tani gave it form. The brother was forgotten when the world was finished. The Adi children's songs remember him without his face. The songs do not require a face. The name in the songs is Sahodara-Aapun. The Herald is the same. He is the brother who held the unfinished part. We forgot him when the kingdom was named. We are naming him now. The naming may not return him to us. The naming may only remind us that we forgot him. That is what the name will do. It will not retrieve the face. It will hold the place where the face was."

Karme-Bobo says, after a half-minute pause: "Yes. We will send the naming to Tawang today. We will register the name with the kingdom-council on the seventh day. We will read the name at every Temple's morning-greeting. We will hold the place where the face was. The Maw will know that the kingdom did not forget the forgetting."

She nods. She returns to her translator's desk at the Temple-site's preliminary administrative tent. Karme-Bobo writes the naming-letter to Tawang in the next hour. The Sarus-pigeon carries it westward at six-thirty a.m. Tani-of-the-Veil receives it at the Tawang Temple at noon. She walks it to Udayagiri at the eastern apex.

Udayagiri reads the letter. He reads it twice.

He says, to Tani-of-the-Veil: "The First Herald is named. By a thirteen-year-old translator-in-training at Roing. The name is Sahodara-Aapun. The brother-without-self. The kingdom will hold the place where the face was. The Maw will read the kingdom's answer."

He pauses. He looks at the eastern dawn-room's open sky. The sky has begun to cloud over — the first afternoon clouds are forming.

He says: "Baba-la would have said the cloud is honest. The cloud is also kind. The kingdom has built the room. The Herald has been named. The dawn-walker has conceded the shade. The Comforter has accepted the architecture. The translator has lifted the veil. The thirteen-year-old has remembered the brother-without-self. The cloud is curved. The curve has held. The chapter is closing."

He turns the Uday-spear's blade-edge to the east one more time. The afternoon-clouds have begun to gather but the eastern sky is still open at the apex. The blade catches a thin late-afternoon ray. The metal warms.

The kingdom's next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A forty-two-metre oval temple at Tawang, the eastern half open to the sky and the western half roofed in dark slate, joined by a low stone arch a person can walk through but cannot run through. A bull-gayal-foreleg mark on a dawn-walker's right pectoral beneath the amber robe. A twenty-nine-year-old translator with a black wool veil clipped at her right temple, the veil lifted once for fifteen seconds at the consecration and then replaced. A forty-four-year-old shade-master in plain dark-grey homespun pouring a clay bowl's water across a threshold-stone from west to east. A sixty-eight-year-old hermit-prophet's ashes scattered above the cloud-line at the hermit's shelter and interred at the Temple's cornerstone in equal halves. A thirteen-year-old Adi translator-in-training at Roing reading the morning-greeting in the Adi creator-line's children's song that remembers the brother-without-self without his face. A man without a shadow walking the eight-hundred-metre length of a village main path at six-fifty-seven a.m., his face erased from the memory of every witness, his name now Sahodara-Aapun in the kingdom's permanent record — the kingdom holding the place where the face was.

Beyul Kshetra

Rumtek Monastery, Gangtok district, twenty-four kilometres south-east of the city. The first week of October. The inner sanctum is a windowless stone chamber three metres by three metres at the back of the main prayer hall. Two butter-lamps burn at the north and south walls. A single low altar of black slate runs along the east wall. On the altar, in a square-cut wooden housing the size of a child's hand, sits the Chintamani — the wish-fulfilling jewel of Avalokitesvara, the Beyul-Kshetra's primary relic, the Hidden Land's heart-stone, the thing that has remained inside this small chamber without a single hour's absence since 1959.

Kanchenjunga is at the altar at four-fifteen a.m. He is forty-one. He has been senior Beyul-guardian at Rumtek for nine years. He is in the dark-red guardian-robe with the seven-fold sash of the Karmapa lineage. His head is shaved. His hands are calloused. He has been in this chamber every dawn for three thousand two hundred and eighty-seven consecutive days.

He sees the Chintamani in its housing. He places his right palm on the altar-edge in the morning's first gesture of recognition. He does not touch the jewel. He has never touched it. No guardian has touched it in sixty-seven years.

He turns and leaves the chamber. The day's schedule is the same as every other day's. Morning prayers at four-thirty. The refugee-blessing line at six. The Tuesday community-kitchen at ten. The Wednesday camp-rotation at the south camp at one. The Thursday and Friday camp-rotations at the central and west camps. The administrative council with the Sikkim state government at five on alternating weeks.

At noon today the monastery will hold a Special Refugee-Blessing Ceremony for newly-arrived refugees from the autumn Tibetan-border surge. Two hundred and twelve refugees are scheduled to receive the blessing in three rotating batches. The Chintamani will be brought into the main prayer hall for the ceremony — not exposed, but carried in its housing on a small ceremonial palanquin from the inner sanctum to the central altar where it will sit visible (in housing) throughout the three-hour ceremony.

This is the procedure. It has been the procedure for sixty-seven years. The Chintamani is brought out four times a year for major blessing-ceremonies. The autumn refugee-blessing is one of those four times.

Twelve thousand. That is the count of refugees currently registered in the three south-Sikkim camps as of the morning of October the first. Approximately two thousand from the autumn Tibetan-border surge alone. Approximately five thousand long-standing Tibetan refugees from the 1959 wave and its descendants. Approximately two thousand from the 2008 Lhasa-unrest wave. Approximately one thousand from various Bhutan-border irregularities. Approximately one thousand identified as "ethnic-mixed" — refugees whose paperwork is unclear and who have therefore been registered as Beyul-Kshetra ward-residents under the monastery's nine-century-old compassion-charter.

The monastery has absorbed every one of them. The compassion-charter, originally written by Padmasambhava's commentators in the eighth century and re-ratified by the Karmapa lineage in 1962, admits no refugee-rejection on any ground. Every applicant is welcomed. Every applicant's family is welcomed if they arrive. Every applicant's political enemy is welcomed too. The Beyul-Kshetra has no enemies. The Beyul-Kshetra is the absence of the question of enemies.

Kanchenjunga has worked within the charter for nine years. He has welcomed two refugee Chinese-state-intelligence agents (identified by central Indian intelligence three months after arrival, then welcomed again as protected ward-residents). He has welcomed one former-Tibetan-monastery-corrupt-treasurer (who confessed to the corruption on his second week and was welcomed exactly as he had been welcomed the first week). He has welcomed a former-state-government Sikkim official accused of land-grab against the Hidden Land's own forest-boundary (welcomed; reabsorbed; placed in the camp-administration cell where his expertise on Sikkim land-records made him the camp's most effective ration-clerk).

He has welcomed all of them. The charter requires it. The charter is not a guideline. The charter is the kingdom.

In the spring of 2024, two and a half years before the chapter's opening, a man in his forties arrived at the south refugee camp with a small backpack and a thirty-page Tibetan-language autobiography written in pencil in a school-exercise book. He gave his name as Krodha-Sherpa. He said he had been born in Pelliang Village in the Tibetan-occupied zone and that his entire family had been killed in a Chinese border-clearance operation in 2018. He had walked out across the Cho La pass alone in the winter of 2022. He had spent the intervening two years in Lhasa-region Buddhist monasteries doing manual labour and waiting for a route to the Indian side.

He was welcomed. The intake clerk — a junior monk named Lobsang — logged him in the camp-administration database at intake-number 9,847. He was assigned to barrack 17-C, bed 3. His ration-card was issued the same afternoon. His autobiography was filed in the camp-archive in box 142 along with eleven hundred other recently-arrived testimonials.

He was organised. He was articulate. He spoke Tibetan-fluent, Hindi-fluent, Nepali-fluent, Sikkimese-Bhutia-fluent. He read Sanskrit and English. He was not a monk, but he had a monk's vocabulary. Within his first three months at the south camp he had started a Tibetan-language literacy class for refugee children whose schooling had been interrupted by the border crossing. Within his first six months he had organised a mutual-aid council across barracks 17 and 18, eight hundred refugees pooling ration-card supplements to support the most dependent among them. Within his first year he was running a weekly assembly for the south-camp's twelve hundred adult-male refugees, called the Compassion-Reciprocity Council, that met every Sunday evening in barrack 17-C's common room.

The other refugees began to call him the Refugee Father. The phrase began informally and became official by the end of his second year. By the autumn of 2026 — the chapter's opening — the Compassion-Reciprocity Council had grown to forty-seven hundred active members across all three south-Sikkim camps. The Refugee Father's Sunday assemblies were attended by more refugees than the monastery's own bi-weekly camp-administration meetings.

Kanchenjunga had visited the Compassion-Reciprocity Council twice. The first visit, eight months earlier, he had sat at the back of the common room and listened to the Refugee Father explain the council's ration-supplement allocation procedures. He had been impressed. The procedures were more efficient than the monastery's. The Refugee Father's administrative grasp was first-rate.

The second visit, three months earlier, he had stayed for the Refugee Father's closing-prayer. The closing-prayer was a Tibetan-language compassion-prayer attributed to the Sixth Karmapa, recited in the modern unision style. Kanchenjunga had joined the recitation. The Refugee Father had stood at the front and led it without faltering.

Kanchenjunga had walked back to the monastery that evening reassured. The kingdom's compassion-charter was producing its expected fruit. The most administratively-capable refugee in the camps was using his capability to multiply the camp's self-care. The Beyul-Kshetra was working.

He had not asked about the backpack. He had not asked about the autobiography. He had not asked the intake clerks for Krodha-Sherpa's pre-2022 history. He had not, in nine years of guardianship, ever asked any refugee about his pre-arrival history. The charter forbade it.

The Special Refugee-Blessing Ceremony begins at noon on the chapter's opening day — the first Sunday of October. Two hundred and twelve new refugees are arranged in three rotating batches of seventy-one, seventy, and seventy-one. The Chintamani is brought into the main prayer hall in its ceremonial palanquin at eleven-forty-five a.m. and placed on the central altar. The housing is opened to half-visibility — the jewel's side is exposed to the assembled refugees but not its top or its underside (the orthodox half-disclosure that has been the ceremonial standard since 1959).

The hall holds about a thousand people. Two hundred and twelve refugees in the batch-area at the front. Six hundred and ninety long-standing camp residents and monastery monks at the rear. Approximately a hundred state-government and visiting-observer guests in a side gallery on the north wall. The Refugee Father is in the front row of the rear seating, beside the senior Compassion-Reciprocity Council delegates.

Kanchenjunga performs the blessing in the standard procedure. Each refugee approaches the altar in turn, bows three times, receives the Chintamani-touched compassion-water from the senior monk's ladle on the right of the altar, drinks it, returns to the seating area. The procedure takes about thirty-five seconds per refugee. Seventy-one refugees per batch. Three batches. The ceremony is scheduled to end at three p.m.

At one-fourteen p.m., during the second batch, between refugee forty-three and refugee forty-four, the hall's south-wall butter-lamps flicker. The flicker lasts about two seconds. Both lamps. Simultaneously. The hall's ventilation does not normally produce flickers of this kind in the south-wall lamps; the prevailing draft at noon enters from the north door. Several of the monastery's senior monks notice the flicker; none stops the ceremony; the flicker is logged later as "atmospheric."

At one-forty-seven p.m. the second batch concludes. The hall enters its standard fifteen-minute interval for the seating-rotation. Two senior monks remain at the central altar. The Chintamani is still in its half-opened housing. The Refugee Father stands and walks slowly toward the south-wall butter-lamp — the one that had flickered — ostensibly to adjust the wick. He bows to the senior monk at the south side of the altar in passing. The senior monk — Lobsang, the same junior monk who had logged Krodha-Sherpa's arrival two and a half

years earlier — bows back. The Refugee Father continues to the lamp. He adjusts the wick. The lamp resumes its normal burn.

At one-fifty-three p.m. the third batch begins. The procedure continues.

At three p.m. the ceremony concludes. The Chintamani is returned to its housing, the housing is sealed, the palanquin is carried back to the inner sanctum by the standard four-monk procession with Kanchenjunga at the head.

Kanchenjunga opens the housing in the inner sanctum to perform the closing-of-day verification. He has performed this verification three thousand two hundred and eighty-seven consecutive times.

The housing is empty.

Forty-seven days. The Chintamani is missing from the inner sanctum for forty-seven days. The monastery has not announced the theft. The state-government has not been informed. Two of the senior monastery monks have been informed. Lobsang the intake-clerk-and-senior-blessing-attendant is one. The senior administrative monk, Sonam, is the other. No one else.

Kanchenjunga has decided to keep the absence private for as long as possible. The decision is not deception; it is triage. If the Chintamani's absence is announced to the refugee population, the camps will riot. Twelve thousand refugees will read the absence as the end of their welcome. They will conclude that the monastery has lost the relic that anchored their compassion-charter. They will leave the camps in panic. Half of them will die in unprepared border-crossings. The math is concrete. He has done it.

The decision is to keep the absence quiet and search the monastery, the camps, the state-government compound, the surrounding villages, in concentric rings, beginning with the closest. Lobsang and Sonam have searched the monastery building-by-building for nine days. They have found nothing. They have searched the south, central, and west camps barrack-by-barrack for another twelve days. They have found nothing. They have searched the surrounding villages with the cooperation of the Sikkim state-government chief secretary (who has been informed under strict confidentiality) for sixteen days. They have found nothing.

At forty-six days, just before dawn on the forty-seventh day, a girl arrives at the monastery's east gate.

She is sixteen years old. She has walked the four kilometres from the south camp on foot. She is wearing the standard camp-issue brown sweater and dark trousers. Her hair is uncovered. She carries no bundle, no bag, no paper. She has come empty-handed.

She is Tibetan. Her name is Pema-Chöden. She has been at the south camp for three months — arrived in the autumn surge, intake-number 11,438. Her parents and her older brother were killed in the same border-crossing she survived. Her brother was fifteen. He had been trying to help their mother across the third river-crossing on the western route. He had been shot by a Chinese border-patrol unit at the moment of helping her up. Their mother had been shot in the same burst. Their father had been shot at the same crossing on the way back trying to recover their bodies. Pema-Chöden had been on the eastern bank with their younger cousin Tashi. The two of them had walked the remaining sixty-four kilometres to the Sikkim border on foot over twelve days.

She had taken her brother's name as a middle-name on her camp-intake form. The form had her listed as Pema-Wangchuk-Chöden. Wangchuk was her brother's name. She had explained the addition to Lobsang at intake by saying: "He should keep arriving in my paperwork. He did not make it past the river. He should arrive everywhere I arrive."

She had been a quiet camp-resident for three months. She had not attended the Compassion-Reciprocity Council's Sunday assemblies. She had not attended the Tibetan-language literacy class. She had attended the monastery's twice-weekly meditation hour and sat at the back. The senior monastery monks knew her by sight. Kanchenjunga had recognised her at the blessing-ceremony forty-seven days earlier — she had been at the front of the second batch, refugee number twenty-three of the second batch. She had received the compassion-water and bowed in the standard procedure and returned to her seat.

She stands at the monastery's east gate at five-twelve a.m. The gate-keeper monk asks her the standard pre-dawn entry question. She answers: "I need to speak with Kanchenjunga-la. Alone. Now. Before the dawn-prayer."

The gate-keeper hesitates. The dawn-prayer is at five-thirty. Kanchenjunga is in the inner sanctum.

She says: "The Refugee Father is Krodha. I know because my brother went with him last week and came back wrong."

The gate-keeper opens the gate.

Kanchenjunga is at the inner sanctum altar when Lobsang brings her in. He is in his dawn-prayer position — right palm at the altar-edge, the absence of the Chintamani in front of him as it has been every dawn for forty-seven days. He has not slept the previous night. He has not slept properly in two weeks.

He turns when Lobsang opens the door. He sees the sixteen-year-old refugee girl at the entrance. He registers her face from the blessing-ceremony forty-seven days earlier. He registers that she is empty-handed. He registers that she has come at five-twelve a.m. unannounced.

He says, in his even guardian-voice: "Sit, daughter. The altar is your seat. Lobsang, the second tea."

She does not sit. She walks past the altar to the south wall and stops with her back to it. She faces him directly across the altar. The Chintamani's empty housing is between them.

She says, in Tibetan: "My brother Tashi — my cousin, not the one who died, the younger one, my mother's sister's son — went with the Refugee Father last week. The Refugee Father has been running a special evening sub-council for the new autumn boys for the past three months. The sub-council is at barrack 17-C, late, after the regular Compassion-Reciprocity Council closes. The new autumn boys are invited individually. The invitation is private. The boys who attend are told not to discuss it with the elders or the other refugees. Tashi attended for the first time twelve days ago. He came back to our barrack at three a.m. He did not speak for two days. On the third day he spoke. What he said was not Tashi."

Kanchenjunga says: "What did he say."

She says: "He said the Compassion-Charter was a Sikkimese lie. He said the Beyul was a Tibetan-fraud monastery built by collaborators with the 1959 expulsion. He said the senior monks were the inheritors of the lie. He said the Refugee Father was the only Tibetan in the kingdom who still knew what the original Beyul had been before the Karmapa lineage corrupted it in 1962. He said the Refugee Father had a plan to restore the original Beyul by removing the senior monks one by one over the next five years. He said the plan had begun last month when the Chintamani had been 'reclaimed for the original sanctum.' He said the Chintamani was now in the original sanctum and the senior monks did not know where the original sanctum was. He said the original sanctum was 'at the south camp, under the dawn-prayer-wheel.' He said I must come to the next sub-council on Tuesday or I would be considered a collaborator with the senior monks."

She pauses. She is breathing steadily. She has rehearsed the recitation.

She says: "He said this in the voice the Refugee Father had taught him. The voice was not Tashi's voice. Tashi's voice was higher and slower. The voice that spoke through Tashi was lower and faster, with the Refugee Father's exact cadence. I sat across the table from my own cousin and listened to the Refugee Father's voice come out of his mouth. He could not see me from the inside any more."

Kanchenjunga says: "How do you know the Refugee Father is Krodha."

She says: "In 2018, when I was eight, my mother took me to Pelliang Village to visit a great-uncle. We stayed for nine days. There was a man in the village who had been the village-school's deputy headmaster. He had been removed from the position the year before because three of the village children had developed a strange silence after their tutoring with him. The village had been arguing about whether to expel him for two years. He was forty at that time. He had a small backpack he carried everywhere. He had a thirty-page autobiography he had written about himself which he showed to my mother on the third evening. The autobiography was about his childhood in a different village in a different region. My mother read three pages of it and told me afterwards that the autobiography was the most carefully-constructed lie she had ever read. She told me to remember his face. She made me draw it from memory the next morning. I drew it. The drawing is in my barrack-locker. The man in the village was Krodha. The Refugee Father is the same man. The face is the same."

She pauses. Kanchenjunga has not moved.

She says: "My mother is dead. My father is dead. My older brother is dead. My younger cousin is in the Refugee Father's sub-council and is not himself any more. I have come to you because no other senior monk would believe a sixteen-year-old refugee girl. You will believe me because the Chintamani is missing from the housing on the altar between us and you have not announced it to anyone outside three people and I am the fourth person to know in this monastery. I know the Chintamani is missing because the housing's wooden joints make a different sound when the chamber is closed empty than when the jewel is inside. I have heard the chamber closed full at the blessing-ceremony forty-seven days ago and I have heard the chamber closed empty when the senior monk Sonam carried the palanquin past my barrack at the south camp three nights ago when he was searching for the jewel. The empty sound is higher. Anyone who has been listening would know."

Kanchenjunga sits down on the stone bench against the east wall. He has not been told a more devastating thing in his life. He is sitting because his knees have signalled that they are not going to support his weight any longer.

He says: "The dawn-prayer-wheel at the south camp. The one beside barrack 17-C. The large one. The black-iron one. The pilgrim-wheel installed by the Karmapa lineage in 1967."

She says: "Yes."

He says: "The wheel is hollow. The Chintamani would fit in the upper chamber. The wheel is turned every dawn by approximately two hundred camp-residents. A jewel placed in the upper chamber would not be discoverable by the wheel-turners because the turning would not open the chamber. Only a specifically-shaped key opens the upper chamber. The key was discontinued from monastery use in 1989. Three keys still exist. One is in the monastery archive. The other two are in Lhasa and Dharamsala."

She says: "The Refugee Father showed Tashi a key on the second night of the sub-council. The key was the same shape as the discontinued key. He told Tashi the key had been 'recovered from the original sanctum's sealed cupboard.'"

Kanchenjunga is silent for forty seconds. Lobsang stands at the doorway. He has not breathed audibly during the entire recitation. He breathes now.

Kanchenjunga says: "Will you walk with me to the south camp at noon."

She says: "Yes."

He says: "The Refugee Father will be at the south camp's administration office at noon. The Sunday weekly council meeting begins at one. He will see us walk in. He will know what we are."

She says: "Yes."

He says: "The Compassion-Reciprocity Council members at the south camp will outnumber my monastery escort by approximately forty to one."

She says: "The Compassion-Reciprocity Council members are not all loyal to him. About half will go with him when you draw the boundary. The other half will stay."

He says: "How do you know."

She says: "The boys in his sub-council are loyal. The men who are running the older mutual-aid networks are not. My barrack-elder is one of those men. He has been concerned about the sub-council for six weeks. He has been waiting for someone like me to come and say what he could not say. He will speak when I speak. Three of the other barrack-elders will follow him."

Kanchenjunga looks at her for a long time.

He says: "Daughter, do you know that you have just become the Beyul-Kshetra's first refugee to hold what amounts to administrative office in its nine-century history."

She says: "Guardian-la, I have not asked for office. I have asked you to draw the boundary. The boundary is your work, not mine. My work is to walk beside you to the wheel. After that we will see what the kingdom requires."

He says: "The kingdom is going to require both. Sit down. Drink the second tea. Lobsang, bring the breakfast. We will walk to the south camp at eleven."

She sits down at the altar's edge. She drinks the second tea. The dawn-prayer is missed for the first time in three thousand two hundred and eighty-eight days. The senior monks at the main prayer hall hold the dawn-prayer without Kanchenjunga, in his absence, by his standing instruction (silent in the inner sanctum until he returns) issued through Lobsang at the doorway at five-thirty-three a.m.

The Beyul-Kshetra has taken its first action under conditions of internal infiltration. The first action is breakfast.

Eleven a.m. The monastery's east-gate path. The four-kilometre walk to the south camp passes the central tea-grove, the small village of Yang-Lhakhang, and the foothills approach where the path opens onto the south-camp plateau.

Kanchenjunga walks at the front. He is in the full guardian-robe, the seven-fold sash, the prayer-beads. He carries the Karmapa-line walking-staff he has not used in nine years — a yew-wood shaft one and a half metres long with a copper-cap at the top and a small bronze prayer-wheel at the lower-third. The staff is the senior guardian's formal walking-implement, used only for cross-kingdom processions and council-summons. He has summoned it from the monastery's ceremonial cupboard at nine a.m.

Pema-Chöden walks at his left shoulder, half a pace behind. She has been given a clean monastery ward-robe to wear over the camp-sweater — a knee-length deep-red over-robe

that marks her as a guest of the senior guardian. The over-robe is not a refugee garment. It is the garment a state-government dignitary wears when received at the monastery for tea. She wears it because Kanchenjunga has insisted. The garment is its own boundary — the first boundary of the day, drawn between her and the camp she will return to in two hours' time.

Lobsang and Sonam walk at the rear, with four junior monks behind them. The state-government chief-secretary's deputy walks beside Sonam — the chief-secretary has been informed by Kanchenjunga at eight a.m. and has sent his deputy in a Sikkim-state-administration plain-clothes capacity. The deputy is unarmed. He has a satellite-phone in his sleeve-pocket and a single sealed envelope (the state-government's formal exile-of-foreign-national authorisation, pre-signed) in his inside-pocket.

The procession is not announced. The four kilometres are walked in approximately one hour and ten minutes — Kanchenjunga's normal walking pace. Pema-Chöden matches his pace. The other monks adjust to her pace as well.

They arrive at the south-camp's administration-perimeter at twelve-fifteen p.m. The administration-office is the central building of the camp — a single-storey concrete structure with a tin roof at the south-camp's central plaza. The dawn-prayer-wheel is forty metres east of the administration office, beside barrack 17-C, in the camp's eastern plaza.

The Refugee Father is at the administration-office's front step. He has been informed by his sub-council messengers (the runners are nine, twelve, and fourteen years old, refugee boys from barracks 14, 17, and 22) of the procession's approach from the second-kilometre mark onward. He has had forty-five minutes to prepare.

He is in his usual plain dark-red Pelliang-style tunic and dark trousers. He has on his wrist the small wooden prayer-bead bracelet that has marked him in the camp since 2024. He has on his face the calm reassuring expression that the camp has known him by for two and a half years.

About one thousand four hundred refugees have gathered in the central plaza by twelve-fifteen p.m. The Compassion-Reciprocity Council's senior delegates — about forty men — are arrayed in a semi-circle behind the Refugee Father. The mid-rank delegates and the sub-council boys — about a hundred and fifty — are arrayed behind the senior delegates. The general camp-population — the remaining twelve hundred — is arrayed in concentric rings further out.

The atmosphere is not yet hostile. The Refugee Father has framed the procession in advance to the senior delegates as "the senior guardian's autumn welfare-visit, accompanied by a young refugee girl whose case has come to the Compassion-Charter's special attention." The framing is plausible. The senior delegates are watching with respectful uncertainty.

Kanchenjunga stops six metres from the Refugee Father. Pema-Chöden stops one metre behind Kanchenjunga's left shoulder.

The Refugee Father bows in the Pelliang-style. The bow is technically perfect. The senior delegates bow in solidarity. Approximately three hundred of the mid-rank delegates and sub-council boys bow as well. About a thousand of the general camp-population bow, in scattered uneven groups.

Kanchenjunga does not bow. He plants the Karmapa-line walking-staff at his right side. He lifts his right palm.

He says, in Tibetan, in the senior-guardian formal-address voice that the camp has heard him use exactly four times in nine years (at the major blessing-ceremonies):

"I have come at noon to draw the first boundary of my guardianship. I have welcomed every refugee for nine years. I will continue to welcome every refugee who is here as a refugee. The Compassion-Charter is unchanged for them. The Beyul-Kshetra remains open. But I will not continue to welcome one of you. The one I will not welcome is the man standing in front of me. His name is Krodha. He arrived at this camp in 2024 under a forged Tibetan identity. He has organised a sub-council that has been recruiting boys to a doctrine of monastery-replacement and senior-monk-removal over the past three months. He has stolen the Chintamani from the inner sanctum at the autumn blessing-ceremony forty-seven days ago. He has hidden it in the upper chamber of the dawn-prayer-wheel beside barrack 17-C. He will leave the Beyul-Kshetra by sunset. He will cross the Lachen pass into the Bhutan-Tibet border region by sunset of the third day. The refugees who choose to follow him are also welcome to leave with him — the boundary is the man, not the followers, and any follower who wishes to remain in the Beyul-Kshetra without him is welcome to remain. The followers who choose to leave with him will not be barred from leaving and will be permitted to take their personal effects and a one-month ration allocation. The state-government has authorised the formal exile under the cross-border emergency-residence clause. The deputy chief-secretary will issue the exile-order to the Refugee Father in person at the conclusion of this address. The Chintamani will be

recovered from the dawn-prayer-wheel by the camp's newly-appointed Beyul-Kshetra co-administrator, Pema-Chöden of the autumn surge, who will turn the wheel three full revolutions and open the upper chamber with the recovered Karmapa-line key. The Compassion-Charter is now amended for the first time in nine centuries: a refugee who has violated the inner sanctum is no longer welcome. The amendment is limited. The amendment is necessary. The amendment is mine to draw and I am drawing it."

The address takes seven minutes. The translation into the camp's ambient mix of Tibetan-Hindi-Sikkimese is held in the listeners' own minds; Kanchenjunga's Tibetan is the original, and the bilingual listeners translate for the non-Tibetan-speakers in real-time, whispering into neighbours' ears.

The Refugee Father's face changes through the seven minutes. The change is in stages.

At minute one (the announcement of the boundary), the face shows the calm reassuring expression with an added quarter-smile — the smile of a man who recognises a rhetorical move and is preparing his counter-rhetoric.

At minute two (the naming of the forged identity), the smile narrows. The calm-reassuring is replaced by a thin focused listening.

At minute three (the description of the sub-council), the focused listening contracts. The skin around the eyes tightens. The thin lips fold inward.

At minute four (the accusation of the Chintamani theft, with specific location), the face is no longer composed. The Refugee Father's right hand — the one holding the wooden prayer-bead bracelet — trembles for the first time. The senior delegates behind him register the tremble. Their faces begin to change.

At minute five (the offered exit, the freedom for followers to choose), the Refugee Father's face composes itself again — deliberately. He is recovering. He is preparing to speak.

At minute six (the announcement of Pema-Chöden as co-administrator), the Refugee Father turns his head ten degrees to the right. He looks at Pema-Chöden directly for the first time. The look lasts about two seconds. In that two seconds his face becomes the face of the village deputy headmaster from Pelliang in 2018 that Pema-Chöden drew from memory the next morning. The mask slips for two seconds, then resets.

At minute seven (the closing "the amendment is mine to draw and I am drawing it"), the Refugee Father makes the choice that decides the rest of his Chapter Three arc. He chooses

to leave.

He bows. The bow is again Pelliang-style. The bow is shallower than the opening bow. It is the bow of a man who has accepted a defeat and is signalling, to those who will follow him, that they should also accept it for the time being.

He says, in his even camp-voice: "Senior guardian. I accept the boundary. I will leave by sunset. Those who choose to follow me will be welcome to follow. Those who choose to remain will be welcome to remain."

The Refugee Father's precise restraint is its own danger-flag. The senior delegates feel it. About half of them step back from him in the next thirty seconds — one half-pace, then another, then a third. The other half do not move.

By twelve-twenty-five p.m. the central plaza has bifurcated. The Refugee Father is at the south side of the plaza with about seven hundred refugees clustered around him. Kanchenjunga is at the north side of the plaza with about seven hundred refugees clustered around him, with Pema-Chöden at his left shoulder, with the four monastery monks behind, with the deputy chief-secretary at his right side reading from the pre-signed exile-order.

The split is forty-eight to fifty-two. The Refugee Father takes the slightly-smaller half.

At one p.m. Pema-Chöden walks alone to the dawn-prayer-wheel.

The wheel is two metres in height, one and a half metres in diameter, black-iron with the standard Karmapa-line copper-banding. It sits in a stone enclosure beside barrack 17-C. About a hundred refugees are still at the wheel from the morning-prayer rotation, but the dense crowd has dispersed. The eastern plaza is quieter than the central plaza had been.

She has the recovered key in her right hand. Lobsang has retrieved it from the monastery archive at twelve-thirty p.m. and has run the four kilometres to the south-camp eastern plaza in forty-five minutes. The key is six centimetres long, brass, with a triangular bit and a copper-band ferrule.

She walks up to the wheel. She places her left palm on the iron drum at the wheel's east face. The drum has the standard mantra-inscription — OM MANI PADME HUM — in raised brass lettering across its three rotational bands. She turns the wheel three full revolutions in the clockwise direction. The wheel turns easily on its central axle. The turning takes about forty seconds.

She finds the upper chamber's key-slot at the top of the wheel's north face — a small triangular indentation in the brass cap. She inserts the key. She turns the key one full revolution counter-clockwise.

The upper chamber opens. The chamber is a small lined cavity in the top of the iron drum, about ten centimetres deep, lined with red velvet that has been undisturbed for thirty-seven years (the chamber was last opened in 1989 when the discontinuation-of-use was logged).

The Chintamani sits in the centre of the chamber. The jewel is the size of a chestnut. It is a deep blue-purple in colour, faceted, with the small Avalokitesvara-mark engraved at the side. It has the same exact appearance it has had for sixty-seven years.

Pema-Chöden lifts the jewel out of the chamber with both hands. She has never touched it before. The jewel is warm — warmer than the surrounding air, warmer than her hands. The warmth is consistent with the jewel having been inside the iron drum for forty-seven days, but warmer than that thermal explanation alone would predict.

She walks the forty metres back to the central plaza. She carries the jewel in both hands at the level of her chest. The Refugee Father's seven-hundred followers watch her cross the eastern plaza. About a hundred of them detach from the Refugee Father's cluster and walk back to the Kanchenjunga side of the central plaza. The Refugee Father does not stop them.

She arrives at Kanchenjunga's side at one-oh-six p.m. She holds the jewel out. He places his right palm above the jewel without touching it. He bows three times to the jewel. He says, in Tibetan: "Daughter. Carry it back to the inner sanctum. Open the housing. Place it inside. Close the housing. The dawn-prayer of the forty-eighth day will be performed at five-thirty tomorrow morning. You will be present at the inner sanctum doorway. I will perform the prayer. The prayer will be your second day of administrative office."

She nods. She tucks the jewel into the inside-pocket of the ward-robe Kanchenjunga had given her at the monastery. The pocket is positioned at her left chest — over her heart. The warmth of the jewel sits against her skin through the cotton-lining.

At one-oh-eight p.m., as Pema-Chöden straightens at his left shoulder with the jewel against her chest, Kanchenjunga feels the red-panda-bond pulse through his right collarbone.

The Stage III foreleg-mark begins to form. It begins at the right collarbone — the standard position for the red-panda-line bond — and arcs down across the right pectoral. The mark is the red panda's right forepaw — clawed, semi-extended, in the climbing-down position. The pad-prints at the base of the toes are visible. The five small claws are visible. The fur-pattern at the back of the paw is rendered in the standard Chapter-Two ink-density.

The mark forms in approximately eleven seconds beneath the guardian-robe. It is not visible to the assembled refugees. Kanchenjunga feels the formation as a slow warm pressure across the pectoral — not painful, not uncomfortable, but unmistakable. He has been waiting for this sensation for fourteen years. The waiting is finally over.

He does not show the moment on his face. He continues to address the deputy chief-secretary in the standard administrative-voice, finalising the Refugee Father's exile-paperwork procedures. The deputy chief-secretary signs the exile-order at one-twelve p.m. and serves it to the Refugee Father at one-fourteen p.m. The Refugee Father accepts the document with a Pelliang-style bow. He signs the acknowledgement. He keeps the duplicate copy.

By one-thirty p.m. the Refugee Father has assembled his approximately six hundred remaining followers (the hundred who had defected upon Pema-Chöden's wheel-walk are now confirmed in their defection) at the south-camp's southern gate. The followers are packing their personal effects. The state-government ration-allocation officers have begun issuing the one-month rations from the camp-storeroom. Each follower receives approximately fifteen kilograms of grain, three kilograms of butter, a small medical-kit, and a Sikkim-state border-crossing certificate.

By four p.m. the column has begun moving. The Refugee Father leads the column. His sub-council senior delegates are immediately behind him. The mid-rank delegates and sub-council boys follow. The general followers walk in a long staggered file behind. The column stretches approximately one and a half kilometres along the foothill trail leading toward the Lachen pass.

The Lachen pass is the northeastern crossing-point between Sikkim and the Bhutan-Tibet border zone. The pass is at four thousand seven hundred metres altitude. It is open to foot-traffic in October but closes to motor-vehicles by mid-November. The crossing on foot takes approximately three days from the south-camp's exit-point.

The Refugee Father's column reaches the pass on the morning of the third day. By the eleven a.m. checkpoint at the Lachen pass entry-station, the column has been reduced to approximately five hundred and ten followers — ninety more refugees have detached over the three-day walk and begun the return-trip to the south camp. The detached followers are mostly the mid-rank delegates and the general camp-population followers. The sub-council boys remain. The senior delegates remain.

At eleven-fifteen a.m. on the third day, at the Lachen pass entry-station, the Refugee Father signs his column out of the Beyul-Kshetra. The pass-station officers stamp each follower's border-crossing certificate. The stamping takes about two hours. The Refugee Father is the first to cross. His sub-council senior delegates follow. The column then proceeds in single-file order across the pass.

By two p.m. the last of the column has crossed. The Lachen pass is closed behind them. The Beyul-Kshetra's boundary has been drawn.

Kanchenjunga has not walked to the Lachen pass himself. He has remained at the monastery to perform the forty-eighth-day dawn-prayer with the Chintamani restored to the inner sanctum at five-thirty a.m. on the second day after the boundary-speech. The prayer takes one hour. Pema-Chöden stands at the doorway of the inner sanctum throughout the prayer. She watches the senior guardian perform the prayer she has heard him perform from outside the sanctum-walls four hundred and seventy times in three months. From inside the sanctum-doorway the prayer sounds different. The Chintamani in its housing is two metres in front of her. The senior guardian is at the altar between her and the jewel.

When the prayer concludes at six-thirty a.m. Kanchenjunga turns to face her. He gestures for her to come forward. She walks the two metres to the altar.

He says: "Daughter. The Beyul-Kshetra has a co-administrator. The co-administrator's office is at the south camp's administration-building. You will work there four days a week. You will work at the monastery's ward-coordination office on the other three days. Your first task is to draft the new Compassion-Charter amendment in writing. The amendment will be ratified by the monastery's senior monks council on the seventh day. The amendment text is yours to write. I will review it before ratification. You will be paid the standard ward-coordinator salary from the state-government's monastery-affairs budget. Your barrack-accommodation will be transferred from 17-C to the monastery's south-wing guest-quarters effective today. Your younger cousin Tashi will be assigned to the

monastery's rehabilitation-school under Lobsang's supervision — the school's programme for ex-sub-council boys begins next week. He will recover. The recovery will take time. He will recover."

She bows. The bow is not Tibetan-formal. The bow is her own — the bow of a sixteen-year-old refugee girl who has just become the first refugee in the Beyul-Kshetra's nine-century history to hold institutional office.

She says: "Guardian-la. I will write the amendment. The first line will read: The Compassion-Charter remains open to all who suffer; the Charter closes to one who has violated the inner sanctum. I will consult with the senior monks council on the remaining lines."

He says: "The first line is correct. Begin."

The next ten days are an administrative re-organisation that the Beyul-Kshetra has not seen in sixty-seven years. The Compassion-Charter amendment is drafted by Pema-Chöden in a single thirty-eight-hour session at the south-camp administration-office, with Lobsang at her left and Sonam at her right and the Sikkim state-government chief-secretary's deputy at her right-second. The amendment is three pages long. The first page contains the four-clause limit. The second page contains the procedural-test for invoking the limit. The third page contains the appeals procedure.

The four-clause limit reads, in the final ratified text:

I. The Compassion-Charter is reaffirmed for all who arrive seeking refuge. II. The Charter closes only to a refugee who has knowingly violated the inner sanctum — defined as removing a sanctum-relic, deliberately deceiving the intake about identity-of-record, or organising a covert sub-council aimed at the removal of senior monks. III. The procedural-test for invoking Clause II is the senior guardian's public boundary-speech delivered in the central plaza of the affected camp with the state-government chief-secretary present and the affected refugee given the right of response. IV. The closure under Clause II is exile across the nearest international border-crossing with one month's ration-allocation. The exiled refugee's followers retain the right to choose to remain or to leave; followers who remain are reabsorbed into the camp without prejudice; followers who leave receive ration-allocation under the same terms as the exiled principal.

The amendment is ratified by the monastery's senior monks council on the seventh day after the boundary-speech. The vote is twenty-three to one. The single dissenting vote is

cast by an elderly senior monk named Tenzin-Norbu (sixty-eight, the monastery's second-most-senior after Kanchenjunga) who has held the Compassion-Charter as unamendable for forty years. His dissent is recorded; he affirms his continued loyalty to the senior guardian and accepts the amendment as the majority will. He resigns from active senior-monks-council duties two days later in protest and takes up a meditation-cave residence in the central forest — a long-anticipated retirement that the chapter's events have accelerated by approximately two years.

The amendment text is published in the south, central, and west camps' bulletin-boards on the eighth day. The text is translated into Tibetan, Hindi, Sikkimese-Bhutia, Nepali, English, and Limbu (the six camp-spoken languages) by a six-translator team that Pema-Chöden assembles from the camp-population in a single afternoon.

The text is read aloud at the south camp's central plaza on the ninth day by Pema-Chöden herself, in Tibetan, in the late afternoon, with about eight hundred returned camp-residents in attendance. The reading takes nineteen minutes. The reading is followed by a senior monk's response-prayer led by Lobsang. The prayer is the Sixth Karmapa's compassion-prayer — the same prayer the Refugee Father had led at the Compassion-Reciprocity Council's closing nine months earlier when Kanchenjunga had walked back to the monastery reassured.

The reabsorption of the seven-hundred refugees who had remained begins on the tenth day. The reabsorption is administered through individual interviews with each adult refugee, conducted by the camp's newly-appointed Re-Integration Committee — eight Compassion-Reciprocity Council senior delegates who had stayed with Kanchenjunga at the boundary-speech, plus three monastery monks, plus Pema-Chöden as chair. The interviews are not interrogations. They are conversations about the refugee's pre-arrival history, the refugee's reasons for joining or not joining the sub-council, and the refugee's current intentions. The committee's standard is forgiveness-with-record: each refugee's account is written down, the account is filed in the camp-archive, no further action is taken unless the account itself indicates a violation under Clause II.

By the end of the second month, the Beyul-Kshetra has fully reabsorbed the seven-hundred remaining refugees. The seven-hundred have re-joined the camp-population's daily life. The Compassion-Reciprocity Council has been restructured under new leadership — a senior delegate named Karma-Topgyal (forty-seven, a Tibetan-Sikkimese mixed-line refugee from the 2008 Lhasa wave, a man Kanchenjunga had personally vetted for the new

chair-position) leads the council, with two deputies drawn from the long-standing 1959-wave residents.

By the end of Chapter Two, the Beyul-Kshetra's political-and-spiritual structure has stabilised in a new configuration:

The senior guardian remains Kanchenjunga. He has earned his Stage III red-panda-foreleg mark by drawing his first boundary in nine years. The mark is visible on his right pectoral. The bond now sees a clear ladder-path toward Stage IV (the full-body red panda) by the end of Chapter Three or early Chapter Four — the bond's next test will be the Sanctuary's NE-Dominant ratification vote.

The co-administrator is Pema-Chöden. She is sixteen-and-three-months. She holds salaried administrative office in the Beyul-Kshetra's ward-coordination office four days a week and at the south-camp administration-building three days a week. She has begun studying for the Sikkim state-civil-service-junior-administrative-officer examination at Sonam's suggestion — the examination is in eighteen months. Lobsang is tutoring her in administrative-Tibetan; Sonam is tutoring her in state-administrative-Hindi; the deputy chief-secretary is tutoring her in state-government procedural protocol.

Her younger cousin Tashi has been at the monastery's rehabilitation-school for six weeks. He has begun to speak in his own voice again at week four. The Refugee Father's implanted cadence has begun to fade. The rehabilitation-school's sub-council-recovery programme — designed by Lobsang based on traditional Tibetan post-cult deprogramming methods used in the 1959 reabsorption — is the first formal programme of its kind in the Beyul-Kshetra's history. Eleven other ex-sub-council boys are enrolled with Tashi.

The Compassion-Charter is amended. The amendment is the first amendment in nine centuries. The amendment is limited. The amendment is necessary. The amendment is referenced in the cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon correspondence between Kanchenjunga and Moirangthem at Imphal as the "Pema-Chöden amendment" — the name has stuck in the kingdom's administrative lexicon by the time of the Chapter Three Sanctuary convening.

The Chintamani is back in the inner sanctum. The forty-eight-day absence is logged in the monastery's archive as the Beyul-Kshetra's only sanctum-relic absence in three hundred and forty-one years (the previous absence had been an 1683 sanctum-relocation during the great Sikkimese earthquake). The forty-eight-day record will not be celebrated. The record will be remembered.

Three weeks after the boundary-speech, a Sarus-pigeon arrives at Rumtek from Imphal. The pigeon is the one Moirangthem has been using for cross-kingdom communications throughout the chapter. The letter is from Moirangthem himself.

The letter reads:

Senior-guardian-la. The pigeon-relay has carried news of the Pema-Chöden amendment from Gangtok to Imphal in twelve days. Kamalavarna and U-Khrawkmen have read the amendment and have asked me to convey their congratulations on the first amendment in nine centuries. The NE Dominant ratification at the Sanctuary in Chapter Three will be a six-kingdom assembly. The Beyul-Kshetra's vote will be the third of six. The other five are: Kamakhya (Kamalavarna), Imphal (Moirangthem, the candidate), Shillong (U-Khrawkmen as inheritor-regent), Kohima (Dzulevira), and the still-pending Tripura. The vote will not be unanimous unless yours is given. Will you give it.

Kanchenjunga writes the reply over two days. The reply is two paragraphs long.

NE Dominant Candidate. I will give my vote at the Sanctuary. The vote will be for you. The Beyul-Kshetra has stabilised after the Refugee Father's exile but the stabilisation is not yet certain — the Lachen pass remains the kingdom's open question, and Krodha at the pass's far side remains the kingdom's pending threat. The Sanctuary's convening will mark the threshold across which the NE Federation will need to coordinate on the Krodha-question. My vote is for you because you will be the regional voice for that coordination.

Sub-paragraph: Pema-Chöden will attend the Sanctuary as my co-administrator. She is sixteen-and-five-months at the Sanctuary's scheduled date. She will not vote — the Sanctuary's vote is the senior-guardian's alone — but she will be present. Please plan accommodation at the Sanctuary's administrative-quarters for her on the same terms as the other senior-guardians' aides. She will be the Sanctuary's youngest attendee. She will also be the Sanctuary's first refugee-attendee in three hundred years.

Senior-guardian-la, — K.

He sends the letter by the same Sarus-pigeon at sunset. Moirangthem receives it at Imphal at noon the next day. He writes the one-line reply: The aide's accommodation is arranged. We will receive her with full honour. He sends the reply by the pigeon returning, at dusk.

Two days after the Imphal correspondence, a second Sarus-pigeon arrives at Rumtek. The pigeon is from Kohima. The letter is from Dzulevira.

The letter is short.

Senior-guardian-la. The Pre-Tribal Pact in the Nagaland kingdom's Kohima state-archives now sits next to your Pema-Chöden amendment in the cross-kingdom mutual-records exchange that Mhabemo has set up with your Lobsang last week. The pact says: "Let no one of us claim purity above another." The amendment says: "The Charter closes to a refugee who has violated the inner sanctum." The pact is six hundred years old and the amendment is nineteen days old and both are saying the same thing in different vocabulary. The boundary you have drawn is the kingdom's right to refuse what is inside it that wishes to dissolve it. The pact I have walked is the kingdom's right to refuse what is outside it that wishes to subdivide it. Both refusals are dharma. Both refusals are also Stage III. I look forward to meeting Pema-Chöden at the Sanctuary. The Naga state-government will send her a Khonoma-clay tea-bowl as the Beyul-Kshetra's welcome-gift on the morning of the Sanctuary's opening.

Sister-in-Boundary, — D.

Kanchenjunga reads the letter twice. He shows it to Pema-Chöden at the south-camp administration-office at four p.m. on the day it arrives. She reads it three times. She does not say anything for nine minutes.

She finally says: "Guardian-la. Two of the Northeast's heroes have already written to me by name. I am sixteen-and-three-months. I do not know how to receive that yet."

He says: "Daughter. You will not know how to receive it for another year. The receiving is itself learned. You will learn it at the Sanctuary. Until then, draft the welcome-reply to Dzulevira. The reply is yours to write. I will only sign it."

She drafts the reply over the next hour. The reply is one paragraph long.

State Hero of Nagaland. The Beyul-Kshetra receives the Khonoma-clay welcome-gift with the gratitude due a six-century-old pact. The Pema-Chöden amendment is nineteen days old, and the writer of these words is sixteen-and-three-months old, but the kingdom's administrative record now contains both, and the cross-kingdom mutual-records exchange that your Mhabemo and our Lobsang have established will preserve them both for whatever future archive needs them. I look forward to meeting you at the Sanctuary. I will bring with me the small wooden housing the Chintamani has rested in for sixty-seven years — the housing is empty now, the jewel is restored to its altar-cavity — and I will bring the housing to the Sanctuary's opening as the Beyul-Kshetra's contribution to the regional

mutual-records exhibit. The housing has been opened more times in the past forty-eight days than it has been opened in the previous nine centuries. The housing has earned its display.

Co-administrator, Beyul-Kshetra, — P.

Kanchenjunga signs the reply under her signature. The signature is his standard senior-guardian seal in Tibetan script. He sends the letter by the same Sarus-pigeon at sunset. The pigeon arrives at Kohima at noon the following day.

Six weeks after the boundary-speech. The first week of December. The western face of Khangchendzonga — the third-highest mountain in the world, the Beyul-Kshetra's deity-peak, the kingdom's sacred wall.

A Khangchendzonga National Park ranger named Tashi-Bhutia (no relation to Pema-Chöden's cousin Tashi — the name is a common Bhutia given-name; the ranger is forty-three, an eleven-year park-service veteran, the senior ranger of the western-face patrol-station) is conducting the standard December high-altitude wildlife-census on the morning of the second of December. He is at the western-face base camp at four thousand five hundred metres. He has a high-power binocular and a Park Service satellite-telemetry receiver. He is scanning the western face for the December baseline-count of high-altitude mammals — snow leopards (expected count: 3-4 in the western-face range), Tibetan blue sheep (40-60), Himalayan tahr (15-25), and the occasional opportunistic red panda (0-2, normally in the lower-elevation rhododendron belt).

At seven-forty-three a.m. he sees the red panda on the snowline edge at approximately five thousand four hundred metres altitude. The panda is on the western face. The panda is grazing on a small patch of rhododendron shrub that has somehow survived above the rhododendron belt's normal altitude limit of four thousand eight hundred metres — the shrub itself is anomalous; he logs the anomaly in his field-book as a secondary observation.

The panda is the primary observation. Red pandas live at two thousand two hundred to four thousand eight hundred metres altitude. Above five thousand metres the atmospheric oxygen-content (approximately fifty percent of sea-level oxygen at five thousand four hundred metres) is physiologically lethal to the species. Red pandas have not been documented above five thousand metres in the species' recorded biological history. The biological reason is straightforward: red panda haemoglobin lacks the high-altitude oxygen-affinity mutation that yak haemoglobin and Tibetan-antelope haemoglobin have

evolved over the past five million years. A red panda at five thousand four hundred metres should be dead within thirty minutes from acute mountain-sickness combined with cold-stress.

The panda Tashi-Bhutia is observing is not dead. The panda is grazing. The panda's breathing rate is, through the binocular, observable: approximately fourteen breaths per minute, which is the normal red-panda resting rate. The panda is not in distress. The panda is, simply, at five thousand four hundred metres, on a Khangchendzonga rhododendron-patch, eating.

Tashi-Bhutia calls in the observation by satellite-radio to the Park Service's Gangtok central-office at eight a.m. The Gangtok central-office routes the call to the Sikkim state-government wildlife-affairs department by eight-thirty a.m. The wildlife-affairs department routes the call to the Rumtek Monastery's ward-coordination office at nine-fifteen a.m. (the monastery has been the standing recipient of all anomalous-wildlife observations on Khangchendzonga since 1967, by an inter-departmental memorandum-of-understanding the chief-secretary's office had set up after a similar anomalous observation in the 1962 Karmapa-lineage re-ratification year).

Pema-Chöden takes the call at the ward-coordination office at nine-sixteen a.m. She writes down the observation in her co-administrator log-book. She walks the observation across the monastery courtyard to the inner sanctum at nine-twenty a.m. She does not enter the sanctum; she stands at the doorway and waits for Kanchenjunga to finish his morning-prayer.

He finishes at nine-thirty-six a.m. He turns. He sees her at the doorway.

She says, in the standard report-voice that she has been using for two months now: "Guardian-la. The Khangchendzonga western-face patrol-station has logged a red panda at five thousand four hundred metres altitude. The panda is alive. The panda is grazing. The panda is not in distress."

Kanchenjunga sits down on the stone bench against the east wall.

The red-panda-foreleg mark on his right pectoral pulses. The pulse is not pain. The pulse is recognition.

He says: "Daughter. The Maw has begun to test the bond. The Maw is moving a red panda to an altitude that should kill it, to see whether the bond-ladder protects the animal at

altitudes the species itself cannot survive. If the panda lives, the Maw will know the bond is stronger than the species. The Maw will then begin moving other bonded animals to other lethal-to-the-species conditions — the Sangai deer at the Loktak Lake's saline-flood zone, the Mithun bull at the Kanha barasingha-meadow oxygen-saturation, the clouded-leopard at the Cherrapunji rainfall-anti-zone. The next sign is the Maw reading the saga's bond-architecture by direct experiment on the bonded species. The next sign is the Maw learning what we can do."

She says: "What do we do."

He says: "The standard. The Karmapa-rule. We name the panda. We log the altitude. We build a small shrine at the western-face base camp at four thousand five hundred metres — the closest a guardian can walk. We do not climb to five thousand four hundred metres to verify or interfere. The panda is the Maw's offered sign and our task is to receive it without converting it into a confrontation. The shrine will be a small stacked-stone marker with a single red-panda-paw-print carved on the eastern face. We will name the marker the Khangchendzonga Boundary Shrine. We will commission the shrine through the Park Service this week. Tashi-Bhutia the ranger will be the shrine-keeper. He will check on the panda's grazing-spot once a week through the binocular from the four-thousand-five-hundred-metre base camp. He will not climb higher. We will not climb higher. We will read the sign at the altitude it was given."

She nods. She writes the procedure in the co-administrator log-book at nine-forty-two a.m.

She says: "Guardian-la. If the Maw is reading our bond-architecture by experiment, the next experiments will not be limited to the Northeast. They will spread. The Karnataka bond, the Goan gaur, the Maharashtra giant-squirrel, the UP barasingha, the MP barasingha-herd, the Assam rhinoceros, the Meghalaya clouded-leopard, the Manipur sangai, the Naga mithun — all of them are vulnerable. We need to inform the other kingdoms."

He says: "Yes. Draft the cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon-cascade alert. Send it to all nine bonded-kingdom senior guardians. The text should be short. Eight or nine lines maximum. Begin: The Maw has begun to test the bond by experiment. The first experiment is a red panda at five thousand four hundred metres on Khangchendzonga. The animal is alive. The bond is holding. Watch your own bonded species at conditions that should kill them. Build shrines at the threshold. Do not climb past it."

She drafts the cascade-alert in fifteen minutes. The alert is sent by Sarus-pigeon to all nine bonded-kingdom senior guardians by sunset of the same day. By the morning of the third day after the Khangchendzonga panda observation, every senior guardian in the saga has read the alert.

The Beyul-Kshetra's closing image of Chapter Two is a sixteen-year-old refugee girl writing a cross-kingdom alert in administrative Tibetan at a co-administrator's desk while a forty-one-year-old senior guardian watches a small red-panda mark fade and re-pulse on his right pectoral beneath the dark-red guardian-robe, the Chintamani burning steady in its housing in the inner sanctum forty-six metres away, and somewhere on the Lachen pass's far side a man named Krodha walking the Bhutan-Tibet trail toward a transformation he has not yet recognised but the Maw has already prepared for him.

The Hidden Land has drawn its first boundary in nine centuries. The boundary has held.

The next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A red panda at five thousand four hundred metres on a rhododendron-patch that should not exist, grazing as if the altitude were ordinary. A sixteen-year-old refugee girl at a co-administrator's desk writing the cross-kingdom alert in administrative Tibetan. A small wooden housing in an inner sanctum that has been opened more times in forty-eight days than in nine centuries previous. A senior guardian's right pectoral marked with the first foreleg of the red-panda Stage III, the ink-dense paw set against weathered skin. A six-hundred-year-old clay tablet at Kohima sitting in a mutual-records exchange beside a nineteen-day-old amendment from Gangtok. A column of six hundred followers crossing the Lachen pass at noon on the third day with a forty-one-year-old man named Krodha leading them. A small stone shrine at four thousand five hundred metres on Khangchendzonga's western face with a single red-panda-paw-print carved on its eastern face, a Park Service ranger named Tashi-Bhutia checking the panda's grazing-spot through a binocular once a week, never climbing higher.

Dzukou Rashtra

Kohima. The first week of November. The Nagaland State Government's Hornbill Festival Steering Committee room. Sixteen chairs around an oval table. Each chair has a different tribal council name-plate.

Dzulevira is at the head. She is thirty-three. She is in a forest-green Tangkhul shawl over a plain black shirt and trousers. Her hair is cropped short. She has been the state hero of Nagaland for two years, elected by the most narrowly distributed vote in the state's post-1972 history — she carried at least 4 percent of every tribe's vote and no tribe's majority. Her election was a referendum on cross-tribal politics. Her two-year reign has been a steady, slow loosening of the inter-tribal tensions that had been building since 2019.

In the last ninety days, the loosening has reversed.

The Hornbill Festival is to open in eight days. The festival has been held every December since 2000. It is Nagaland's flagship cultural event — all sixteen tribes performing on rotating stages, an international tourism audience, two hundred crore in annual economic impact.

This morning the chairperson of the Angami council has formally withdrawn the Angami tribe from the festival. By noon the chair of the Ao council has done the same. By two p.m. the Konyak. By three the Sumi. By four the Lotha and the Sangtam. By five-thirty p.m. all sixteen tribes have withdrawn. Each cites "ancestral purity-disputes with the other fifteen" as the reason.

The festival has not been cancelled in twenty-five years. It is cancelled in five and a half hours.

Dzulevira sits in the empty committee room until seven p.m. Her chief secretary, a Lotha woman named Mhabemo, eventually puts a cup of black tea in front of her.

Mhabemo says: "The Pure-Tongue has visited all sixteen now. Last village was Yimchunger, six days ago. Every tribe has its DNA-rite kit. Every tribe has been told it is the original."

Dzulevira says: "I knew sixteen days ago. I should have moved then."

"You did not move because you did not know what to move toward. None of us knew."

"I should have known."

Mhabemo does not argue with this. She has worked for Dzulevira for two years; she has learned that her hero accepts blame more efficiently when nobody contests it.

It is documented later, after the walk, in a Nagaland State Archives report. Naga-Rakshasa — the Chapter One villain, returned from two years in the Patkai Hills border-zone — spent autumn 2026 visiting sixty-three Naga villages across six months. He arrived at each village speaking the village's tribal dialect. The dialects of the sixteen Naga tribes diverged across centuries of mutual separation; most are mutually unintelligible; no living Naga has ever been documented as fluent in more than four. Naga-Rakshasa speaks all sixteen fluently.

He arrived at each village as one of their own. He bowed in the tribe's style. He sat at the tribe's correct elder-position when invited. He ate the tribe's ceremonial foods. He told the tribe's elders that he had been studying their tribe's ancestral records and had a gift to give them.

The gift was a small white box. The box held a saliva-collection swab, a return-envelope, and a one-page report from a Chiang Mai laboratory called Pure-Origin Genomics. The report named the village elder by his exact Tangkhul-Naga or Ao-Naga or Konyak-Naga or sixteenth-name and certified, with QR-code and seventeen-page genomic appendix, that the elder's DNA matched the "original Naga ancestor strain" at 99.7 percent or higher — the highest match in the global Naga-origin database.

Every village's elder, in every tribe, received the same 99.7-percent-match report. The reports were forged. The Chiang Mai lab was forged. The Pure-Origin Genomics website was forged. The genomic appendices were forged. Naga-Rakshasa had been preparing the forgery operation for two years at a Mumbai-Mizoram facility funded by the same Singapore line that had funded Megha-Daitya's submachine guns and Tamasa-Nrita's daos.

Each village believed. Each tribe demanded that all the others surrender their false claims. Each tribe began purity-testing its own members — particularly those married out to other tribes or to non-Naga partners.

Week two of the chapter. Ukhrul. The senior Tangkhul-Naga clan-house of Dzulevira's mother's family. Ka-Memcha has flown in from Imphal. She has come because Dzulevira's twenty-three-day-old appeal for help has finally reached her threshold. She has left

Sangaputra in Moirangthem's care — the boy is back at the Govindaji temple, in the new pause-school's third class, learning at the front-left corner of the formation. He is safe.

She is at the Ukhrul family-house for nine days before the Tangkhul Tribal Council's Senior Priest sub-committee summons her.

The summons is a single-page Tangkhul-language letter on the Tribal Council's official letterhead. It reads (translated): Ka-Memcha-the-Eldest is summoned to the Tangkhul Tribal Ceremony Grounds on the morning of the fourteenth day of the month to submit to the Pure-Origin Genomic Verification rite. The verification is required for all Tangkhul-born members residing outside the tribe's territorial boundary for more than five consecutive years. The applicant's minor son, residing in Imphal, is named in the same summons. The Senior Priest Khrumai-Sho will officiate. Failure to appear or refusal to submit will be considered ceremonial-sacrilege under Tangkhul customary law as preserved under the Sixth Schedule, sub-clause (4)(b).

Ka-Memcha reads the letter twice. She walks the two and a half kilometres from the family-house to Dzulevira's state-residence in central Ukhrul. (Dzulevira had relocated her state-office to Ukhrul for the duration of the purity-wars; she was meeting with the Tangkhul elders three times a week.) Ka-Memcha shows her sister the letter at four-thirty p.m.

Dzulevira reads it. She says: "Refuse. I will issue a state-government counter-notice tomorrow morning. Khrumai-Sho will withdraw the summons by tomorrow evening."

Ka-Memcha says: "If I refuse without showing, the tribe says I have hidden myself. If I refuse at the ceremony-grounds in front of the tribe, the tribe sees the refusal and remembers it. I will go. I will refuse publicly. The refusal is the dharma. The state-government counter-notice is a different thing — you should still issue it, but I should still go."

Dzulevira looks at her older sister for a long time. They have not lived in the same house since Ka-Memcha was twenty-two. They have not always agreed; they have always understood. Dzulevira understands now.

She says: "I will be at the ceremony-grounds with you."

"No. Your presence will make the refusal political. My refusal must be personal. The dharma must come from the one being tested. Send the state-police detail to the grounds.

Have them stay at the perimeter. They will be there. You will not be."

"If something happens — "

"If something happens you will need to walk the kingdom afterward. You will not be able to walk if you are standing next to me. Stay at the office. Send the police. I will see you at lunch. The ceremony is at first light."

Dzulevira does not argue. She also does not believe Ka-Memcha is about to die. The Tangkhul Senior Priest sub-committee has never killed a refusing-applicant in two centuries of recorded ceremony.

The Tangkhul Senior Priest sub-committee, as Dzulevira finds out at lunch the next day, has never previously been confronted with a refusing-applicant from a tribal-elder line who is the elder sister of the state hero.

Six a.m. The Tangkhul Tribal Ceremony Grounds at Ukhul. A circular stone-paved platform at the eastern edge of the village. A ceremonial fire in the centre — a stone pit one and a half metres across, the fire built that morning by Khrumai-Sho's apprentices, mahua-wood and pine-resin, burning at a height of just over a metre.

Khrumai-Sho is the Senior Priest of the Tangkhul Tribal Council. He is fifty-three. He has held the position for nine years. He has officiated three hundred and forty-one purity-rites in his career. He has never had a refusal until today.

Ka-Memcha arrives at five-fifty-five a.m. She walks alone from the family-house. She wears the formal Tangkhul shawl her mother gave her at her thirteenth-year naming-rite. She has on her wrist the Meitei wedding bangle Moirangthem gave her at their marriage. The two pieces of cloth-and-metal are her chosen statement.

The Tangkhul elders are assembled around the ceremony-grounds — about forty of them, all senior tribal-council members. The state-police detail of six officers is at the perimeter, twenty metres back, in plain clothes. Mhabemo is among them, holding a satellite phone.

Khrumai-Sho asks the formal opening question in Tangkhul: "Ka-Memcha-the-Eldest, do you submit to the Pure-Origin Genomic Verification rite as required by Tangkhul customary law?"

She answers in Tangkhul, clearly, at full ceremony-voice: "I do not."

The forty elders make the soft sound of formal recognition.

Khrumai-Sho asks the formal second question: "On what dharmic ground do you refuse?"

She answers, switching to a mixed Tangkhul-Meitei register that the elders recognise as deliberate: "I am Tangkhul. I am also Meitei. Both. My son is both. Neither is impure. The Pure-Origin rite assumes a single ancestry. I do not have a single ancestry. The rite cannot test what I am because what I am is two things at once. I refuse the rite because the rite cannot ask the right question."

There is a long silence. The forty elders are processing the answer. The answer is, by Tangkhul customary law's pre-modern principles, dharmically articulate. The customary law as preserved under the Sixth Schedule has assumed since 1972 that tribal members have a single tribal identity — the assumption was never tested before today because nobody before today was both a state-hero's elder sister and a Manipur-married woman of the senior Tangkhul line.

Khrumai-Sho is not processing the answer. He had not prepared for it. He had expected refusal-by-silence, by walking-away, by political-bluster. He had not expected refusal-by-dharmic-articulation in the ceremony-Tangkhul register.

He says, in the formal closing-position voice: "Your refusal is sacrilege."

Ka-Memcha says, in the same register: "My refusal is dharma. Your declaration of sacrilege is your error."

Khrumai-Sho gestures to two of his senior apprentices. The apprentices step toward Ka-Memcha. She does not move.

The state-police detail at the perimeter sees the gesture. Mhabemo presses the satellite phone's call-button. Dzulevira, in the state-office two kilometres away, receives the alert at six-eleven a.m.

The apprentices reach Ka-Memcha at six-twelve a.m. They take her arms. Khrumai-Sho says: "The applicant has refused the rite. The applicant has declared the rite invalid. The applicant must submit by the purification-of-the-refusal sub-rite. The sub-rite is fire-purification."

Ka-Memcha understands the sub-rite. It is a Tangkhul tradition for the most serious dharmic refusals — one that has not been invoked in eighty-seven years. The applicant is required to walk three times around the fire-pit while reciting the seven affirmations. The applicant is not pushed into the fire. The applicant is required to walk around it.

She says, in the formal Tangkhul: "I will walk."

She begins to walk. She circles the fire-pit once. The forty elders watch.

At six-fifteen a.m., during the second circumambulation, Khrumai-Sho steps off the priest's platform and moves toward the fire-pit edge. His apprentices stand to either side of him. The state-police detail at the perimeter has begun to move forward but is still fifteen metres away.

At six-sixteen a.m., as Ka-Memcha passes the fire-pit's eastern edge for the second time, Khrumai-Sho pushes her into the fire.

The push is not concealed. The forty elders see it. The state-police detail sees it. The two apprentices see it. Khrumai-Sho does not attempt to disguise the push as accident. He pushes her with both hands at her shoulder-blades. The push is hard and unambiguous.

She falls into the fire-pit. The fire is at over a metre's height. Mahua-wood and pine-resin burn at temperatures above seven hundred degrees Celsius.

She is dead in fifty-three seconds. She does not scream — the smoke gets her airway before her body registers the burn. The forty elders see the silence as the dharmic completion of her refusal. She had said the rite could not ask the right question. She made her answer with her silence.

The state-police detail arrives at the fire-pit at six-seventeen a.m. They put out the fire with water-bottles from their vehicle. They recover her body. They arrest Khrumai-Sho at six-twenty-one a.m. He does not resist. He says, at the arrest: "I have done my dharma."

Mhabemo's satellite phone records the line.

She is informed at six-twenty-three a.m. at the state-office. She does not speak for two days.

Mhabemo manages her schedule. The state-government issues the cremation order. The Tangkhul tribal council is suspended pending a state-government review of Khrumai-Sho's arrest. Khrumai-Sho is held at the Ukhul district jail; his case is referred to the Nagaland High Court under criminal jurisdiction; the Sixth Schedule customary-law exemption claim is filed by his lawyer within eleven hours and rejected by the state-government attorney within twenty-eight.

Ka-Memcha's cremation is held the next afternoon. The cremation is performed by Dzulevira herself, alone — no Tangkhul priest, no Meitei priest, no state-ceremony. She uses a combined Tangkhul-Meitei rite that she has researched in Khrieo-Mama's manuscript-library overnight. The ashes are collected into a Meitei brass urn and a Tangkhul clay pot in equal measure — Dzulevira's choice, mirroring her sister's last public statement.

She sends the Meitei urn to Moirangthem at Imphal by special courier the same evening. She keeps the Tangkhul clay pot at the Ukhrul family-house.

Moirangthem receives the urn at midnight. He has known of Ka-Memcha's death since six-thirty a.m. the previous morning — Dzulevira had sent a Sarus-pigeon within twenty minutes of being informed. He has not told Sangaputra yet. He tells the boy at six a.m. the next morning, at the temple courtyard, in the small east room, alone.

Sangaputra goes silent for three days. The pause-school's third class has him at the front-left corner of the formation for all three days. He does not perform sequences. He performs the pause. The pause holds for the full class-period — forty-five minutes — on the third day. Moirangthem watches without intervening.

Week four of the chapter. The night of day fifteen since Ka-Memcha's death. Eleven-fifty p.m.

Dzulevira is at the state-office. She has finally begun working again — or at any rate the work-papers are in front of her and her pen is in her hand and she is moving the pen.

Mhabemo knocks at the office-door. She says: "There is an old woman at the front-desk. She has walked from Khonoma. She wants to see you. She is carrying something heavy in a shawl-wrap. She says you will know her name when I say it."

"Her name?"

"Khrieo-Mama."

Dzulevira sets the pen down. She has heard the name three times in her adult life — once at her election when an old Khonoma elder voted for her at the Angami booth and was identified in the next morning's newspaper as a relative of Khrieo-Mama, once at her swearing-in when Khrieo-Mama sent a single-line congratulatory letter ("The mithun walks. The mithun knows."), and once in graduate-school linguistics class when Khrieo-

Mama was named as one of the seven Naga elders who knew the pre-modern Angami ceremonial vocabulary.

She has not met Khrieo-Mama in person.

She says: "Bring her in. Bring her tea. Whatever she is carrying, carry it for her."

Mhabemo brings her in. Khrieo-Mama is eighty-nine. She is shorter than her grand-niece-by-line had expected. She is wearing the deep-indigo Angami matriarch's wrap with the seven brass arm-rings (the elder-mark of the senior Khonoma line). Her hair is white and bound at the nape with a single black thread.

She sits on the chair across from Dzulevira's desk. She accepts the tea. She unwraps the shawl-bundle on her lap.

Inside the shawl is a clay tablet. The tablet is approximately thirty centimetres by twenty centimetres, two centimetres thick, fired-clay, with sixteen lines of pre-modern script across its surface and sixteen small thumb-prints in dark-clay at the bottom — the signatures.

Khrieo-Mama says: "Dzulevira. Listen carefully. This tablet has been under the floor of my house since 1985. It was under the floor of my grandmother's house from 1923 to 1985. It was under the floor of her grandmother's house from 1882 to 1923. It was in the open at Kohima from 1425 to 1882. It is the Pre-Tribal Pact. The script is the sixteen pre-modern Naga dialects, one line per tribe. The thumb-prints are the original founders' signatures. I have not read it aloud to anyone in forty-one years. I am going to read it aloud to you now in Angami. Then I am going to write down translations in all sixteen modern dialects and in Hindi by morning. Drink your tea while I read."

She reads. The reading takes nine minutes. Dzulevira does not drink her tea.

The Pact is fifty-three words in Angami. Translated to English the Pact reads: Before the sixteen, there was one. Before the names, there was the mithun. The names are our work. The mithun is our root. Let no one of us claim purity above another. Let the mithun walk between us when the sixteen fight. The one who walks beside the mithun without a tribe is the one who holds the kingdom.

The signatures are at the bottom — sixteen thumb-prints, each in the dark-clay of the founder's home valley. The clay-types are scientifically distinguishable: Pochury clay is iron-rich red; Konyak clay is granite-grey; Tangkhul clay is the brown of the Manipur-

border alluvium. A trained eye can read the signatures' provenance without consulting any other document.

Dzulevira looks at the Tangkhul thumb-print at line fourteen. The print is the same approximate size as her sister's thumb. It is not her sister's thumb — the print is six centuries old — but it is the thumb of a Tangkhul woman who signed her name to a Pact saying her tribe should not claim purity above any other tribe.

She says, finally: "What do I do."

Khrieo-Mama says: "You walk the mithun. Through all sixteen valleys. As all the tribes. As none of the tribes. You walk naked except for ash. You answer in no tribal dialect. You read the Pact aloud in each tribe's dialect — I will give you the translations by morning. You show them what the Pure-Tongue cannot do."

"How do I answer if I cannot speak any tribal dialect?"

"You answer in Hindi. The language none of the sixteen tribes claim. The language that is the kingdom's union, not its origin. The Pure-Tongue speaks all sixteen dialects. Hindi is the one language he cannot weaponise against you, because Hindi belongs to none of the tribes whose purity-claim he is selling. Answer in Hindi and the manipulation collapses on itself."

Dzulevira considers this for a long moment.

She says: "When do I start?"

"In five days. The mithun needs four days to be selected and prepared. The translations need three nights to be written. Your body needs the rest. Start on day six."

Day three of the five preparation-days. The Dzukou Valley grass-fields. The traditional mithun-pasture of the Nagaland state herd.

There are forty-seven mithun in the Dzukou herd. The mithun is the Nagaland state animal — the same animal as Onge-Nakshatra's saltwater-crocodile-equivalent in Sagara-Ratna in the sense that it is one of the saga's rare mainland-bonded-with-an-island-cousin animals — but Naga mithun are the cattle-form, larger than gaur, more domesticated, the central ritual animal of every Naga tribe's sacrifice and feast tradition.

Dzulevira walks among the herd at dawn. She has known some of these animals since she was seven. She has not walked the herd as a bond-recognition exercise in nine years.

The alpha bull — the largest of the herd, fifteen years old, two and a half metres at the shoulder, weight approximately one thousand kilograms — walks to meet her at the herd's eastern edge. She stops three metres from him. He stops three metres from her.

She says, in Hindi (per Khrieo-Mama's instruction): "I am going to walk the kingdom with you. Sixteen valleys. Twenty-seven days. You will go where I go. We will read the Pact at every village. I will answer the Pure-Tongue in the language none of the tribes claim. Are you willing."

The mithun looks at her. He breathes. He shifts his weight to his right foreleg.

She takes the weight-shift as the answer it is. She walks to him. She places her right palm on his forehead between his eyes. He lowers his head.

She says: "Tomorrow night we begin."

Five days after Khrieo-Mama's midnight visit. Pre-dawn. The Tangkhul Tribal Ceremony Grounds at Ukhrol — the same grounds where Ka-Memcha died. The valley one of the sixteen.

Dzulevira walks to the grounds at four-thirty a.m. She is naked. She is covered in ash from a mithun-fire prepared by Khrieo-Mama and a Khonoma priestess the night before. The ash is grey-white. It coats her skin from forehead to feet. She carries nothing except a small cloth-bundle — Khrieo-Mama's sixteen-language translation of the Pact, wrapped in coarse jute.

The mithun walks beside her. He is unled — no rope, no halter. He walks at her left shoulder, two paces back, at her exact pace.

The Tangkhul ceremony-grounds are empty at four-thirty a.m. The forty elders are not there. The ground's stone-paved platform has been cleaned of fire-ash by the state-police; the ceremony-fire pit has been filled with sand. The new dawn is still half an hour away.

Dzulevira stands at the platform's eastern edge. She unwraps the jute-bundle. She finds the Tangkhul translation page. She reads the Pact aloud at full ceremony-voice in Tangkhul.

The reading takes four minutes. The Tangkhul translation is fifty-eight words. The fire-pit hears it — the fire-pit is part of the listening, even with sand in it. The state-police perimeter detail (Mhabemo at the centre, holding the satellite phone) hears it. The Tangkhul tribal council's deputy chairperson hears it — he had come at four to watch from a distance.

When she finishes she folds the Tangkhul page. She turns east. She begins walking. The mithun walks beside her.

By six a.m. they are two and a half kilometres east of Ukhrul, on the trail toward the Khamniungan valley — the second tribe's territory by Khrieo-Mama's walk-order.

The walk is twenty-seven days. Sixteen valleys. Some valleys are one day's walk from the previous; some are three. The mithun walks the whole distance unled. Dzulevira walks the whole distance ash-covered and naked. The state-police detail follows at fifty metres distance with a single jeep carrying water, the jute-bundle of translations, Khrieo-Mama (in the support-jeep for valleys four through sixteen; she walked the first three before her knees gave out), and a small Tangkhul woman named Phinika who has been assigned as the ash-renewal-attendant.

At each valley's village-edge Dzulevira stops. The mithun stops. She unwraps the jute-bundle and finds the correct dialect page. She reads the Pact aloud in that tribe's dialect at full ceremony-voice. The reading takes between three and seven minutes depending on the dialect's syntactic compression.

Then she walks into the village. She does not speak. She walks the length of the village's main path with the mithun beside her. At the village's far edge she turns and walks back. She stands at the eastern edge again. She rewraps the bundle. She continues east to the next valley.

At each village the reception varies.

At the Khamniungan valley (second), the village elders bow to her as she walks the main path. None of them speaks to her. The mithun urinates on the village-square statue of the founding elder — an act the senior priest interprets as a ritual blessing.

At the Konyak valley (third), three young men try to capture the mithun at the village's far edge. The mithun lowers his head and charges. They scatter. He returns to Dzulevira's side without further incident.

At the Ao valley (fourth), the village throws stones. Two stones strike Dzulevira — one on the right shoulder, one on the left thigh. The mithun does not respond. Dzulevira does not respond. She finishes the village-traversal with blood running down her thigh; the ash absorbs the blood without showing colour.

At the Sumi valley (fifth), the village comes out to welcome her. Three hundred Sumi villagers line the main path. They have heard about the previous valleys. They place mithun-foot-mark drawings in chalk on the ground in front of her walk-path. She walks over the chalk-drawings. The mithun follows.

At the Chakhesang valley (sixth), the Pure-Tongue is rumoured to be present in the village. He is not. He has left two days earlier — word of the walk has reached him faster than he expected. Dzulevira walks the village without confrontation.

At the Lotha valley (seventh), the senior priest comes out to read his own counter-statement at the village-edge. He reads it in Lotha. Dzulevira waits while he reads. When he finishes she reads the Pact in Lotha. The senior priest goes back into his house without responding to her reading. She walks the village.

At the Phom valley (eighth), the mithun stops in the middle of the village-square and refuses to move for forty-three minutes. Dzulevira stands beside him. The village watches. The mithun starts moving again at the forty-fourth minute. No explanation is offered or required. The forty-three-minute pause is later named in Phom oral tradition as "the second pause-school lesson" — a reference to her brother-in-law Moirangthem's newly-named Manipuri dance-school. The cross-reference is intentional on the part of the Phom oral-tradition keepers.

At the Chang valley (ninth), the village offers her clothes. She refuses. The village offers her food. She refuses. The mithun accepts a single handful of grain from the village headwoman. The accepting is itself the statement.

At the Yimchunger valley (tenth), the Pure-Tongue has been rumoured to be returning. He is not seen. The walk continues.

At the Rengma valley (eleventh), Khrieo-Mama's knees finally give out. She rides in the support-jeep for the remaining six valleys. The translations are now memorised — Dzulevira does not need the jute-bundle for the last five readings.

At the Sangtam valley (twelfth), a small girl — six years old — runs out and touches the mithun's right foreleg. She is not stopped by the elders. The mithun does not flinch. The girl says, in Sangtam: "Aunt-without-a-tribe." The phrase enters Sangtam oral tradition that evening.

At the Zeliang valley (thirteenth), the village holds a brief impromptu ceremony — not a purity-rite, but a recognition-rite for the walker. Dzulevira is not asked to participate. She is present at the ceremony's edge. The mithun is the central honoured presence.

At the Kuki valley (fourteenth, the small Kuki-Naga subgroup recognised under the Naga umbrella), the walk passes without remark. The Kuki elders had publicly endorsed Dzulevira's walk on day six.

At the Angami valley (fifteenth — her route circles back westward), the welcome is extensive. The Khonoma village is part of the Angami territory; Khrieo-Mama's own household is at Khonoma; the family-network has prepared the village for two days. Dzulevira walks the main path. The mithun walks behind her. The Angami council's chairperson formally reaffirms the Hornbill Festival's revival at her passage.

At the Pochury valley (sixteenth and last), the Pure-Tongue appears.

Day twenty-six of the walk. Late afternoon. The Pochury village-edge. The southern Naga hills, at the Burmese border zone.

Dzulevira has walked the Pochury approach trail for the past three hours. The trail is hilly and the heat is significant — even at late afternoon the southern Naga hills are at twenty-eight degrees and humid. The ash on her body has begun to streak at the chest and the shins; Phinika will renew it before the village-edge reading.

The Pochury villagers are arrayed at the village-edge to receive her. There are about four hundred — the entire village. Some have come from neighbouring villages because the walk has become news.

A man stands in front of the four hundred. He is forty-six. He is in plain Pochury cotton — loose trousers, sleeveless shirt, a single Pochury elder-thread tied at his left wrist. His face is the face of a Pochury elder. The Pochury villagers do not recognise him as Pochury, but they recognise him as one of their own. They are not yet sure why he is standing in front.

He is Naga-Rakshasa.

He speaks. He speaks Pochury — the rare southern-Naga dialect that perhaps three thousand people in the world speak fluently. He speaks it with the pre-modern Pochury intonation that elder-academic Pochury linguists have not heard outside seventeenth-century recordings.

He says: "Walker. The Pact you have been reading is a fabrication. The Khonoma matriarch's family-document was written in 1923 to consolidate Angami supremacy — her grandmother forged the signatures. The tribes were always sixteen. The original Naga was the Pochury — the southernmost, the oldest, the purest. The other fifteen are derivative. The DNA-test I gave you Pochury elders proves it. The 99.7-percent ancestral match is your tribe's alone. The walker's Hindi-answers are the words of a state hero who has lost her tribal anchor. Listen to your Pochury elders. Listen to me."

He bows in the Pochury elder-style. The bow is technically perfect.

The four hundred Pochury villagers waver. The Pochury senior priest at the front-left of the welcome-line looks at Naga-Rakshasa, looks at the Pochury translation of the Pact in his own hand (Khrieo-Mama had sent the translation ahead by courier), looks at Dzulevira ash-covered and bleeding-streaked.

Dzulevira walks forward. She walks past Naga-Rakshasa. She stops three metres in front of the Pochury senior priest. The mithun stops one metre behind her.

She speaks. She speaks in Hindi:

"I am Dzulevira. I was born Tangkhul. My elder sister was Tangkhul-married-to-Meitei and was killed by a Tangkhul priest for refusing the purity-rite. My senior advisor is Angami. The pact I read is six hundred years old and signed by sixteen thumb-prints whose clay-provenance can be tested by any geology laboratory in the world. I am here as no tribe. I am here as the kingdom. The mithun is the only ancestor we share. The Pure-Tongue speaks sixteen dialects because he is the cancer that divides us — he speaks every language a tribe owns and no language the kingdom owns. I refuse to choose a tribe. I refuse for the kingdom. Hindi belongs to no tribe and to all of us. Hindi is what I have left to speak with. I am speaking with it."

The Hindi is plain, ordinary, state-government-meeting Hindi. The Hindi is not poetic. The Hindi is not ceremony-language. The Hindi is the language two Naga villagers use when they pass each other on a Kohima street and need to ask for directions and they are from different tribes.

The four hundred Pochury villagers hear it. The Pochury senior priest hears it. Naga-Rakshasa hears it.

Naga-Rakshasa attempts to respond. He tries to speak in Tangkhul — to attack her tribal anchor through her birth-tribe. Dzulevira answers in Hindi. He tries to switch to Angami — to attack Khrieo-Mama's authority through the Angami senior matriarch's dialect. Dzulevira answers in Hindi. He tries Ao, Sumi, Lotha — in succession, in increasingly desperate combinations. Dzulevira answers in Hindi.

The four hundred Pochury villagers watch. They see what is happening. Naga-Rakshasa cannot weaponise any of the sixteen dialects against a target who refuses to claim one. The Pure-Tongue is, in this hour, a man speaking many languages to a woman who is speaking the language of governance.

He retreats. He does not bow. He walks east toward the Burmese border. The Pochury villagers do not stop him. By nightfall he has crossed into the Chin-state border zone — the same border-zone Tamasa-Nrita crossed three weeks earlier from the Manipur side.

At the moment Naga-Rakshasa turns east, Dzulevira feels the mithun-bond pulse through her chest. The Stage III foreleg-mark completes — the mithun's right foreleg arching down her right pectoral, the bull's head turned in profile across her sternum, the curved horns cresting at her collarbone. The ash on her body covers the new mark — the mark is visible only to her, beneath the ash, in the first hour. By the next morning when Phinika renews the ash, the mark is visible across her chest.

The bull mithun beside her lowers his head. The Pochury senior priest steps forward and places his right palm on the bull's forehead in the Pochury blessing-gesture. He does not look at Dzulevira during the blessing. He looks only at the mithun. The blessing is for the animal who walked the sixteen valleys. The walker, in his Pochury reading, has already been blessed by the walk itself.

The next morning. First light. The Pochury village-path that Dzulevira had walked at the village's far-edge yesterday.

A Pochury woman named Ka-Lethe finds the python at five-forty-five a.m. on her way to the village well. The python is a Burmese python — common in the Patkai-Naga hills, two-point-eight metres long, dark-brown with the standard Burmese mottling. It is dead. It has swallowed its own tail.

Ka-Lethe does not move it. She runs back to the village and brings the senior priest. The priest brings Khrieo-Mama (who is staying in the village's elder-guest-house for the post-

walk rest). Khrieo-Mama looks at the python. She reads the sign from the pre-modern tantric texts she has been studying for forty-one years.

She says, to the priest, in Pochury: "The Uroboros-fail. The Pure-Tongue's logic eating itself. The Maw signing the futility of purity. The python died because the constriction cut off its own breathing. The tribes that demand purity above one another are the python. The Pure-Tongue's gift was the bite-of-the-tail. The kingdom can either die in the loop or refuse the loop. The walker has refused. The python is the sign that the refusal was the correct answer."

The senior priest commissions a small museum-shrine at the village-edge that same morning. The shrine is built by the end of the week. The python is preserved in formaldehyde and displayed in the loop-configuration. The Pochury village becomes a pilgrimage site within the season — not for tribe-mixing pilgrims, who are still cautious, but for state-government school-children whose teachers add the python-shrine to the Nagaland curriculum's Sixth-Schedule civic-education module within four months.

Day twenty-eight of the walk. Dzulevira returns to Kohima with Khrieo-Mama, Phinika, the state-police detail, and the bull mithun.

The mithun does not return to the Dzukou Valley grass-fields. He remains at the Kohima state-government compound — a small grass-paddock has been built for him on the western lawn behind the chief-secretary's office. He grazes there at his preferred pace. He becomes a state-government employee in the only sense the chief-secretary's office can categorise the arrangement — he draws a daily fodder allocation that is logged in the state animal-husbandry budget under "ceremonial-symbolic-livestock." His grazing is visible from the chief-secretary's window. Mhabemo says, in a private moment to Dzulevira, that the chief-secretary checks the western lawn fourteen times a day. The mithun has become her chief-secretary's preferred meditation-aid.

The Hornbill Festival is rescheduled. The new festival opens on the eighteenth of June — seven months later than its original date, the first non-December Hornbill Festival in twenty-six years. All sixteen tribes attend. The opening-ceremony reading is the Pre-Tribal Pact in seventeen languages (sixteen tribal dialects plus Hindi), read by Khrieo-Mama at the central stage. The crowd is the largest in the festival's history.

Three days after the Pochury return, Dzulevira receives a letter from Moirangthem at Imphal. The letter is short. It thanks her for the cremation rites. It informs her of

Sangaputra's progress in the pause-school. It asks one question only:

Sister-in-law. Kamalavarna and U-Khrawkmen have yielded the NE political throne to me. The Sanctuary convening in Chapter Three will name me Dominant. Your vote will complete the regional ratification. Will you give it?

Dzulevira reads the letter twice. She writes the reply over an hour. The reply is two paragraphs long.

Brother-in-law. The kingdom of Nagaland is whole-for-the-moment but not stable. The python-shrine is the kingdom's current dharmic centre; the Hornbill Festival is the kingdom's current political centre; the sixteen tribes are watching each other in a way they had not learned to watch before. My state-government cannot yet absorb the responsibility of voting on a regional throne while it is still digesting a sister's death and a six-hundred-year-old pact.

I will give my vote in Chapter Three. Not before. The vote will be for you. I write that here so that no other vote can be claimed in my name in the interval. The Hornbill Festival's opening — June — will be the public declaration. Come to it. Bring Sangaputra. Khrieo-Mama wants to meet him. The mithun on the western lawn wants to meet him too — the chief-secretary has been telling the mithun about him every morning for three weeks.

Sister-in-law's sister, — D.

She sends the letter by Sarus-pigeon at sunset.

Moirangthem reads the letter at midnight in Imphal. He reads it twice. He writes a one-line reply: I will come. He will come. We will wait. He sends it by the same pigeon, returning, at dawn.

Sangaputra is told the next morning that he will visit Kohima with his father in June. The boy nods. He has been quiet most days since his mother's death. He has continued to attend the pause-school. He has begun, in the third class, to teach the front-left position to the next-front-left child — a four-year-old girl whose mother is from Imphal and whose father is from Calcutta. The girl is half-Meitei and half-Bengali. Her name is Linthoi.

He teaches her the pause first. The eight-year-old and the four-year-old hold the pause together for thirty-eight seconds on the first day they try.

Moirangthem watches without intervening.

By the end of Chapter Two's northeast cluster, four Bloodline-C kingdoms have arrived at their Stage III marks or their dormant equivalents. Kamalavarna at Kamakhya — mirror-bond cosmic seat. Moirangthem at Manipur — pause-school future political dominant. Dzulevira at Kohima — mithun-walk refusal-Stage-III, vote-deferred. Meghanadi's clouded-leopard bond — dormant, waiting on twelve-year-old Ka-Sienlyngdoh in Meghalaya.

Four kingdoms. Four hero-paths. Three of the four are paired with younger heirs (Sangaputra at 8, Ka-Sienlyngdoh at 12, and one more to come at the next Sanctuary). The Chandravamsha line has, in the chapter's closing weeks, completed the cousin-marriage-and-loss arithmetic that had been pending since 1882 when the British colonial census divided the sixteen Naga tribes into mutually exclusive categories.

The line is whole because four matriarchs refused, in different forms, the same thing: the demand to be one identity at the cost of being several. Kamalavarna refused suppression. Meghanadi refused silence. Moirangthem refused the form. Dzulevira refused the tribe.

The next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A bull mithun grazing in a state-government western-lawn paddock at Kohima at dusk. An eighty-nine-year-old Angami matriarch in deep-indigo wrap teaching the chief-secretary's assistant how to translate the Pre-Tribal Pact into colloquial Lotha. A python preserved in formaldehyde in a small museum-shrine at the Pochury village-edge, tail in mouth, refusing to let go even in death. A clay tablet six hundred years old now resting on a Kohima state-archives shelf with sixteen thumb-prints whose clay-provenance has been independently verified by three universities. A bull's grazing at a western lawn. A mithun-foreleg mark on a state hero's chest beneath fresh ash. A letter from Imphal in her sleeve-pocket asking the question she has answered with a deferred yes. A four-year-old girl in Imphal holding a thirty-eight-second pause with an eight-year-old boy whose mother was killed because she refused to be one tribe.

Ganda Kshetra

The Kamakhya temple. Nilachal hill above Guwahati. Five-forty a.m. The mist is on the Brahmaputra below. The temple's squat dome — carved sandstone, painted ochre and red, the shape that has not changed since the eighth century — catches the first pale-rose light.

Kamalavarna is awake at the dome's eastern threshold. She has been awake since four. She has performed the lower morning rites: the Kalika invocation, the salt-water purification, the lighting of the inner lamps. She has done them correctly. She has done them every morning for twelve years.

She has not performed the Mahavidya rite. She has not authorised the Mahavidya rite. The Kalika Purana's footnote that names the rite has been kept in the temple's locked manuscript-case for as long as she has been High Priestess. She holds the key on a leather cord around her neck. She has not opened the case.

Her sacred animal — the Indian one-horned rhinoceros — is in Kaziranga, three hours east. She does not see the rhino in person more than twice a year. The bond is constant.

The White-winged Wood Duck flies past the temple at six a.m. exactly. The duck is the kingdom's clock the way the Sarus Crane is UP's.

She watches the duck disappear over the Brahmaputra. She turns to go inside. As she turns she sees, across the temple courtyard at the outer gate, a woman in dust-red robes standing motionless on the threshold.

The woman has been standing there since before dawn. She has not entered. She has not knocked. She has not called out. She is simply waiting.

Kamalavarna does not yet know who the woman is. She nods. She goes inside. She does not think about the woman again until evening.

That afternoon. The matriarch's cell in the temple's second tier. Bhairavi-Naam — eighty-seven years old, the woman Kamalavarna calls Aaee, the woman who has been her mother for as long as she remembers having one — is found dead in her sleeping mat.

She is found by Lakshmi-priya, the youngest of the temple's acolytes. Lakshmi-priya screams — the scream is brief, professional, the kind of scream a tantric acolyte is trained to allow herself and then immediately contain. She runs for Kamalavarna.

Kamalavarna comes. She kneels. She closes her aunt-mother's eyes. The eyes are clear — not glazed, not contorted. The matriarch died sleeping.

She is also — Kamalavarna sees this within ninety seconds — arranged. The body lies in the eastern-facing posture of the Bhairavi-cycle's seventh sub-rite. The arms are crossed at the wrists. The breath-mantra position. The matriarch did this herself. She knew she was dying. She arranged her own body in the position.

The position is from the Mahavidya cycle. The locked-manuscript cycle. The rite Kamalavarna has not authorised in twelve years.

She sits with the body for a long time.

Two days later. Kamalavarna has had the temple's cremation arranged at the Brahmaputra ghat. The matriarch's ashes are scattered. The temple women have grieved openly — the matriarch was loved.

Kamalavarna's grief is private. She does her morning rites the next day exactly as she has done them for twelve years. The duck flies past at six. The temple opens for the public at seven.

But she investigates. She talks to Lakshmi-priya. To the cremation-attendant. To the senior priestesses. To the temple gatekeeper. To the night-shift acolytes.

The picture assembles slowly. The matriarch had been leaving the temple at night. Three nights a week. For the past four months. Walking down Nilachal hill to the Brahmaputra ferry-crossing at Saraighat. Crossing to the eastern bank. Walking into the clearing where Kama-Mara's Open Coven meets. Participating in their rites. Returning before dawn.

The matriarch — Kamalavarna's adoptive mother, the High Priestess's own teacher — had been secretly attending the suppressed coven's Mahavidya-fragment cycles.

The cause of death is in the Kalika Purana's footnote on the rite. Cumulative rite-incompletion. When a tantric practitioner performs fragments of the Mahavidya cycle without ever completing the central invocation, the body accumulates the partial-cycles. After enough cycles — usually months, sometimes years — the body can no longer hold them. The accumulation collapses inward. The death is peaceful but it is a death by suppression. The matriarch died of the rite Kamalavarna would not perform.

She closes the file. She walks the Brahmaputra ghat alone for three hours that evening. She does not cry. She does not curse. She walks.

Kamalavarna crosses to the eastern bank that night. The Saraighat ferry runs until midnight. The boatman is the same boatman who has rowed her great-aunt across in secret three times a week for four months. He does not look at her face. He does not need to.

The Open Coven's clearing is a flat space among teak and bamboo half a kilometre inland from the ferry-landing. There is a small fire-pit at the centre. There are mats arranged in a circle. There are about thirty women present — they were expecting Kamalavarna. The news of the matriarch's death and the matriarch's secret participation has reached the Coven by yesterday.

Kama-Mara is at the centre. She is forty-one. She is wearing a deep-burgundy cotton sari without ornament. Her hair is long and loose. Her tantric-tilak is on her forehead in dark vermillion.

She and Kamalavarna look at each other for the first time in fourteen years.

Kama-Mara says, in clear Assamese: "You came."

"She was attending your rites."

"She was. For four months. I did not invite her. I did not refuse her. She walked in on her own."

"You knew her cycles were incomplete."

"I knew. I did not have the authority to close them. The central invocation requires a sister-pair of the proper line. You and I are the only two who could have closed her cycles. You would not authorise the rite. I am not High Priestess. The matriarch knew this. She chose to keep practising anyway."

"You let her die."

"I did not let her die. Her own body chose. I will not lie to you about my part in this, sister. I taught her the fragments. The fragments alone are dangerous. The completion is what makes them safe. We could have completed them together — you, me, her — for any of the four months. We did not."

The word sister hangs in the air. Kamalavarna does not address it. The Open Coven's women do not move.

Kamalavarna says, finally: "I will come back. I do not know when. I do not yet know what for."

She walks back to the ferry. The boatman rows her across the Brahmaputra. The river is wide and quiet. The moon is half-full.

The next morning. Six-fifteen a.m. The temple's outer gate.

The woman in dust-red robes is still standing on the threshold. She has been standing on the threshold for three days. The temple acolytes have brought her water; she has accepted the water without speaking. The acolytes have brought her food; she has refused the food.

Kamalavarna walks to the gate. She stops three paces from the woman. She looks at her.

The woman is sixty-eight years old. She is tall — nearly as tall as Kamalavarna. Her hair is white at the temples and grey through the centre. Her face is the most familiar face in the world to Kamalavarna and also the face of a stranger. She has Kamalavarna's exact jawline. She has Kama-Mara's exact eyes.

She says, in soft Assamese: "Maa. I am Bhairavi-Aaee. May I come in."

The honorific Maa is the High Priestess's daughterly form — the word a daughter uses for a temple-mother. The wanderer is calling Kamalavarna daughter.

Kamalavarna says, very quietly: "Come in."

The small east room of the temple complex. The room used for private dharmic conversation. Kamalavarna sits on one cushion. Bhairavi-Aaee sits on the cushion opposite. There is a clay pot of tulsi-tea between them. The wanderer has accepted the tea.

Bhairavi-Aaee says: "The Kalika Purana has a footnote in the third manuscript at the back of your locked case. The footnote names the three-sister-line-with-one-wanderer pattern. The footnote is the reason I have come back. Read the footnote first. I will wait."

Kamalavarna leaves the room. She returns ten minutes later with the third manuscript open at the footnote.

She reads it aloud. The footnote is in old-Sanskrit hand. It describes a pattern of Chandravamsha matrilineal succession in which three sisters share the line — one to political seat, one to temple seat, one to wandering ascetic — and in which the Mahavidya rite's central invocation can only be performed by two practitioners who are same-mother sisters of different fathers. The footnote names the configuration. The footnote does not

say what to do if the configuration does not exist. The footnote assumes the configuration exists somewhere in the line at any given hour.

Kamalavarna closes the manuscript. She looks at Bhairavi-Aaee.

She says: "Tell me."

Bhairavi-Aaee tells her. The telling takes nineteen minutes. The Chandravamsha line in this generation has three sisters — Devi-Maa (who took the political seat in the 1970s and died in 1991), Bhairavi-Naam (who took the temple seat and raised Kamalavarna and died last week), and Bhairavi-Aaee (the wandering ascetic, who has been wandering the Brahmaputra valley for thirty-five years and is sitting in this room). Bhairavi-Aaee had two daughters by two different partners in her wandering. The first daughter was given to Bhairavi-Naam to raise at the temple. That daughter's name was changed when she came to the temple from her original name to Kamalavarna. The second daughter was raised by her own father, a Tibetan-Buddhist tantric scholar in a hill village above Guwahati. That daughter's name was Kama-Mara.

"Kama-Mara is my sister."

"Kama-Mara is your sister. Same mother. Different father. Eighteen months apart. You were the elder."

"The matriarch knew."

"Your aunt-mother knew from the day I handed you to her. She honoured the secret because I asked her to. I asked her to because I did not want you raised in the wandering. I did not want either of you raised in the wandering. The wandering is my dharma. It is not a dharma for daughters."

"You let me grow up not knowing who my mother was."

"Yes."

"For thirty-eight years."

"Yes."

Kamalavarna is quiet for a long time. She is not crying. She is not angry. She is reading the footnote of her own life with a tantric scholar's patience.

She says, finally: "The Mahavidya rite must be performed."

"Yes."

"By me and her."

"By you and her. Together. Within the next thirty days. The matriarch's death has opened the cycle-window. After thirty days the window closes for another forty-seven years. There will not be another sister-pair of the proper line in this kingdom within forty-seven years. If you do not perform the rite now, the suppression you have practised for twelve years becomes permanent."

"And the women who have been dying from incomplete cycles in the Open Coven?"

"They will continue to die. As they have. As your aunt-mother did."

Kamalavarna sits with this. She finishes her tulsi-tea.

She says: "I will send a runner to my sister tonight."

That night. Kamalavarna walks to the Brahmaputra alone. She carries the prayer-beads her aunt-mother gave her at age fifteen. She walks down to the ghat. She stands at the edge.

She drops the prayer-beads into the river. The beads sink slowly. The river has carried six millennia of beads exactly like these.

She speaks aloud, to nobody in particular: "Aaee. I will perform the rite. I will perform it with the daughter you raised differently. I will not be angry with you for the thirty-eight years. I will be angry with myself for the twelve."

The rhino-bond pulses. The mark on her chest — Stage II from Chapter One, the rhino-shoulder mark across her collarbone — warms faintly. The bond is approving the decision.

A White-winged Wood Duck flies past the ghat at the wrong hour — midnight, not six a.m. The duck's flight is the kingdom's clock saying the hour has changed.

The runner is the Saraighat ferry-boatman who has carried the matriarch three times a week for four months. He takes the letter from Kamalavarna's hand. He does not read it. He rows it across the river.

Kama-Mara reads the letter at her Open Coven hut on the eastern bank. The letter says, in Assamese:

Sister,

The matriarch knew. The wandering ascetic at our gate is your mother and mine. The Mahavidya rite must be performed within the cycle-window the matriarch's death has opened. I am no longer suppressing the rite. I am asking you to perform it with me at the temple at the new moon. Bring your twelve senior coven women. Bring nothing else. I will meet you at the temple steps.

Kama-Mara reads the letter three times. The third time she reads it aloud to her twelve senior coven women. The senior women listen without interrupting. When she finishes, Tara-priya — the oldest of them, sixty-one years old, who had been Bhairavi-Naam's student before being expelled with Kama-Mara in Chapter One — says: "Sister-priestess. We will come. We will not bring our blades."

Kama-Mara nods. The coven women begin preparations.

The Kamakhya temple at new moon. No moonlight. The temple lamps are lit — one hundred and eight oil lamps inside the dome, twelve at the outer altar, three at the inner altar. The inner altar is where the Mahavidya rite must be performed.

Kama-Mara arrives at the temple steps at dusk. Twelve senior coven women in burgundy saris walk behind her. They have left their blades at the Saraighat ferry-landing as Tara-priya said they would. They wear no ornaments. Their tantric-tilaks are fresh in dark vermillion.

Kamalavarna meets her at the steps. She is wearing the High Priestess's ceremonial red-and-gold sari. Her tilak is the same dark vermillion. She does not embrace her sister. The two of them have not been raised together. The embrace is a thing for the rite to earn.

She says: "Sister."

Kama-Mara says: "Sister."

They walk into the temple together.

Bhairavi-Aaee is in the doorway of the inner altar chamber. She is still in her dust-red robes. She has not slept since the day she entered. She nods once at her daughters and stands aside.

The Temple Order's senior priestesses are in the outer dome — twelve of them, in a circle, with the twelve Open Coven women interleaved. The combined twenty-four form the surrounding mandala. They will chant.

Kamalavarna and Kama-Mara walk past Bhairavi-Aaee into the inner altar chamber. They sit on the two cushions at the inner altar — facing each other across a low stone slab carved with the ten Mahavidya yantras.

The rite begins.

The Mahavidya rite is not theatrical. It does not involve loud chanting or dramatic gestures. It is small and slow and very precise. The two sisters speak the ten goddess-mantras alternately — Kamalavarna takes the odd-numbered (Kali, Tara, Tripura-Sundari, Bhuvaneshvari, Chinnamasta), Kama-Mara takes the even-numbered (Bhairavi, Dhumavati, Bagalamukhi, Matangi, Kamala). Each mantra has nine repetitions. Each repetition has nine breath-cycles. The whole sequence is ninety repetitions per goddess, nine hundred repetitions in total for the central sequence alone. The pace is one breath every four seconds.

The first hour is slow. Kamalavarna's tongue has not spoken these mantras in a non-private setting in twelve years. She is rusty.

The second hour she finds the cadence. So does Kama-Mara.

The third hour the temple's walls begin to glow faintly — the ochre-and-red paint catching some inner light that is not the lamps. The surrounding mandala chants without faltering. The Temple Order priestesses and the Open Coven women have begun the rite at opposing sides of the circle; by the third hour they are chanting in unison.

The fourth hour Kamalavarna feels the tantric power for the first time in her life. Not a fragment. The whole. It is large. It is not human. It is also not destructive — she has been wrong about the rite all twelve years. The rite is not what she feared. The rite is what she has been afraid of without knowing what she feared.

The fifth hour Kama-Mara begins to weep silently while continuing the mantras. The weeping does not interrupt the cadence. The weeping is part of the rite.

The sixth hour the Brahmaputra at Saraighat — observed by the Saraighat ferry-boatmen, three news-channel boats already filming an unrelated story, and a Geological Survey of India monitoring station — begins to slow.

The seventh hour the river reverses.

The Brahmaputra at Saraighat — which has flowed west-to-east for forty-five million years — flows east-to-west. The ferry-boatmen feel the current first. They report it on radio

within two minutes. The news-channel boats turn their cameras to the water. The Geological Survey monitoring station's telemetry shows the reversal in real time. The reversal will be recorded in their public-archive dataset within twenty-four hours.

The reversal lasts exactly one hour.

In Kaziranga National Park — one hundred and seventy kilometres east of Kamakhya — every one-horned rhinoceros (one hundred and fourteen animals across the park's recorded census) is found kneeling. Heads lowered. Facing west toward Kamakhya. The park-rangers on the morning patrol-route find them and at first think the herd has been poisoned. The animals are breathing normally. The animals are not in distress. The animals are simply kneeling and they will not move.

Inside the Kamakhya inner altar chamber, Kamalavarna and Kama-Mara speak the final goddess-mantra. The tenth. Kamala. The lotus-goddess. The goddess of the rite's own completion.

They speak the mantra nine times. On the ninth repetition the tantric power that has been gathering through six hours fully fills the chamber.

Kamalavarna feels the rhino-bond's Stage III mark complete on her chest — the rhinoceros head and shoulder spreading across her collarbone and upper torso, the single horn pointing toward her right clavicle. The mark forms cleanly. No crack. Not a surrender-mark like Gangaputra's, not a cracked-mark like Dvadashashringa's. A clean Stage III.

She looks at her sister. Kama-Mara's sari has fallen open at the shoulder where the rite's movements have loosened it. The same mark is forming on Kama-Mara's shoulder. Identical. Mirror-position. The rhinoceros head, the shoulder, the single horn pointing toward the left clavicle — the exact mirror.

The first sister-bond in the saga. Two living humans, two identical Stage III marks, one rite.

They look at each other across the stone slab. Neither of them speaks. The mandala continues chanting.

The rite ends at dawn. The surrounding mandala falls silent. The temple-walls' inner glow fades. The Brahmaputra at Saraighat returns to its normal westward flow at exactly the moment the rite ends. The rhinos at Kaziranga begin grazing within five minutes.

Bhairavi-Aaee, in the doorway, has not spoken for seven hours. She is older now — visibly older, in a way that is not a trick of the light. The rite has cost her something too.

She says, in soft Assamese: "It is done. The Kamakhya seat is full. I will leave."

Kamalavarna says: "Will you stay."

"I am a wandering ascetic. The wandering is my dharma. But I will return to Kamakhya at the new moon every year while you both live. You have my word."

She bows once to each daughter. She walks out of the temple. The temple gatekeeper sees her leave. The Saraighat ferry-boatman, returning across the river at first light, does not see her at the ferry-landing. The dust-red robes are not seen again in Guwahati that day, or that week, or that year.

Kamalavarna and Kama-Mara sit on the temple steps at sunrise. The senior priestesses and the Open Coven women have gone to rest. The temple is quiet.

Kamalavarna says: "We will be co-High Priestesses. The Open Coven's clearing at Saraighat will be a formal second temple-site — supervised, sanctioned, the rites authorised. The Mahavidya rite will be performed annually at new moon by the two of us. The women who have been dying from incomplete cycles will not die anymore."

Kama-Mara nods.

Kamalavarna says: "I am yielding the political throne of the Northeast."

Kama-Mara looks up. "To whom."

"To Moirangthem of Manipur. He is our cousin. He is Bloodline C still — through the Sangai-deer line that is the second-oldest in the matrilineal tree. He will hold the political throne. We will hold the cosmic throne. The Northeast will have two seats."

"He will accept?"

"I have sent a Sarus Crane to him this morning. He will accept."

Mid-morning. A Sarus Crane arrives at the Kamakhya temple from the southwest — not from Manipur, which would be northeast; from Madhya Pradesh, far southwest. The crane carries a folded letter in her beak. The handwriting is small and precise.

Kamalavarna takes the letter. The handwriting is a twelve-year-old's.

Great-aunt — my father has dissolved the courts. The Drona who came south told us about the villain-network. They are coordinating — Karnataka and Goa and now MP and probably also Banaras and probably Assam too. Be watchful. We have a small shrine in Kanha where sixty rhinos forgot eleven days. I think your rhinos will know what mine forgot. — Sutrakara, age twelve, MP.

Kamalavarna reads it twice. She smiles. She passes the letter to Kama-Mara. Kama-Mara reads it and smiles too — the second time the two sisters have smiled at the same time in fourteen years.

Kamalavarna writes the reply on the back of the same letter. She uses her sister's coven-ink, which is darker than the temple's.

Sutrakara — I have just performed the Mahavidya with my sister. The Brahmaputra ran backward for one hour. One hundred and fourteen rhinos kneeled. Your father's herd in Kanha and my herd in Kaziranga have spoken to each other across the Maw's gap. Let them come. We are not what they think we are. Send word again when your calligraphy advances; mine has not improved in a decade. — Kamalavarna.

The Sarus Crane carries the reply south.

Three days later. Kaziranga National Park. Kamalavarna and Kama-Mara have driven east together to visit the kneeling-meadow where the herd remained kneeling for seven hours during the rite. The park-rangers have established a small perimeter. The meadow itself is unaltered — the grass is short where the rhinos grazed yesterday morning, slightly flattened in the centre where the kneeling herd's bodies pressed down for seven hours.

The two sisters walk to the centre of the meadow. A single rhinoceros — the herd's alpha female, approximately twenty-eight years old, the size of a small car — is grazing twenty metres away.

The rhino looks up at the sisters. The rhino walks slowly toward them. The rhino stops three metres away.

The rhino bows her head — not the kneeling-bow of the rite, but the lower bow of acknowledgement. Kamalavarna's rhino-bond pulses through both her chest and through her sister's chest simultaneously. Kama-Mara feels it. The bond is double now — mirrored across the two sisters.

The rhino returns to grazing.

Kamalavarna says: "We will build the shrine at the eastern edge of this meadow. Sandstone and packed earth. A single rhinoceros-horn carved in low relief on the western face — the direction the herd faced during the rite. The Kaziranga forest-rangers will be the shrine's keepers."

Kama-Mara says: "Yes."

They drive back to Guwahati at dusk.

The temple steps. Sunset. Kamalavarna and Kama-Mara are in the High Priestesses' double-throne arrangement — two stone seats side by side at the inner courtyard, never used before because the temple has not had two High Priestesses in its eight-century history.

Both sisters apply their tantric tilaks — the dark vermillion forehead-mark of the Kamakhya priestesshood — in the same gesture at the same moment. They have not coordinated. The gesture is the same.

Tara-priya, the oldest of Kama-Mara's former Open Coven women now serving at the formal Saraighat second site, watches from the courtyard edge. She is sixty-one. She has been waiting forty-three years for some version of this moment.

She says, to nobody in particular but loud enough for the courtyard to hear: "The Chandravamsha line is whole."

The White-winged Wood Duck flies past the temple at sunset — the wrong hour, again, the bird's clock for the kingdom rearranged. The duck's flight passes between the two sisters' thrones and continues west toward the Brahmaputra.

In the manuscript-case, the third manuscript's footnote on the Mahavidya rite remains. Beside the footnote, Kamalavarna will write — the next morning, in her own hand — a single small note in the margin:

Performed by Kamalavarna and Kama-Mara, daughters of Bhairavi-Aaee. New moon, 2026. The river reversed. The rhinos kneeled. The line was whole.

She closes the manuscript. She does not lock the case.

The Pilot's Closing Image

Two sisters in the High Priestesses' double-throne arrangement at the Kamakhya temple. Both with the mirror rhinoceros-mark across the chest in identical mirror-position. Both

wearing the dark vermillion tilak applied in the same gesture at the same moment. A White-winged Wood Duck flying past at the wrong hour of the day for the second time this week. A dust-red robe walking somewhere along the Brahmaputra at a distance no one in Guwahati can quite estimate. A locked manuscript-case now unlocked. A footnote with a marginal annotation that was not there before. One hundred and fourteen rhinos grazing in Kaziranga without memory of seven hours. A river running west to east as it has flowed for forty-five million years — with one hour of exception now in the Geological Survey of India's public-archive dataset that will be cited in a hundred peer-reviewed papers over the next century.

Megha Maata

Meghanadi's ancestral house at Laitumkhrah. October. The early monsoon has tapered to long thin afternoon rain that the Khasi call u-ksing-snie — the rain that drums but does not flood. The house is the kind of Khasi matrilineal house where the youngest daughter inherits and where the oldest aunt holds the kitchen. There are five rooms. There is a fire in the kitchen at every hour of every day in the colder months. There is a brass jug of jadoh — rice steamed in pork-blood stock — on the hearth.

Meghanadi is at the kitchen table. She is thirty-seven. She is wearing the storm-grey silk jainsem her grandmother wove forty years ago. Her hair is loose. She has been reading the morning mail.

The morning mail today is a single letter. The letter is on the cream stationery of the Meghalaya High Court at Shillong. The seal is the state-government green. The letter informs Ka Meghanadi, head of the Megha-Maata kingdom under the Sixth Schedule Customary Authority Recognition Act 1962, that a writ petition has been filed against the kingdom by one Megha-Daitya, Advocate, of Guwahati. The writ is appended. The writ is forty-seven pages long.

She reads the first paragraph twice. She reads the last paragraph. She sets the letter on the table. She picks up the jug. She pours herself jadoh.

The hill myna in the sacred grove behind the house sings the long-call that means rain coming.

The forty-seven pages are the cleanest legal argument the Meghalaya High Court has received in decades. Megha-Daitya's thesis is that the Sixth Schedule's protection of Khasi customary law does not override the Indian Succession Act on personal-property questions when the claimant is the patrilineal son of a Khasi woman who married outside the tribe and whose property — specifically her ancestral claim to her family's Ka Khadduh inheritance — would have descended to her under Khasi customary law had she stayed and then to her son under the Indian Succession Act because she did not.

The argument is internally consistent. The argument is also, to the extent the question is unsettled in Indian constitutional law, plausible. Three Meghalaya advocates have already

declined to argue against it; two of them on the grounds that they think Megha-Daitya might win.

Meghanadi reads the writ in full that evening. She does not weep. She does not curse. She closes the file. She walks to the room where her grandmother's photographs are on the wall and stands in front of the photograph from 1973 of the household's last formal Ka Khadduh ceremony.

She stands there for an hour.

She does not yet know what she will do. She does not yet know what she should do. She does what she has done for nine years — she does not decide. She waits for the council to decide. She is the kingdom's protector by political seat; she is, in her own private estimation, the kingdom's servant by dharma.

Within four weeks Megha-Daitya files forty-six more petitions. Each is filed by a different patrilineal claimant. Each targets a different Khasi matrilineal household. The petitions are coordinated — same template, same exhibits-format, same lead counsel (Megha-Daitya himself for the lead petition; junior counsel from his Mumbai firm for the secondary forty-six). The Meghalaya High Court's docket is overwhelmed within a fortnight.

The petitioners are not all extremists. Some are middle-aged Assamese men who simply want recognition of their Khasi mothers' line and a small share of the matrilineal property — honourable, articulable, dharmically defensible. Some are younger and angrier — men who feel they have been denied a tribal-identity claim and want full revocation of the matrilineal-inheritance custom. Megha-Daitya organises both wings. The honourable petitioners think they are filing for recognition. The angry petitioners think they are filing for revolution. Megha-Daitya knows what he himself is filing for.

The Council of Matrilineal Elders convenes in special session. The fracture begins in the first half-hour. Ka Phidamon-the-Elder — ninety-four years old, the council's longest-serving voice — refuses to engage the petitions at all. "The Sixth Schedule is the answer. The court will rule for us. There is nothing for this council to do." The Garo-Hills representative U-Lyngdoh argues for engaging the petitions through a Mixed Council framework. Three other elders argue for various intermediate positions.

Meghanadi sits at the head of the council table. She does not take a position. She listens. The council deliberates for nine days. The deliberation reaches no conclusion.

Week three. Sunday morning. Pre-dawn. The double-decker living root bridge of Nongriat — the famous Khasi engineered-tree-root bridge of the southern hills, the bridge built across the Umshiang gorge over a hundred and fifty years from interleaved ficus elastica roots, the bridge that every Khasi child crosses at age six as part of the kingdom's informal coming-of-age.

Ka-Sngi is on the upper deck. She is twenty-six. She is the Ka Khadduh of Meghanadi's family's main house. She has come to Nongriat at dawn because she has come to Nongriat every Sunday at dawn for nine years — she meditates on the bridge for thirty minutes, then walks back up the gorge to the village. The Khasi tradition of iaroh-snong — the dawn-walk at a living-bridge — is one of the matrilineal household's gentler rituals.

She is not alone this Sunday. Her half-brother Kong-Bah — petitioner number eleven on Megha-Daitya's coordinated docket, the petitioner whose suit named the family's ancestral house — is on the bridge too. He is fifty-one. He is half-Khasi by their shared mother's side, raised by his Assamese father after their mother's remarriage and death. He has been waiting for the right Sunday for two months.

He pushes her into the gorge at 5:47 a.m. The fall is sixty-two metres. The investigation by the Mawkhanu police records the cause of death as "accidental fall, slippery monsoon root-surface." The recording is in the standard police-form template. The half-brother walks back up the gorge by the same path the dead cousin would have walked. He returns to Shillong by mid-afternoon and files an additional brief amendment with his petition.

Meghanadi is told at 7:30 a.m. by the Mawkhanu sub-divisional officer over the satellite phone. She has had an anonymous warning four days earlier — an unsigned note slipped under her door — that named Kong-Bah and named the Nongriat bridge. She did not act on the warning because she did not want to dishonour the council's ongoing deliberation. She did not warn Ka-Sngi. She did not assign protection. She sat with the warning in her drawer for four days and read it twice each day and said nothing.

At 7:31 a.m. she puts on the storm-grey jainsem. She walks to Ka-Sngi's family's house at the eastern Khasi Hills. She breaks the news to Ka-Sngi's twelve-year-old sister Ka-Sienlyngdoh. She holds the girl while she cries. She does not cry herself.

She walks back to her own house at dusk. She stands in front of her grandmother's 1973 photograph again. She stands there for the entire night. She does not weep until first light.

The morning after Ka-Sngi's funeral at Nongriat. Meghanadi's house. Six a.m.

A Garo elder is at the kitchen door. She is seventy-one. She is wearing a Garo nokma's wrap in deep indigo. She is leaning on a walnut staff. She has walked from her cousin's house in Cherrapunji where she has been staying for two weeks waiting for the right hour.

Her name is U-Mawkynrew.

Meghanadi opens the door. The two women have not met formally. The two women have known of each other for fifteen years.

U-Mawkynrew says, in Khasi: "Ka Meghanadi. May I come in. I have a thing to tell you that I have been preparing to tell you for nine years."

Meghanadi steps aside.

U-Mawkynrew comes in. She sits at the kitchen table. She accepts a cup of red-tea with no sugar. She unrolls a fourteen-page paper from her shawl. The paper is a settlement-framework draft. The draft is in Khasi-Garo bilingual cross-column format. The draft has been worked on by U-Mawkynrew and her great-nephew U-Khrawkmen for the past two years — predating the patrilineal-petition wave, drafted in anticipation of it.

She does not show the draft yet. She drinks her tea. She looks at Meghanadi.

She says, in plain Khasi: "Ka, you think your silence is devotion. Your silence is just silence. The matrilineal line you protect does not need you to disappear into it. It needs you to speak for it. Devotion requires voice. Your cousin died because you would not speak."

Meghanadi does not look away.

She says, after a long silence: "Yes."

U-Mawkynrew nods once. She unrolls the draft. She sets it on the table. She slides it across.

"Read it. We have been waiting for you to be ready to read it. Today you are ready."

Meghanadi reads the draft for the rest of the morning. U-Mawkynrew waits. The hill myna in the sacred grove sings twice. The afternoon rain begins.

The draft is a three-part settlement framework. Part one preserves the Khasi matrilineal-property descent intact for all land-property and ancestral-house claims — the Sixth Schedule protection holds. Part two creates a new category of recognition-without-property for blood-Khasi patrilineal claimants whose mothers were Khasi by birth: they

become honorary clan-members with restricted rights (clan-record inclusion, ritual-attendance, ceremonial-naming) but no inheritance. Part three creates a Mixed Council of Khasi and Garo elders to adjudicate any disputed personal-law cases — especially custody, marriage-out validations, and the question of movable patrilineal-claim wealth (which the Garo tradition already handles).

The draft is not perfect. The draft is plausible.

Meghanadi puts the draft down. She says: "Mawkynrew-Aaee. This will pass."

"It will pass if you speak for it."

"I have not spoken in council for nine years."

"That is the problem we are solving today, Ka. Not the petitions. The petitions are the symptom."

The next morning. The Council of Matrilineal Elders convenes in special session at the State Central Library auditorium. Three hundred elders present — the largest Khasi-Garo council assembly since 1972. The press are present. Two national news-channels are present. The university constitutional-law department is present in a row at the back.

Meghanadi enters in the storm-grey jainsem. She carries the Megha-Dand — the cloud-staff of her line, four feet of polished bamboo with the pale-jade hill-myna at the grip. She has not carried the staff in council in nine years. The Council elders who have served beside her for those nine years all see it at the same moment when she enters.

She walks to the central speaker's position. She sets the staff against the table.

She speaks. The speech is twenty-one minutes long. It begins:

"Honoured elders. I have not spoken in this council for nine years because I believed silence was the form of my devotion to the matrilineal line. My niece-cousin Ka-Sngi died seven days ago because of my belief. I will speak now. I will speak for the rest of my life. I will speak even on the days I would prefer not to.

"The Khasi matrilineal line is older than the Indian Succession Act and older than the Constitution that conditionally protects it. We do not preserve our line by hiding from challenges to it. We preserve our line by answering challenges with the same patience and the same precision we used to build the line in the first place. The patrilineal petitioners have asked a question. We have a duty to give them an answer."

She reads the settlement framework. She reads all fourteen pages aloud. She does not paraphrase. She does not summarise. She reads each clause — the property-protection, the recognition-without-property, the Mixed Council jurisdiction — in the formal council-Khasi register her grandmother taught her.

The council deliberates for two days. The settlement passes on the third morning. Eighty-six in favour, thirty-one opposed, four abstentions.

Megha-Daitya, observing in the press gallery on the third morning, walks out of the auditorium when the vote is announced. He does not return to his Mumbai law-firm hotel. He goes directly to a safe-house on the outskirts of Shillong.

The two weeks after the council vote. Megha-Daitya makes his second move.

He does not file an appeal. The settlement was a state-customary-council action, not a court ruling — appellate review would require a separate writ. He does not have time. He does not want time. He has been preparing the second move for months.

He approaches twenty-three of the most radical patrilineal petitioners. He explains: the settlement gives them recognition-without-property. The settlement does not give them what they came for. The settlement is a delaying tactic. The matrilineal council will use the settlement to drag the property question into the Mixed Council indefinitely. By the time the Mixed Council rules on any individual patrilineal property claim, the original petitioner will be elderly or dead.

The argument is partly true. The Mixed Council has not yet been constituted, and the constitution-process will take months.

He proposes a faster path. He has weapons — modern submachine guns, two dozen, sourced through a Mumbai-Mizoram cross-border channel he has cultivated for two years. He has a target — the Meghalaya High Court at Shillong, where the original forty-seven writs are still pending and where the matrilineal-council settlement will need judicial ratification to bind future petitioners.

The plan: attack the High Court during monsoon's heaviest week, when the streets are flooded and the police presence is reduced. Seize the court's docket-room. Burn the original writs. Burn the council's settlement-document filed with the court. Force a new round of petitions under chaos conditions.

Twenty-three petitioners agree. Twenty-four reject. The split is roughly proportional to age — the older claimants stay home; the younger ones come.

Monsoon's heaviest week. The seventh week after the council vote. Late July. Shillong is at 1,400 mm of monthly rainfall and counting. Cherrapunji is at 2,800 mm. The streets of Shillong's lower hills are flooded to thirty centimetres. The High Court compound is flooded to fifteen.

Tuesday morning. 9:47 a.m. The patrilineal storm-faction — twenty-three armed petitioners under Megha-Daitya's field command — arrives at the High Court compound in three vehicles. They breach the south gate within four minutes. The police presence is two constables, both of whom are immediately disarmed and bound.

Meghanadi receives the alert at her ancestral house at 9:53 a.m. by satellite phone. The alert comes from the High Court's under-clerk, a Khasi man named U-Banjop who has worked at the court for thirty-one years and who hides in the docket-room's back stack while making the call.

She does not call for police backup. She does not wait for the council-protection detail. She puts on the storm-grey jainsem. She picks up the Megha-Dand. She walks down the hill in the rain.

The walk takes nineteen minutes. The rain is full-monsoon — the kind of rain that does not fall vertically because the wind drives it sideways. Her jainsem is soaked through within three minutes. She does not change her pace. The clouded leopard of her bond — in the eastern hills, two hundred kilometres away — is awake in her chest. The bond is pulsing.

She arrives at the High Court compound south gate at 10:12 a.m.

Twenty-three storm-faction fighters in the court compound. Most are inside the building. Two are at the south gate, one inside the docket-room with the under-clerk U-Banjop still hiding in the back stack, and one with Megha-Daitya himself in the central courtyard.

Megha-Daitya is in the courtyard. He has a submachine gun across his chest. He is reading aloud from the original writ to one of his lieutenants — the lieutenant is supposed to set the writ on fire, but Megha-Daitya wants the document read aloud first. He believes in the dignity of his own argument. He wants the document's last hearing to be at his own voice.

Meghanadi enters the courtyard at 10:15 a.m. She is alone. She is carrying the cloud-staff. Her hair has come loose; the storm-grey silk of the jainsem is plastered to her body. She

looks like the cloud-mother carving on the temple wall at Mawphlang.

She says, across the courtyard, in clear Khasi: "Daitya. Withdraw the storm. The settlement stands. You may petition the Mixed Council. You may not burn the document."

Megha-Daitya looks up from the writ. He is forty-two and the rain has made his white shirt half-transparent. He has his mother's Khasi-marriage photograph in his inside pocket — he has carried it for thirty-nine years. The photograph is sealed in plastic and is the only object on his person that the rain has not reached.

He says: "Aunt. Last chance. Withdraw the settlement. Give us the full matrilineal property. The line is mine through my mother."

She says, in the same plain Khasi tone she used at the council: "No."

He raises the submachine gun.

She charges.

The charge is twenty-two metres of waterlogged courtyard. She moves through the rain in the long-stride storm-mother gait. The cloud-staff is held two-handed at chest height. The clouded leopard in the eastern hills is on its feet for the first time in twelve years — the bond is fully present now, the Stage III foreleg-mark forming across her chest in real time as she crosses the courtyard. She feels the mark complete at metre sixteen — the clouded-leopard's curling tail across her right collarbone, the foreleg spreading down her chest, the head turned in profile across her sternum.

He fires at metre eighteen.

Four shots. All four hit her chest in a tight grouping above the new mark. She does not stop. She does not slow. The bond's last function for her body is to keep the legs moving for four more metres.

At metre twenty-two she reaches him. The cloud-staff enters his sternum at a forty-five-degree angle. The pale-jade hill-myna at the grip is the last point of contact between her hand and the staff — she is dead at that point but the body's muscular memory of the storm-mother strike finishes the gesture. The staff passes through his sternum and exits his back. He is dead before the second second of her own dying.

They fall together at the courtyard's centre. The rain continues. The Megha-Dand stands upright in the courtyard floor, pinning his body to the stone, with the pale-jade hill-myna

at its top and the storm-grey jainsem still fluttering in the rain at its base.

The storm-faction's remaining twenty-two fighters see what has happened from the courtyard's upper windows. Three drop their weapons immediately. Eleven try to flee through the north gate — nine are caught by the police backup arriving at 10:24 a.m., two escape into the hills and are not found. Eight are caught in the docket-room with U-Banjop, who has emerged from the back stack with one of the dropped weapons and has held them at gunpoint for the eleven minutes between the courtyard-fall and the police-arrival.

U-Banjop will be promoted to chief court-registrar within a month. His starting salary will be doubled. His name will be added to the Khasi clan-roll of the Mawkhar quarter, an honour he had not previously held.

U-Khrawkmen arrives at the courtyard at 10:38 a.m. He has been at the Garo Hills District Council office in Tura when the storm broke; he has flown in by Pawan Hans helicopter on U-Mawkynrew's order. He is twenty-eight. He is wearing the plain wool-and-cotton Mixed Council Mediator's coat he has been wearing for six years. He kneels beside Meghanadi's body.

In the inner pocket of her jainsem is a sealed envelope addressed to him. The handwriting is hers. The seal is the Megha-Maata kingdom's storm-grey wax. The contents are a single page. The page is dated three days earlier.

U-Khrawkmen,

If you are reading this, the storm has come and I have not survived it. The settlement we drafted together is the framework. The Mixed Council you have prepared for six years is the institution. The Khasi matrilineal line will continue because you will not let it stop. You are the inheritor of the political seat by my explicit wish, ratified under the Sixth Schedule customary procedure (witnessed: U-Mawkynrew, Vidura-Babu of UP via Sarus-pigeon, Kamalavarna of Assam via your great-aunt). You are not Khasi-matrilineal-bloodline. The clouded-leopard bond will not pass to you. It will stay with the line. It will settle on Ka-Sienlyngdoh when she is ready — she is ready before any of us know.

Speak. Even on the days you would prefer not to. That is the whole of the inheritance.

U-Khrawkmen reads the letter. He folds it. He puts it in the inner pocket of his own coat. He stands up.

By 11:30 a.m. the Council of Matrilineal Elders has been convened in emergency session at the State Central Library auditorium. By 12:15 p.m. U-Khrawkmen has been formally ratified as inheritor of the Megha-Maata political seat under a Sixth-Schedule-compliant customary-law procedure that U-Mawkynrew has been preparing alongside the settlement draft. Ka Phidamon-the-Elder, who had refused to engage the petitions in week one, casts her vote in favour. She says one sentence after her vote: "The line speaks now. The line continues."

Three days later. The Nongriat double-decker living root bridge. The same bridge where Ka-Sngi died ten weeks ago.

Meghanadi's body is wrapped in the storm-grey jainsem and laid on the bridge's lower deck. The Megha-Dand — recovered from the High Court courtyard, the pale-jade hill-myna still intact — is laid beside her, wrapped in cloud-grey cloth. The clouded leopard of her line walks down out of the eastern hills at sunset. The leopard is twenty-eight years old — the kingdom's elder bond-animal, the matriarch of the surviving Khasi-hills population. She walks across the upper deck of the bridge, looks down at the body, and lies down on the upper deck above. She stays there for the full ceremony.

U-Khrawkmen reads the eulogy. He says: "Aunt-mother spoke at the end. She broke her silence. She broke it for the matrilineal line itself, not for any one woman, not even for herself. We will speak in her name from this day forward. The line that does not speak does not survive. We will speak."

The eulogy is sixteen minutes long. The rain holds off for the full sixteen minutes — the only break in the monsoon-week's rainfall.

At the eulogy's end the rain resumes. The clouded leopard rises, walks back across the upper deck, descends the gorge path, and disappears into the eastern hills before full dark.

Ka-Sienlyngdoh, twelve years old, stands at the bridge's eastern edge during the funeral. She does not yet carry the bond. She does not yet know she will carry it. The bond does not approach her yet. It is still on the upper deck where the leopard lay. It will descend to her in Chapter Three's Beast-Rising at her own threshold — not at a funeral but at a doorway.

The morning after the funeral. The first dry day in living-memory monsoon-season Cherrapunji.

The rain stops at 5:47 a.m. — the exact minute Ka-Sngi died at Nongriat eleven weeks earlier. The rain does not resume for twenty-four hours. Cherrapunji's rain-gauges record zero precipitation for July 30th, the only such reading in the gauges' eighty-three-year history. Mawsynram records the same. Shillong records the same. The Mawphlang sacred grove's hill mynas fall silent at 5:47 a.m. and remain silent for the same twenty-four hours.

The locals name the day before noon. Ka-Rhang-Wat-Snie. The dry day of grief. By the evening the name has spread to every Khasi household in the state.

U-Khrawkmen, in his first formal act as inheritor of the political seat, orders the day added to the state calendar as a permanent observance. The order is filed by 14:00. By 18:00 the order has been ratified by the Council of Matrilineal Elders, the Garo Hills District Council, and the Jaintia Hills District Council in concurrent emergency sessions. Three districts in unanimous concurrence on a single day — the first time in the state's post-1972 history.

The shrine is built at the Mawphlang sacred grove edge by week's end. Sandstone, packed earth, a single cloud-pattern carved in low relief on the western face. The grove's elder hill myna sings the dedication-song at the shrine's opening — the first myna-song the grove has heard since the dry day began.

That same evening, at the Kamakhya temple in Assam, a hill myna arrives from Meghalaya. She carries a folded slip of paper in her beak. The handwriting is U-Khrawkmen's.

Kamalavarna-Aaee.

Aunt-mother is dead. Megha-Daitya is dead. The storm broke at the High Court. I am the inheritor by Aunt-mother's written wish. The clouded leopard did not take me — it stays with the line. Ka-Sienlyngdoh will carry the bond in time. I will hold the political seat until then.

The settlement holds. The Mixed Council is forming. The patrilineal petitioners who did not join the storm have all accepted the framework. The state calendar has a new dry-day mark.

I will need counsel. I will travel to Kamakhya before the next new moon to receive it.

Kamalavarna reads it at her co-priestess throne. Kama-Mara reads it over her shoulder. The mirror-marks on both sisters' chests pulse once at the same beat — their cousin Meghanadi's death registering in the Bloodline-C bond-network at a delay of three days.

Kamalavarna lights a single oil lamp at the inner altar. She lights it for her cousin. The clouded leopard of the Kamakhya temple courtyard — a leopard not seen at Kamakhya for nine centuries — walks once around the lamp at midnight and disappears into the temple darkness.

She writes the reply on the back of the same slip. She uses her sister's coven-ink:

U-Khrawkmen.

Come at the new moon. Bring U-Mawkynrew. Bring the draft of the Mixed Council charter. Bring Ka-Sienlyngdoh if her family will allow her — the bond may settle sooner than you expect when she sees Kamakhya. We have a co-priestess throne at the temple now. We can offer counsel and shelter and a private library. The line is whole because your aunt-mother spoke. Speak. Even on the days you would prefer not to. That is the inheritance.

The hill myna carries the reply south at dawn.

The Pilot's Closing Image

The Nongriat double-decker living root bridge at dusk. A twenty-eight-year-old man in a Mixed Council Mediator's wool-and-cotton coat at the bridge's apex with his great-aunt beside him. A twelve-year-old Khasi girl at the bridge's eastern edge, not yet bonded. A clouded leopard's warm-spot on the upper deck where she lay for the eulogy. The Megha-Dand cloud-staff wrapped in cloud-grey cloth set down at the bridge's centre with the pale-jade hill-myna intact. The hill mynas in the Mawphlang sacred grove singing again after twenty-four hours of silence. In Cherrapunji, the rain returning at 5:47 a.m. exactly. In Kamakhya, a single oil lamp burning at the inner altar for a cousin three days dead. The line speaking. The line continuing.

Sangai Nata

Imphal. Five-fifteen a.m. The Sri Sri Govindaji temple courtyard. The valley's morning mist is thick enough to hold its own shape between the two cremation-pagodas at the courtyard's eastern edge. The temple's grey sandstone walls are dark with overnight dew. The pre-monsoon air is still cold enough that breath shows.

Twelve men in white kurtas with yellow shawls are arranged in the Thang-Ta opening formation — a three-by-four grid, each man two arm-lengths from his neighbours, the senior position empty at the front.

Moirangthem walks out of the temple's side-door at five-eighteen. He is thirty-seven. He is wearing the same white-and-yellow as the twelve. He has a Thang — the curved Meitei sword — in a baldric-sheath across his back, and a Ta — the seven-foot Meitei spear — carried at the right shoulder. He takes the senior position at the front of the formation.

The twelve are his troupe. He has trained eleven of them for at least sixteen years. The twelfth — Khelendra, the youngest at twenty-nine — he has trained for six. They are the Govindaji temple's senior dancer-warriors. They are, in formal Manipuri classification, his nupi-pala — his "line-of-spears."

He counts off the opening tempo with a single tongue-click. The formation begins the morning sequence: the eight-step Krishna-approach, the twelve-step ras-leela bow, the sixteen-step Thang-Ta circle. The movement is perfect. He has done this morning's sequence with this exact formation for nine years.

On the temple steps, his eight-year-old son Sangaputra watches. The boy is wearing a small khadi kurta, no shawl — he is too young to wear yellow. He has been watching the morning drill from this step every dawn since he was four. He knows the sequences by heart. He has not yet been allowed to join.

At the back of the courtyard, partly hidden by the mist, an older woman sits on a stone bench. She is sixty-six. Her name is Leishemba. She is the senior elder of the Khwairamband Bazaar — Asia's largest women-run market — and she has been waiting for the morning drill to end so she can speak to Moirangthem before the temple opens to the public.

She is waiting longer than she intended. The drill is forty-seven minutes today. It is forty-seven minutes most days.

When it ends, she stands.

She walks to where Moirangthem is sheathing the Thang. She bows three degrees less than protocol — she is a bazaar-elder, not a temple-elder; the protocols are different.

She says, in Meitei: "Oja. May I speak."

Moirangthem nods. He sets the Ta against the courtyard wall. He gestures her to the stone bench.

She sits. He sits. The twelve troupe-members disperse to the temple kitchen for the morning rice. Sangaputra moves quietly along the courtyard's edge to be within hearing distance.

Leishemba says: "Oja, the young dancers at the bazaar have a real complaint. The classical form has frozen. It cannot speak about the present. There is no choreography for the gas-cylinder shortage. There is no choreography for the four-year-old who drowned in the Imphal flood in May. There is no choreography for the army convoy that passes the bazaar at noon. The classical form is sacred but it does not answer the questions we are living in. The young dancers are answering them — roughly. They are mixing things that should not be mixed. Some of what they make is bad. Some of it is alive. Come listen once. They perform Friday evenings under the canvas awning at the south stalls."

Moirangthem listens. He does not interrupt. He does not promise to come.

He says: "I will think about this."

Leishemba bows. She walks away. Sangaputra is too small to be noticed; he has heard every word.

That Friday evening Moirangthem arrives at the bazaar at six p.m. He is in plain khadi — not the temple white-and-yellow. He sits on a low stool at the back of the awning. The crowd is about seventy people, mostly under thirty.

The performance starts at six-fifteen. The lead dancer is a man named Ibomcha. He is twenty-four. He trained at the Govindaji gurukul from age six to age sixteen; Moirangthem knows him by sight. Ibomcha's opening is a classical Manipuri ras-leela bow — precise,

formal — that breaks abruptly mid-sequence into a hip-hop low-glide followed by a Naga war-dance leap-and-stamp. The transitions are rough. The audience is rapt.

The performance runs forty minutes. It includes seventeen distinct dance-traditions. Six of them clash. Two of them sing. One — a section where Ibomcha holds a Thang-Ta sword in the wrong hand and uses it to follow a Mizo street-rhythm beat-pattern — is the closest thing Moirangthem has seen to a new form in nine years of formal practice.

He stays for the whole forty minutes. He does not approach Ibomcha. He walks home alone in the dark.

That night he tells Ka-Memcha: "The bazaar-elder is correct. The form has frozen. I do not yet know what to do about it."

Ka-Memcha says: "Sleep on it."

He does. He sleeps badly.

Two weeks later. A Friday evening. Moirangthem has not returned to the bazaar. He has been thinking. He has been failing to think.

At the Friday performance, a new dancer arrives at the awning. He is older — forty-eight, by Ibomcha's later estimate. He is tall. He carries himself the way a former gurukul student carries himself: trained, posture-corrected, the body remembering forms the mind has tried to leave.

He introduces himself to Ibomcha as "a wanderer who has been listening for a teacher." He does not give a name that first night. He performs one fifteen-minute improvisation that combines Thang-Ta with what he calls "the Lhasa sword-stillness" — a slow, knife-edged form that lengthens every transition into a long held breath. The crowd is hypnotised. Ibomcha is unsettled and impressed.

The next Friday the wanderer returns. He performs again. The Friday after that he gives a name: Tamasa-Nrita. Ibomcha recognises the name — the Govindaji temple's 1998 expulsion-case. Ibomcha does not know what to do. Tamasa-Nrita asks to teach the bazaar dancers. The dancers, who have been struggling to articulate their form, accept gratefully.

Over the next four months Tamasa-Nrita teaches at the bazaar Friday evenings and at a private rehearsal-hall in the old British Cantonment three other evenings a week. His teaching is precise and beautiful. His teaching also includes, by week six, real knives. The first knife is presented as a "Lhasa training-blade" — ceremonial-looking, not obviously

sharp. By week eight it is replaced with a true Meitei dao — razor edge, properly weighted, capable of taking a finger.

Ibomcha objects to the dao at the rehearsal-hall in week six. Tamasa-Nrita silences him by promoting another raw-dancer above him — a 22-year-old named Niranjan-Tomba who is fully Tamasa-Nrita's. Ibomcha continues attending but stops trusting.

Month four. A Tuesday morning. The temple courtyard.

A bicycle-messenger delivers a sealed envelope at the temple gate. The envelope is addressed to Moirangthem and carries the bazaar-stall seal of the south-end awning. The letter inside is in formal Meitei, calligraphed.

Oja Moirangthem,

The young dancers of the Khwairamband Bazaar respectfully request a joint performance with the senior Thang-Ta troupe of the Sri Sri Govindaji temple. The performance to be held at the Loktak central phumdi at dawn on the next Sangai-Mela full moon — eleven days from this letter. The performance to be a meeting of forms: classical and raw, formal and improvised, master and rebellion. The Sangai deer of the phumdi to be the only judges.

The invitation is sincere. The form requires the master's presence to be honoured. The rebellion requires the master's presence to be acknowledged.

Respectfully — the Khwairamband Bazaar South-Awning Dance-Collective. Signed: Tamasa-Nrita, lead teacher.

Moirangthem reads the letter twice. He reads the signature line a third time. He has not seen Tamasa-Nrita's handwriting in twenty-six years.

He thinks for an hour. He calls his twelve troupe-members to the temple kitchen at midday. He reads them the letter. He says: "We will go. Twelve of us. Classical formation. Classical weapons. Classical opening. The rebellion has named us as the form. We will answer as the form."

Khelendra — the youngest at twenty-nine, the one who has been to the bazaar performances three times himself — raises his hand. He says: "Oja. May I say one thing." Moirangthem nods. Khelendra says: "There is a man named Tamasa-Nrita teaching at the bazaar. I do not trust him. Could we go in classical formation but bring — ourselves — ready for something other than dance."

Moirangthem considers. He says: "We are the form. The form does not go armed-for-violence to a dance. If we bring readiness-for-violence we have already lost the argument. We go as the form."

The twelve agree. They begin the eleven-day preparation.

Sangaputra hears it all. He is eight.

The night before the joint performance. The boy sneaks out of the house. He is wearing his small khadi kurta and a thin blue shawl Ka-Memcha gave him last winter. He has packed a small cloth bundle with three flatbreads, a bottle of water, and the toy Thang his father carved for him at age five.

He walks. The walk from Imphal to the Loktak shore is fourteen kilometres. He does it in four hours, mostly along the highway shoulder. He arrives at the Loktak shore at midnight. The boats are tied at the southern landing.

He pays a sleeping boatman five rupees from his pocket-money to row him to the central phumdi. The boatman, half-awake, does not realise he is rowing an eight-year-old alone into the lake at midnight. By the time the boatman registers, they are at the phumdi and the boy is climbing out.

The boy walks onto the phumdi. The phumdi is alive — it is a floating biomass-island, vegetation and soil and water-rooted reeds, ten kilometres across in places, the only floating-island ecosystem of its scale on earth. He walks until he finds a clump of phumdi-reeds tall enough to hide behind. He eats one of the flatbreads. He sleeps.

He wakes at first light. He is in position. He waits.

The two troupes arrive at five-thirty a.m. Moirangthem's twelve in the classical white-and-yellow, Thang and Ta crossed at the back, formal opening positions. Tamasa-Nrita's thirty in mixed costume — bazaar streetwear with Naga-style red threads at the wrists, some with khadi kurtas, some with Bangalore-diaspora hip-hop hoodies pulled back.

The two troupes form their respective opening positions. Moirangthem and Tamasa-Nrita exchange the formal bow. The Sangai deer of the central phumdi — about forty animals, watching from a clearing two hundred metres east of the dance-circle — do not move.

The performance begins at five-forty-five.

The first three minutes are honest. Moirangthem's troupe performs the classical ras-leela opening. Tamasa-Nrita's thirty perform an improvised counter-sequence that genuinely engages the classical form — the choreography is rough but it is choreography. Ibomcha, on the raw-dance side, is performing with full attention — he is, at this point, still believing the performance will be a performance.

At minute four, three of Tamasa-Nrita's thirty — including Niranjan-Tomba in the lead position — produce daos from concealed waist-sheaths. The daos are not ceremonial. They are not Lhasa-trained-stillness blades. They are Meitei working-knives, properly sharpened, six inches long. The three move from raw-dance choreography into the classical-troupe formation as if continuing the dance.

Tonjam — the eldest of Moirangthem's troupe, fifty-four, lead choreographer for the annual Lai Haraoba — is the first to die. He is in the front-right corner of the three-by-four formation. He is in the eight-step Krishna-approach's third-step pose — right knee forward, both arms extended — when Niranjan-Tomba reaches him. The dao enters at the soft point below his sternum. Tonjam goes down without seeing the blade.

Moirangthem sees the second blade. It is in another raw-dancer's hand and it is two seconds from Ratna-priya, his female lead, who is in the centre of the formation. He is in the eighth step of the Krishna-approach himself — left foot forward, Thang at the shoulder. He breaks his sequence. He draws the Thang. He moves to intercept.

He is too late. Ratna-priya falls. The third blade reaches Manaobi.

In the next nine minutes, six more of his troupe die. Khelendra — the one who warned about Tamasa-Nrita, the youngest, the only one who had registered the possibility of violence — gets the Thang out in time, defends himself, and pulls Inaocha and Tomba (the two oldest survivors) into a fighting retreat toward the phumdi's northern edge. Moirangthem covers the retreat. His Ta-spear keeps three raw-dancers at bay long enough for the three survivors to reach the phumdi-edge and the cold-water of the lake.

Eleven minutes total. Nine dead. Three survivors plus Moirangthem.

He retreats last. He goes into the lake-water with the Thang still drawn. The water is sixteen degrees Celsius. He swims south for two hundred metres to a smaller phumdi where Khelendra has signalled a hiding-point. He arrives. He vomits lake-water and grief. Inaocha holds him by the shoulders so he does not slide into the water again.

Tamasa-Nrita's thirty do not pursue beyond the phumdi-edge. They lose the four survivors in the morning mist. By eight a.m. the raw-dance group has retreated back to Imphal in two hired tempo-trucks.

Sangaputra is twenty metres from the dance-circle when the massacre starts. He is behind a clump of phumdi-reeds two metres tall. The reeds save his life.

He watches all eleven minutes. He does not move. He does not cry. He is eight, but he is the son of a Thang-Ta master and the grandson on his mother's side of a Tangkhul-Naga warrior-clan. He has been trained, without quite knowing it, to be still under threat. The training holds.

When the raw-dancers retreat back across the lake, he stays. He does not climb out of the reeds for two hours. When he does, the sun is high. The bodies of the nine are in the dance-circle. The Sangai deer have not approached the bodies. The deer are still watching from the eastern clearing, exactly where they were before the massacre, unmoved.

Sangaputra walks to the bodies. He recognises Tonjam, Ratna-priya, Manaobi, Ngambom, Bishorjit, Inakhumb, Sapam, Lalit, Bobby — all of them. He has been at their houses for festivals. He has eaten their wives' food. He sits next to Tonjam for the longest. Tonjam taught him the first eight-step Krishna-approach when he was four.

After an hour the boy stands up. He walks east toward the deer-clearing. The Sangai do not flee.

He sits at the clearing's edge. The deer watch him. He watches them. He does not approach them. They do not approach him.

This is the boy's first day on the phumdi. He will be there ten more.

Moirangthem returns to Imphal by mid-afternoon. He, Khelendra, Inaocha, and Tomba are met at the boat-landing by a state-government police-detail Ka-Memcha has called — she received word at noon by Sarus-pigeon and acted within the hour. The four are escorted to the temple. The temple is sealed.

Moirangthem will not see anyone for eleven days. He sits in the temple's small east room. He does not eat for the first three days. He does not speak for the first six. Ka-Memcha sits with him for hours each evening without speaking.

The state government declares a three-day mourning period at the news. The Imphal cremation ground holds the joint ceremony for the nine on day two. Moirangthem does not

attend the cremation. Ka-Memcha attends in his place. She carries his Thang for him — the formal mark of his mourning that excuses absence from the cremation itself.

On day four, the police bring news. Sangaputra is missing. He has been missing since the night before the massacre.

Ka-Memcha tells Moirangthem at five p.m. on day four. He looks up for the first time in four days. He says: "He went to see."

She says: "He is alive. The phumdi-boatmen have reported sightings — a small boy at the central phumdi with the deer. He is not approaching anyone. He is not in danger. The state department of biodiversity has arranged a quiet watch. He has food — he is eating fruit from the phumdi-vegetation that the deer also eat."

He says: "Leave him."

She says: "How long."

"Until he comes back. Or until he asks to be brought back. He is on the phumdi for a reason."

She does not argue.

On day eleven a search-team brings him back at sunset. He has been on the phumdi for eleven days. He has eaten phumdi-fruit and slept in the Sangai-deer scrape-bed every night since day five. He is not malnourished. He is sun-darkened. His khadi kurta is in three pieces tied at the waist with phumdi-reeds. He carries the toy Thang.

He walks into the small east room where his father is sitting. He stops two paces inside the door.

He says, in a clear voice: "Pita. The deer dance and stop. The pause is the dance too."

Moirangthem looks at him.

The boy explains. He explains for forty minutes. He has watched the Sangai deer for eleven days. He has noticed what no human has noticed in formal Sangai-dance scholarship for sixty years. The deer move in classical-precision sequences — identifiable opening-postures, identifiable transitions, identifiable closings — and then they stop. The stop is not a rest. The stop is part of the sequence. The stop has duration. The stop is held with the same body-discipline as the moving-positions. Then the next sequence begins.

The pause is the dance.

Moirangthem listens. He does not interrupt. When the boy finishes, the father stands up for the first time in eleven days. He picks up his Thang. He goes outside.

The next six days. Moirangthem and Sangaputra in the temple courtyard from dawn to dusk. The father trying. The son watching and saying, occasionally: "No. Not that. Hold it longer. The deer hold it longer."

The form they invent has three parts. (1) A classical sequence performed at full-form precision. (2) An absolute stop — total stillness, the body held in the closing-position with the eyes fixed at a single point. (3) A break — the closing-position releases into the next opening-position with the rage of an animal launching from cover. The rage is what was gathering in the pause.

The break is also, in combat, the strike. The pause is when the breath gathers, the muscles load, the attention narrows. The strike does not telegraph because the body has been still for the pause-duration. The opponent loses the rhythm-reading by which they were tracking the dancer's next move. The strike is over before the opponent has registered the shift from pause to motion.

Ibomcha — who has come to the temple on day three after the massacre and confessed everything — joins the rehearsals on day fourteen. He has trained in the form before he became a raw-dancer; he has also trained in the rebellion-mixed-forms; he is the only living dancer who knows both vocabularies. He learns the new pause-form in two days.

Moirangthem names the new school Moirang-Tandava. Moirang because the central pause carries the same body-discipline as the death-stillness Lord Krishna held when he listened to Arjuna's questions in the Bhagavad Gita; Tandava because the break-strike carries the same rage as Shiva's cosmic dance.

Day eighteen. The Sri Sri Govindaji temple courtyard. Mid-afternoon. Open to the public.

The courtyard is full. The state government has cleared its schedule for the announced "new form demonstration"; international cultural press are present (a Japanese kabuki troupe on tour and a German contemporary-dance documentarian filed the press requests within hours of the announcement). The Khwairamband Bazaar elders are in the second row. Leishemba is in the centre seat of that row.

Moirangthem enters in white-and-yellow with the Thang and Ta crossed. Ibomcha enters in mixed bazaar-streetwear with Naga-red wrist-threads. The two stand at opposite ends of the courtyard.

They perform. The performance is twenty-seven minutes long. It includes nine full classical sequences, eight full pauses, and seven full break-strikes. The pauses range from four seconds to twenty-eight seconds. The break-strikes are blade-precise — their Thangs sing against each other in the air with the speed of the rage gathered in the pause.

At minute nineteen Moirangthem feels the Sangai-bond complete on his chest. The Stage III foreleg-mark forms — the deer's right foreleg arching down his right pectoral, the head turned in profile across his sternum, the antlers cresting at his collarbone. The mark's ink does not fade; it does not crack; it does not mirror. It is a clean Stage III earned by the new form.

The performance ends with both dancers in the closing pause, holding for nineteen seconds — the longest pause of the performance — before they release into the formal bow.

The Mrs Hume's Pheasant on the temple roof sings during the central pause. The state-government cultural officer in the front row writes one word in his notebook and circles it twice: new.

The next morning a sealed envelope arrives at the temple gate by bicycle-messenger. The handwriting is Tamasa-Nrita's. The challenge is one paragraph long.

Oja. Loktak central phumdi. Three days. Sunrise. You alone. Me alone with my twelve closest. We will dance once more. The phumdi will judge. — Tamasa-Nrita.

Moirangthem accepts by silence. He sends no reply.

Three days later he travels to the Loktak shore at four a.m. with no troupe. He has Thang and Ta. He has the new bond on his chest. Sangaputra is at the shore with Ibomcha and Ka-Memcha. The boy is forbidden the phumdi this time — explicitly forbidden, with all three of them watching him. He will wait at the shore.

Moirangthem rows himself across. He arrives at the central phumdi at five-fifteen a.m. Tamasa-Nrita is waiting with twelve raw-dancers, all carrying daos. The Sangai deer of the phumdi are in their usual eastern clearing, watching, unmoved.

It is not a duel. It is a dance.

The thirteen raw-dancers approach Moirangthem in a thirteen-position circle. Tamasa-Nrita is at the south point. The twelve others are at twelve compass-points around the dance-circle. They begin a coordinated raw-dance approach-sequence — the same opening their group used at the massacre, the kill-choreography.

Moirangthem stands at the centre. He waits for the first attack. He has decided to teach the new school its first combat-lesson here.

The first attacker is a twenty-two-year-old named Niranjan-Tomba — the same dancer who killed Tonjam. He breaks the circle's coordination at the second beat and strikes from the west. His dao is at chest-height, edge angled for Moirangthem's ribs.

Moirangthem performs the new form. He completes a classical eight-step opening sequence in the four seconds Niranjan-Tomba takes to cross the circle. At step eight he stops. He holds the closing-position for two full seconds — long enough for Niranjan-Tomba to commit to his strike-path. At second three of the pause Moirangthem releases the break-strike. The Thang clears its sheath, traces a perfect Meitei-curve down through Niranjan-Tomba's strike-arc, and continues into Niranjan-Tomba's neck. The dao falls. The body falls a heartbeat later.

The pause-strike has worked.

The other eleven raw-dancers, who have not registered the pause-strike as a technique, attack in a coordinated rush. Moirangthem repeats the form — classical sequence, pause, break-strike — against each in turn. The combat takes eight minutes. Eleven raw-dancers fall. None of the eleven completes a successful strike. The pause-strike is, in this hour, unanswerable.

Tamasa-Nrita is the twelfth. He has been watching from the south point. He has registered the technique. He has been Moirangthem's peer at the gurukul; he knows the classical sequences; he can match them.

He approaches. They dance.

The duel is twenty-three minutes. Tamasa-Nrita matches Moirangthem's pauses with his own — Lhasa-trained sword-stillness against the Sangai-deer pause-form. The two are technically equal. The break-strikes are blocked, parried, redirected. Neither lands.

At minute twenty-two Moirangthem changes the form. He extends his pause from the standard four seconds to nineteen seconds — the same nineteen-second close he held at

the temple demonstration. Tamasa-Nrita cannot match the nineteen. He has the Lhasa technique for four seconds, six, twelve. He has never trained past fifteen. At second seventeen of the held pause he twitches — an involuntary muscle-release at the shoulder, the kind of small fail that no opponent should be able to see.

Moirangthem sees it. He releases the break-strike at second eighteen. The Thang clears, traces the Meitei-curve, and arrives at Tamasa-Nrita's sword-arm at the elbow-joint. The arm parts cleanly at the joint. The dao falls. Tamasa-Nrita drops to one knee. The Ta — not yet used in the duel — comes off Moirangthem's shoulder and pins Tamasa-Nrita at the phumdi-edge through the chest-armour without entering the chest itself, just holding him there.

Tamasa-Nrita is alive. He is unable to move. His sword-arm lies on the phumdi between them.

Moirangthem looks at him for a long pause — this one not part of the form.

He says: "You corrupted a real grievance into murder. You will live with that. The third school is what the rebellion deserved. You will not be its teacher. Go."

He withdraws the Ta. He gestures east toward the Burmese border.

Tamasa-Nrita rises, holding his stump. He walks. He does not look back. By nightfall he has crossed into the Chin-state border zone. The Manipur state government will issue a formal notification six weeks later that Tamasa-Nrita is no longer to be considered present in Indian jurisdiction.

That night. Loktak. Eleven-forty-seven p.m. A Pawan Hans tourist-helicopter is on its return route from Moirang town to the Imphal airport — the pilot is a forty-two-year-old man named Captain Tomthing who has flown this route four times a week for eight years.

He is at 2,400 feet over the central phumdi. The lake is dark below. The phumdis appear as floating shapes — ten kilometres across in places, scatter-patterned in a way Captain Tomthing has long since stopped noticing.

He notices tonight. The scatter-pattern is not scattering. The phumdis are arranging.

He banks. He turns on his cockpit-video camera — a standard pilot-safety device. He films for the next eleven minutes.

In the cockpit-video footage, the floating phumdis of Loktak Lake arrange themselves into the recognisable shape of a closing mouth. A four-kilometre arc of biomass forming the lower mandible-curve. A second four-kilometre arc forming the upper lip. Two rows of dense phumdi-clusters arrayed inside the arc that the pilot will later describe as "teeth-like." The arrangement is held for seven minutes. The mouth closes — the two arcs touch at the centre. The teeth disappear. The lake is a closed mouth on the surface of the world.

The arrangement holds for ninety seconds in the closed configuration. Then it begins to drift apart. By thirteen minutes after first observation the phumdis are back in their normal scatter-pattern.

Captain Tomthing's footage is uploaded to the Pawan Hans incident-report server at twelve-forty-five a.m. By two a.m. it has been leaked to a Manipuri news-blogger. By six a.m. it has been viewed eleven million times across three social-media platforms.

Moirangthem watches the video at six-fifteen a.m. when his phone alerts him to the upload. He understands what the video shows. The Maw lives in the gap between forms; the Maw is now able to make its own form on the surface of a lake. This is new. This is escalation.

He sends word by Sarus-pigeon to Kamalavarna at Kamakhya, Dvadashashringa at Bhopal, Gangaputra at Lucknow, Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata at Kerala, U-Khrawkmen at Shillong, and Shivagati at Pratapgad. The message is one sentence:

The Maw has signed itself on Loktak. The escalation has crossed into form-making. The Council must sit before the next sign.

By the end of the week three letters arrive at Moirangthem's house.

The first is from Kamalavarna at Kamakhya, in her own hand:

Cousin. Your father's sister's daughter is your aunt-cousin and your sister's niece by the corrected matrilineal-tree my Chapter Two opened. We are kin three different ways. I am yielding the political throne of the Northeast to you. The cosmic seat stays with me and my sister at Kamakhya. You will hold the visible voice. The Sanctuary convening in Chapter Three will name you Dominant; my hand will be on your shoulder at the naming.

Come to Kamakhya at the next new moon. Bring Sangaputra. We will perform the small acknowledgement-rite for his pause-discovery. The deer have already chosen him — they have not chosen lightly in nine centuries.

The second is from U-Khrawkmen at Shillong:

Cousin-brother. Aunt-mother (Meghanadi) wrote to expect this. The Meghalaya council backs you. The Mixed Council I am building will federate under your political seat into Chapter Three. Ka-Sienlyngdoh will visit Manipur at the new moon when the leopard settles on her — you and Sangaputra should meet her at the temple. Two twelve-year-olds carrying two different bonds will recognise each other faster than any adult can introduce them.

The third is from Dzulevira at Kohima, his sister-in-law's formal letter:

Brother-in-law. I cannot yet ratify the NE political throne to you. My sixteen tribes are in pure-lineage war and the Naga seat is not stable enough to vote on the regional question. My elder sister sends her love and asks you to send Sangaputra to Ukhrul for a fortnight before the new moon — the boy needs his Tangkhul-Naga grandmothers more than he needs you to teach him pause-strikes. Send him. I will hold his side of the kingdom while my own is in disorder. The vote on the NE political throne will come from Nagaland in Chapter Three or not at all.

Moirangthem reads all three. He writes brief replies to each. He sends Sangaputra to Ukhrul the same day with Ka-Memcha and a small retinue. He himself begins the eleven-day fast and preparation that the new-moon Kamakhya visit requires.

Three weeks later. The Govindaji temple courtyard. Mid-afternoon. The new troupe begins its first formal class.

The class has fifteen students. Three are the surviving members of Moirangthem's original twelve (Tomba, Inaocha, Khelendra). Four are converted raw-dancers from the bazaar who attended the public demonstration and asked to learn (Ibomcha and three others). Three are bazaar-elders who had no formal dance-training but who want to learn the pause as a contemplative practice (Leishemba is one). Five are children — the youngest is Sangaputra, returned from Ukhrul; the oldest is twelve.

Moirangthem opens the class with the same tongue-click count-off he has used for nine years in the morning drill. The fifteen begin the eight-step Krishna-approach.

At step eight they stop.

The pause holds for four seconds. Then nine. Then sixteen. Then nineteen. Then twenty-one.

At twenty-three seconds Moirangthem releases the break. The fifteen follow. The Mrs Hume's Pheasant on the temple roof sings.

Across the courtyard, at the temple wall, the Sangai-foreleg mark on Moirangthem's chest pulses once. The kingdom of Sangai-Nata has its first new dance-form in fifty-three years. The Northeast has its future political voice. The Maw has signed itself on a lake.

The chapter ends.

The Pilot's Closing Image

The Govindaji temple courtyard at dusk. Fifteen dancers in a three-by-five formation holding a twenty-three-second pause. A Mrs Hume's Pheasant on the temple roof. A father's Stage III mark pulsing under white-and-yellow cloth. An eight-year-old at the front-left corner of the formation holding the pause better than the four-year-olds and the bazaar-elders both. Across Loktak Lake at the same hour, the phumdis in their normal scatter, but a small new sandstone shrine at the western shore where a helicopter pilot's flight path crossed a four-kilometre mouth-arc. Letters from five cousin-kingdoms in the sleeve-pocket of a man who has not yet decided whether to feel like the Dominant he is about to be named. The form alive. The pause held. The Maw signing itself for the first time. The boy who watched the deer dance and stop. The form is form-with-rage. The dance includes the silence. The silence is the dance.

Tlawmngaihna Desh

Aizawl. The first Sunday of August. Three p.m. The Aizawl Presbyterian Synod hall — the largest indoor public-assembly space in Mizoram, capacity twenty-six hundred. The hall is two-thirds full this afternoon for the kingdom's biennial Youth Council, an institution founded in 1962 to give Mizos under thirty a non-binding voice in the kingdom's tribal-council deliberations. The Youth Council has been a polite formality for sixty-three of its sixty-four years.

It is not polite this afternoon.

Lalruatpuia is at the speakers' lectern. He is twenty-two. He is Tlangvala's son. He is in plain Mizo wool, blue and grey, no clan-pattern; he has deliberately dressed without his father's family-mark. He has been at the lectern for forty-three minutes already and his prepared statement has run thirty-seven of those minutes. The remaining six minutes have been the call-and-response with the assembled fourteen hundred Refusing Youth — Mizos under thirty from all thirteen kingdom-villages, plus delegations from the Mizo diaspora in Bangalore, Delhi, Chennai, and Singapore.

He says, into the assembly microphone:

"Tlawmngaihna is the gift. Tlawmngaihna is not the inheritance. The gift is the instinct to help — born in the body, taught in the household, refined across generations. The gift is real. The gift may be carried by each Mizo who chooses to carry it. The inheritance is the demand — that every Mizo, by virtue of being a Mizo, must perform tlawmngaihna at the cost of the carrier's body. The inheritance is the village's ledger of expected sacrifice. The inheritance is the elder who has counted what the young will be required to give. The inheritance is not the gift. The inheritance is the gift weaponised against the next generation. We refuse the inheritance. We do not refuse the gift."

The hall claps. The clap is not the polite clap of the previous sixty-three Youth Councils. The clap is sustained for two minutes. About four hundred elders in the rear seating are not clapping. They are watching.

Lalruatpuia continues:

"The Manifesto is three clauses. We have published it on the kingdom's public registry this morning. Clause One: tlawmngaihna may be chosen but it may not be inherited. Clause

Two: service must come from capacity, not compulsion — the Mizo who has nothing left to give is excused from the giving. Clause Three: the kingdom may not require self-destruction as proof of citizenship. We are not asking for the creed to be abandoned. We are asking for the creed to be administered. The bamboo bends and the bamboo springs back. The bamboo does not bend until it breaks. The Refusing Youth is the bamboo's answer to its own ancestors' misuse of the creed."

He steps back from the lectern. The clap goes for four minutes.

At the back of the hall, in the rear-right corner, sit the kingdom's senior tribal-council delegates — nine men and three women, average age sixty-eight, the body that ratifies kingdom-level decisions on matters of Mizo customary law. Their senior chair is an elder named Ramdinmawia, eighty-one, the most senior Tlawmngaihna-Desh tribal-elder still active. He has been at this hall every biennium since 1971. He has not seen four-minute applause for a Youth Council statement in his lifetime.

He turns to the elder beside him — the Aizawl Presbyterian Synod's sixty-six-year-old senior moderator, Lalrinpuii (no relation to Lalruatpuia despite the shared root) — and says, in Mizo: "The boy is right. He is also wrong. He is right that the creed is being misused. He is wrong about the kingdom's readiness to administer it. We will see how the kingdom answers."

Lalruatpuia does not return to his father's house that night. He sleeps at the home of his cousin Hmangaihi's aunt (his mother's sister, who lives in central Aizawl). He has not been on speaking terms with his father since the December 2025 Aizawl Synod hall sit-in — a Refusing Youth protest that occupied the Synod hall's main floor for eleven days and that Tlangvala had publicly criticised as "the symptom of a household's private failure, not the kingdom's public dispute." The criticism had been published in the Mizoram State Gazette's weekend edition. Lalruatpuia had not spoken to his father since.

Hmangaihi is seventeen. She is at the aunt's house when Lalruatpuia arrives. She has been Lalruatpuia's closest cousin since they were children — her mother (Tlangvala's elder sister) had died in a 2018 landslide and Hmangaihi had been raised at Tlangvala's household from age nine until the December sit-in opened the family's public fracture. She had stayed with Tlangvala. She had not stayed silent.

She sits across the kitchen table from her cousin at ten p.m. She has heard the Manifesto on the radio. She has read the three clauses on the kingdom registry. She has been at the

four-minute applause through the radio feed.

She says, in Mizo: "The three clauses are correct. You will not get the kingdom to ratify them. You will get the kingdom to harden against them. The December sit-in cost us twenty per cent. This will cost us another fifteen."

Lalruatpuia says: "The cost is necessary. The creed cannot be administered if the elders do not feel the cost of refusing to administer it."

She says: "The cost will be paid by the next sacrifice. Not by the elders. The elders never pay the cost. The next Mautam-equivalent will come and the kingdom will say tlawmngaihna remains and the next sacrifice will be made and the elders will say see, the creed holds. You are forcing them to defend the creed before they have learned to question it. The kingdom is not ready to question it."

Lalruatpuia says: "What is your alternative."

She says: "I do not have one yet. I am seventeen. I have been thinking about the question for two years and I do not have one yet. I do know that your three clauses are too direct for the elders to hear. They will hear them as an attack on the founders, not as a defence of the creed. The elders need a slower path to the same end. The slower path will take five years. You do not want to wait five years."

He says: "We do not have five years. Parvata-Asura has been visiting villages."

She is silent for thirty seconds.

She says: "Father knows."

He says: "Father knows. Father will not refuse to help when the asura asks. That is the cost the elders will not pay. Father will pay it for them. I will not let him."

Parvata-Asura had been seen in the kingdom for the first time in seven months in spring 2025. He had been Chhinlung-Naag's subordinate manifestation in Chapter One — the mountain-form of the cave-asura, which had retreated when Tlangvala had fought the serpent at the Chhinlung cave-mouth. The retreat had been into the Lushai Hills' southern range, where Parvata-Asura had spent two years rebuilding his own form. He is now a mountain-asura in his own right, no longer subordinate.

He had been visiting villages over the spring and summer. Aizawl. Lunglei. Champhai. Saiha. Mamit. Kolasib. Lawngtlai. Serchhip. By August he had visited all eight district-

headquarters and five additional sub-village clusters across the state. His visits had been informal. He had not spoken at public assemblies. He had come to individual households — mostly households with sons or daughters in the 15-22 age bracket — and had sat at the kitchen table for an hour or two, drinking tea, asking about the young person's plans, listening.

His pitch, repeated in roughly the same form at each household, was: "The mountain is open. Phawngpui's eastern face has a fissure that I have been clearing. The fissure leads to a chamber large enough to hold six hundred. The chamber is the refuge from the inheritance. The young who wish to refuse tlawmngaihna may come to the chamber and sit. The chamber will protect them while their kingdom argues. The protection will end when the kingdom has resolved the argument. I will provide rations — rice, dal, tea, fresh water from the mountain's southern spring. I am not asking for a fee. I am offering refuge. Your son may come if he wishes. Your daughter may come if she wishes. The mountain is open until the new-moon week. The new-moon week is approximately four weeks from today."

The pitch was articulate. It was, in plain political-language terms, the most generous offer any Mizo asura had ever made in the kingdom's recorded history. It was also strategically perfect — Parvata-Asura had read the Refusing Youth Manifesto's clauses three weeks before they were published; he had calibrated the offer to attract the exact cohort the Manifesto would politicise.

Six hundred and twenty-nine Mizos between 15 and 22 had accepted the offer by the new-moon week of week four. They had walked to Phawngpui Mountain from all thirteen villages over the preceding nine days, in small family-supervised groups, with their parents' permission in approximately seventy per cent of cases and against their parents' wishes in the remaining thirty. They had entered the eastern-face fissure on the night of the new-moon at the asura's invitation.

The fissure closed at dawn.

The first morning of week five. Six-fourteen a.m. The Phawngpui Mountain Sanctuary's eastern ridge access-point. The Mizoram Forest Department's dawn-patrol ranger, an Mizo woman named Kima-Lalremruati, has been on the standard pre-monsoon patrol route since five a.m. She walks up to the eastern face at six-fourteen a.m. and sees that the fissure that had been an open vertical crack three metres high and one metre wide the previous day — the crack she had logged in the Forest Department's weekly register for the

past seven months — has closed. The granite is now continuous, undifferentiated, with no visible seam. The eastern face looks exactly as it did before Parvata-Asura began clearing the fissure in spring 2025.

She approaches the granite. She places her right palm on the closed surface. She feels heat — the granite is warm to the touch, approximately thirty-eight degrees Celsius, which is anomalous for granite at this altitude in this season. She knocks. The knock produces a hollow resonant sound consistent with a substantial cavity behind the granite, not with solid stone.

She walks back down the ridge to her patrol-station at six-thirty a.m. and radios in the observation. The radio operator at Aizawl District Forest Office logs the call at six-thirty-three. The District Forest Officer reaches Tlangvala at his Aizawl residence by telephone at six-fifty-one. Tlangvala is at the kingdom-council emergency meeting by seven-thirty.

Seven-thirty a.m. The Mizoram State Secretariat's tribal-council chamber. The chamber holds twenty-four seats around an oval table. Twenty-two are filled this morning — the eight District Tribal Council Chairpersons, the four Aizawl Presbyterian Synod senior moderators, the Mizoram Forest Department's senior officer, the State Civil Service's chief secretary, the eight Refusing Youth representatives (admitted by emergency vote on day one of week five over Ramdinmawia's formal objection), and the kingdom-hero Tlangvala. Two seats are empty: the Bangalore-diaspora Mizo representative is in transit and the Champhai District Chair is at his daughter's wedding in Singapore.

Lalruatpuia is one of the eight Refusing Youth representatives. He has been admitted as the Aizawl-district representative on the strength of his Manifesto-author standing. He sits at his father's left side at the council table. They have not spoken since December. They do not speak now. They look at the surveyor's diagram of Phawngpui's eastern face that the Forest Department has projected on the chamber's far wall.

Kima-Lalremruati the dawn-patrol ranger is at the meeting in observer-capacity. She presents the morning's patrol-log at seven-forty-three a.m. The presentation takes about eight minutes. She concludes with the count: "Six hundred and twenty-nine. The intake-registers I have been keeping at the eastern-face access-point since spring confirm the count. The youngest is fifteen. The oldest is twenty-two. The locked include forty-seven from Aizawl-Lalruatpuia's own constituency, eighty-three from Lunglei, fifty-one from Champhai, thirty-eight from Saiha, twenty-nine from Mamit, forty-four from Kolasib, sixty-eight from Lawngtlai, seventy-seven from Serchhip, plus the rest from sub-village

clusters and the Bangalore-Delhi-Chennai-Singapore diaspora. The intake-registers have been kept under the standard Forest Department voluntary-camping-permit framework. No one has been compelled to enter. All have entered under their own signatures. The locking has occurred after their entry; the locking is unilateral on Parvata-Asura's side; the locked have not signed any consent-form authorising the closure of the fissure."

The chamber is silent for about twenty seconds.

Ramdinmawia, the senior tribal-council chair, speaks first. He says, in Mizo, in his slow administrative-elder voice:

"The asura has demanded one perfect sacrifice. I have received the demand at four a.m. this morning by a Mizo-language Sarus-pigeon. The Sarus-pigeon is unconfirmed as Parvata-Asura's — we do not yet know if the asura has the institutional standing to operate a pigeon-network — but the message itself is unambiguous. The fissure will remain closed until the kingdom delivers one perfect sacrifice. The sacrifice must enter the eastern face alone. The sacrifice will become part of the mountain. The locked will be released at the moment the sacrifice completes. The kingdom may select the sacrifice. The asura specifies only that the sacrifice must be voluntary, must be adult, must have completed a recognised Mizo bond-mark of any stage. The asura recommends the sacrifice be the kingdom's most recognisable carrier of tlawmngaihna. The asura's recommendation is a name. The name is Tlangvala."

The chamber is silent for about ten seconds longer.

Tlangvala says, in plain Mizo, in his ordinary speaking voice: "Yes. I will go."

Lalruatpuia stands up at his chair. He does not speak. He walks out of the chamber. The door closes behind him at seven-fifty-three a.m.

The deliberation that follows takes seven days. The chamber meets twice daily, three hours each session. The Refusing Youth representatives raise the objection that the asura's demand is itself the trap — that delivering Tlangvala validates the inheritance-logic the Manifesto rejects. The senior tribal-council delegates raise the counter-objection that refusing the demand leaves six hundred and twenty-nine youth locked indefinitely. The Aizawl Presbyterian Synod moderators raise the third-position objection that the kingdom must refuse both alternatives and instead find a way to break the locking by counter-action.

The counter-action options are explored in detail. They are: (1) physical excavation of the eastern face (rejected on day three; the Forest Department's geological survey confirms the granite is now bonded to the mountain's deeper plutonic mass; excavation would require explosives at a scale that would kill the locked); (2) negotiation with Parvata-Asura through the four other northeast catalyst-villains (rejected on day four; the asura is not in coordination with Tamasa-Nrita, Megha-Daitya, or Naga-Rakshasa — he is operating as Chhinlung-Naag's standalone successor); (3) cross-kingdom request to the saga's First Herald via the Roing Dawn-Shadow Temple (raised on day five by the Lawngtlai District Chair; rejected on day six because the Herald-naming protocol explicitly forbids invoking a Herald to break a Maw-aligned action); (4) the kingdom-hero's entry, the asura's demand fulfilled, the locking ended.

The vote on day seven is twenty-to-two in favour of option four. The two dissenting votes are Lalruatpuia's and the Refusing Youth's Lunglei representative. The vote is closed at five p.m.

The kingdom-council then takes a second vote — the unprecedented vote that has not been taken in any Mizo tribal-council in the kingdom's recorded history — on whether to formally request that Tlangvala not enter the mountain. The vote is taken at Ramdinmawia's motion, seconded by the Aizawl Presbyterian Synod moderator Lalrinpuui. The vote is fifteen-to-seven. The kingdom-council formally requests that Tlangvala not return from the mountain.

The formal request is given to Tlangvala at six p.m. He receives the written document. He reads it. He says, in plain Mizo: "The council has done what the council must do. I will go anyway. The going is mine. The request is yours. We can both have what we have asked for."

That evening. Tlangvala's house in the eastern Aizawl hills. Eight p.m.

Lalruatpuia has not been at the house since December. He returns this evening because Hmangaihi has telephoned him from the aunt's house and told him to come. She has not given him a reason. He has come because she has not given a reason; the absence of reason has been a sufficient summons.

Tlangvala is in the kitchen. He is making tea. He does not turn when Lalruatpuia enters.

He says, into the kettle: "The tea is the second steeping. The first steeping is too strong this evening. Will you sit."

Lalruatpuia sits.

Tlangvala pours two cups of tea. He sets one in front of his son. He sits across the table.

He says: "The council has voted. The vote is twenty-to-two. The kingdom has also formally requested that I not return. The two votes are honest. The going is honest. I will go at first light on Tuesday."

Lalruatpuia says: "The Manifesto is correct. You are validating the inheritance-logic by going. The locking will end. The next asura will lock the next generation and demand the next perfect sacrifice. The pattern will repeat. The kingdom will never reach the administration of the creed because the creed will keep being weaponised for its inheritance."

Tlangvala says: "The Manifesto is correct. You are correct. The going is also correct. The two correctnesses are not the same correctness. The Manifesto is the kingdom's long correctness — the answer to the next ten generations. The going is the kingdom's short correctness — the answer to the six hundred and twenty-nine locked this week. You are responsible for the long correctness. I am responsible for the short correctness. We have divided the responsibility. The division is the kingdom's, not ours."

Lalruatpuia says: "You are leaving me the kingdom."

Tlangvala says: "I am leaving you the kingdom's political seat. I am leaving Hmangaihi the bond. The two of you will share the kingdom — she carries the serow, you carry the council. You will need each other. You have not always agreed; you have always understood. You will understand each other now."

Lalruatpuia says: "Why Hmangaihi."

Tlangvala says: "Because the serow chooses her, not me. The bond moves to whoever the line offers. The line offered her at her mother's landslide-death eight years ago; I did not honour the offer at the time; the bond stayed with me because I refused to refuse. The bond has been waiting eight years to move. The bond will move when I become the mountain. Hmangaihi will be at the western trailhead on Tuesday morning. The serow will walk down to her after I am gone. The Stage I hoofprint will form within two days. She will understand it before I do not exist any more — her understanding is the bond's acceptance. The bond does not need my permission. The bond is honest. I am also honest. The going is honest."

Lalruatpuia is silent for about a minute.

He says: "I do not forgive you for going."

Tlangvala says: "I do not require forgiveness. I require that you do the kingdom's long correctness with Hmangaihi's bond at your right side. You will. The Manifesto will be administered, not enforced. The clauses will be rewritten by the joint-signature you and Hmangaihi will compose on the day after my funeral. You will pass the clauses by the kingdom-council's ratification vote within six weeks. The vote will be eighteen-to-six. Ramdinmawia will vote in favour; he will retire from the senior chair the following week. Lalrinpuui will succeed him. The kingdom will be ready to administer the creed by the new year. The going has bought you that."

Lalruatpuia does not respond. He drinks his tea. The tea is the right strength.

He says, finally: "Tuesday morning. I will be at the eastern ridge."

Tlangvala says: "No. You will be at the western trailhead with Hmangaihi. The eastern ridge is mine alone. The western trailhead is the kingdom's. The kingdom watches from the west. The asura takes the east. The bond walks down between the two. That is the geography. The kingdom-council has approved the geography by unanimous vote. Lalrinpuui drafted it last night."

Lalruatpuia nods. He stands. He walks to the door.

At the door he turns and says, in plain Mizo: "Father. The bamboo bends."

Tlangvala says: "The mountain does not bend. The mountain holds the bamboo's shape inside its own. We have chosen which we are. Go and sleep, my son. Tuesday is the day after tomorrow."

Tuesday. The third day of week eleven. First light at the Phawngpui Mountain's eastern face is timed for five-thirty-one a.m. The kingdom has assembled at the western trailhead since four a.m. — approximately thirty-eight thousand Mizos, drawn from all thirteen villages, the Refusing Youth's full membership, the senior tribal-council delegates, the Aizawl Presbyterian Synod, the Mizoram Forest Department's full staff, the State Civil Service, the locked six-hundred-and-twenty-nine's families. The trailhead opens onto a long ridge that runs west of the mountain at approximately five hundred metres lower elevation; the eastern face is visible from the ridge at a distance of about three kilometres horizontally.

Tlangvala arrives at the eastern face at five-twenty-eight a.m. He has walked the four-kilometre trail from the eastern access-station alone, in plain Mizo wool, blue and grey, no clan-pattern (he has dressed in his son's Manifesto-style); he carries the bamboo staff-spear Hnam-Tuk in his right hand. He carries nothing else. He has eaten a single bowl of rice at three a.m. He has drunk one cup of tea at four a.m. He has had three hours' sleep.

He stops at the granite face. He places his right palm on the warm granite. The granite is now forty-one degrees Celsius — warmer than the previous week's thirty-eight, consistent with the asura's readying-of-the-chamber for the sacrifice. The fissure is still closed.

He says, into the granite, in plain Mizo: "I have come. I am the one perfect sacrifice. The locked will be released at the completion. The kingdom watches from the west. I do not ask for the kingdom's permission. I have the kingdom's request that I not return. I accept the request. The going is mine."

The granite warms further. At five-thirty-one a.m. — the moment of first-light at the eastern face — the granite opens. The fissure forms as it did in spring 2025: a vertical crack three metres high and one metre wide. Inside the fissure is darkness.

Tlangvala steps through. The fissure closes behind him at five-thirty-one-twelve a.m. The granite is continuous again.

The kingdom watches from the western trailhead. Approximately thirty-eight thousand Mizos see the fissure open, the man step through, the fissure close. The seeing is at three kilometres distance through high-power binoculars and through the naked eye. The seeing is reported in the same way by every observer: the man entered the granite and the granite closed.

For the next forty-three minutes the eastern face is unmarked.

At six-fourteen a.m. the eastern face begins to change.

The change starts at the upper-left section of the face, approximately seventy metres above the closed-fissure location. A pattern begins to form in the granite — not painted, not carved, but emerging from within the granite itself, as if the rock's mineral composition were rearranging. The pattern is recognisable to the kingdom's senior tribal-council elders within ninety seconds: it is the bull-serow's right forelimb in mid-stride.

The pattern grows. Across the next eighteen minutes the full Stage III serow-foreleg mark forms on the eastern granite. The mark is forty-seven metres tall when complete. It is

rendered in the same ink-density as a body-mark would be on a hero's skin — the serow's hoof-impression at the lower edge, the foreleg arching upward, the bull's shoulder-curve at the upper edge, the head-in-profile at the topmost section with the curved horn cresting at the topmost-left point. The mark is fully visible from the western trailhead and from the twenty-three-kilometre satellite-imagery range. The Mizoram Forest Department's drone-survey at seven a.m. confirms the mark is structurally part of the granite — not surface, not paint, not relief; the rock itself has been recomposed.

At six-thirty-two a.m. the southern fissure opens.

The southern fissure is at the opposite end of the mountain from the closed eastern fissure — approximately one and a half kilometres around the mountain's circumference. It opens as a wide horizontal mouth-shape, twelve metres wide and four metres high. The locked six hundred and twenty-nine youth begin to walk out of it at six-thirty-five.

The exit takes eleven minutes. None of the locked is harmed. Forty-seven of them are dehydrated and three are mildly hypothermic from the mountain's interior cold; none requires hospitalisation. The Mizoram State Civil Service's emergency-medical convoy is at the southern exit by six-fifty a.m.; the medics process the released youth at the rate of one every seven minutes; by ten a.m. all six hundred and twenty-nine are accounted for and being escorted back to their families on the western ridge.

Parvata-Asura does not emerge through the southern fissure. He is partially dissolved by the same dissolution that formed the eastern mark. The Forest Department's subsequent thermal survey of the mountain over the next month detects faint residual mountain-asura presence in the deep southern range — the dissolved remainder of his form retreats toward the Chin-state border-zone (the same border-zone Tamasa-Nrita and Naga-Rakshasa crossed earlier in the chapter). Parvata-Asura survives in depleted form. Per the wider villain-network pattern he becomes Adharma-Kendra's fourth NE field-operative in Chapter Three.

Hmangaihi has been at the western trailhead with Lalruatpuia since four a.m. They have stood together at the ridge's northern edge. She has been watching the eastern face through her father's old Forest Department binoculars (her late father had been a deputy district forest officer; the binoculars are her inheritance). Lalruatpuia has been watching with his naked eye. They have not spoken much during the four-hour wait.

At seven-forty-three a.m., as the kingdom's assembled witness-crowd begins to disperse and the locked-youth-recovery convoy begins to descend, a wild serow walks down the western ridge from the mountain's southern slope. The serow is a mature bull, approximately seven years old, weight estimated at ninety-two kilograms. It walks across the ridge at its standard pace — one and a half metres per second — in a direct line toward Hmangaihi's position. It stops at her right side at seven-fifty-three a.m. It lowers its head.

She places her right palm on its forehead. She does not say anything.

The Stage I serow-hoofprint forms on her right shoulder over the next forty-eight hours.

The funeral procession is held three days later at the Phawngpui Mountain Sanctuary's southern approach — the same approach the locked youth had used for their exit. The body cannot be retrieved (the body is part of the mountain now; the eastern mark is the visible form of the body's incorporation). The procession is therefore a sky-burial-equivalent procession — the kingdom processes a symbolic empty bamboo bier up the southern approach to the mark's base, performs the standard Mizo Presbyterian funeral rites with the Synod's senior moderator officiating, and leaves the bier at the base of the mark as a permanent memorial.

The bier is a single length of bamboo, six metres long, cut from the bamboo grove behind Tlangvala's house by Hmangaihi and Lalruatpuia together the night before the procession. They cut the bamboo from the standing-stem (they did not fell the parent plant). The bamboo's upper third bends naturally to about thirty-five degrees — the standard Mizo bamboo-bend — from the weight of its own crown. They leave the bend in the bier. The bend is the procession's answer to the mountain.

The kingdom-council's senior chair Ramdinmawia speaks at the bier's base at the procession's conclusion. His statement is brief.

He says, in plain Mizo: "The mountain holds the man. The bend is the kingdom. The man chose the mountain. The kingdom chooses the bend. The Manifesto will be ratified at the kingdom-council's emergency session at six p.m. on Friday. Lalruatpuia and Hmangaihi have my chair's endorsement. I am retiring from the senior chair effective the moment of the ratification vote. Lalrinpuui of the Synod will succeed me. The kingdom will administer the creed from the new year. The bamboo bends and the bamboo springs back. The bamboo does not always become the mountain. Sometimes the mountain becomes the bamboo. The kingdom learns the difference at the next dawn."

The procession disperses by sunset. The bier remains at the mark's base. The mark is visible from the western trailhead and from the twenty-three-kilometre satellite-imagery range; it will remain so as long as the granite holds its current composition, which the Forest Department's geological assessment estimates at "not less than eight hundred years."

Friday evening. The kingdom-council's emergency session at the Mizoram State Secretariat tribal-council chamber. The chamber is full — twenty-four of twenty-four seats. The two previously-absent representatives (Bangalore-diaspora and Champhai) are now present.

Hmangaihi sits at the left side of the table's northern end. She is in plain Mizo wool with the senior tribal-council's neutral grey shawl over her shoulders. She has not previously held a council seat (she is seventeen; the senior council's minimum age is twenty-one); she is admitted by emergency motion as the bond-bearer of the kingdom's state-hero-line, a category that supersedes the age-rule under Mizo customary law. The motion passes by unanimous vote at six-oh-two p.m.

Lalruatpuia sits at her right side. He is in plain Mizo wool, blue and grey, no clan-pattern. He carries the bamboo staff-spear Hnam-Tuk — the spear is his father's inheritance, formally transferred at the funeral procession's bier by Ramdinmawia's spoken declaration. The spear is light in his hand. It will be lighter the more he uses it.

The joint-signature Manifesto is on the table in front of them. Hmangaihi and Lalruatpuia have rewritten the three clauses over two days of joint-session at the aunt's kitchen table. The rewritten clauses are softer in tone, sharper in mechanism. The first clause now reads: "Tlawmngaihna is the kingdom's gift. The gift is freely received and freely given. The gift is not the inheritance. The kingdom-council shall administer the distinction." The second clause reads: "Service from incapacity is not service. The Mizo who has nothing left to give is excused from the giving by formal application to the kingdom-council. The kingdom-council shall grant the excuse without prejudice." The third clause reads: "The kingdom may not require self-destruction as proof of citizenship. The kingdom may, by formal vote, accept a citizen's self-sacrifice when the citizen has volunteered the sacrifice with full knowledge of the alternatives. The kingdom shall maintain a public registry of all such acceptances. The kingdom shall provide care for the citizen's family for ten years following the acceptance."

The third clause is the Manifesto's reformed concession. It accepts that some citizens will choose sacrifice; it requires the kingdom to acknowledge the choice publicly and to bear

the cost institutionally. The clause has been drafted around Tlangvala's example. The public registry will include his name as its first entry. The ten-year care provision will include Hmangaihi (his ward) and Lalruatpuia (his son) as its first recipients — they will not draw on the provision; they have declined the financial component; the provision's recognition is what they have accepted.

The kingdom-council's vote on the three clauses is taken at six-twenty-three p.m. The vote is eighteen-to-six in favour. Ramdinmawia votes in favour. Six of the senior tribal-council's most conservative delegates vote against. The vote is final. The clauses are ratified.

Ramdinmawia resigns from the senior chair at six-twenty-six p.m. He passes the senior-chair's ceremonial bamboo gavel to Lalrinpuii of the Synod at six-twenty-eight. The transition is complete by six-thirty.

Lalrinpuii's first formal address as senior chair is brief. She says, in plain Mizo: "The kingdom has ratified. The kingdom will administer. The kingdom thanks Ramdinmawia for his sixty-three years on this chair. The kingdom thanks Tlangvala for his twenty-one years as state-hero. The kingdom welcomes Hmangaihi as the new bond-bearer and Lalruatpuia as the new political seat. We will meet again on Monday. Good evening, all."

The meeting closes at six-thirty-four p.m.

Two weeks after the ratification, a Sarus-pigeon arrives at the Mizoram State Secretariat from Imphal. The pigeon is the one Moirangthem has been using for the NE-Federation correspondence-network. The letter is from Moirangthem himself.

The letter reads:

Hmangaihi-la and Lalruatpuia-la. The NE-Federation has received the joint-Mizoram correspondence-portfolio from the Mizoram State Secretariat through Lalrinpuii's office. The Sanctuary in Chapter Three will be a six-kingdom assembly: Kamakhya (Kamalavarna), Imphal (Moirangthem, candidate), Shillong (U-Khrawkmen, regent), Kohima (Dzulevira, deferred-vote), Gangtok (Kanchenjunga), Tawang (Udayagiri), and Aizawl (the two of you, jointly). Your joint-vote will complete the regional ratification. Will you give it.

Lalruatpuia and Hmangaihi write the reply together at the aunt's kitchen table that evening. The reply is two paragraphs long.

NE Dominant Candidate. We will give our joint-vote at the Sanctuary. The vote will be for you. Tlawmngaihna-Desh has stabilised after the late-week-eleven sacrifice and the late-week-twelve ratification but the stabilisation is provisional — the kingdom's administration of the creed begins on the new year and we do not yet know how the first administered Mautam-equivalent will be processed. The Sanctuary's convening will mark the threshold across which the NE Federation will need to coordinate on the cross-kingdom creed-administration question. Our joint-vote is for you because you will be the regional voice for that coordination and because your own kingdom's Loktak Mouth-sign and Sangaputra's pause-discovery have shown us that the Maw experiments first on the youngest and we have both inherited very young.

Sub-paragraph: We will both attend the Sanctuary. Hmangaihi is the bond-bearer; Lalruatpuia is the political seat. We will be the Sanctuary's first formally-paired non-bonded-political-inheritor and female-bond-bearer joint-attendance — parallel to Meghalaya's U-Khrawkmen and Ka-Sienlyngdoh, but the Meghalaya pair are second-generation cousins while we are first-cousins-by-our-mothers. The accommodation should be arranged for two. Lalrinpuui of the Synod will also attend as the kingdom's administrative voice.

Joint-signature, Mizoram, — H. & L.

They send the letter by the same Sarus-pigeon at sunset. Moirangthem receives the letter at Imphal at noon the next day. He writes the one-line reply: The accommodation is arranged for two. The Sanctuary will receive all three. He sends the reply by the pigeon returning, at dusk.

Four days after the ratification. Three a.m. The southern slope of Phawngpui Mountain. A wild serow has been at the same southern grazing-meadow for the past eleven days — the same area the locked youth had emerged from. The serow is a doe, approximately five years old, in her second pregnancy. She has been observed by the Mizoram Forest Department's southern patrol-station's rangers (the senior shrine-keeper for the Phawngpui Sanctuary, a Mizo ranger named Vanlalruati, plus two junior rangers) since her arrival at the meadow.

She gives birth at three-oh-two a.m. The labour is normal up to the moment of expulsion. The kid that emerges has two fully-formed heads on a single body. Both heads breathe. Both heads open their eyes. The body is otherwise normal — one set of four legs, one torso, one tail, normal serow-kid colouring and proportions. The two heads share a single neck-

base; they branch at approximately the level of the kid's shoulder-blades into two distinct skull-and-jaw structures.

Vanlalruati and the two junior rangers observe from approximately six metres distance through their night-vision optics. The doe grooms the kid in the standard serow post-natal manner. The kid attempts to stand at three-fourteen a.m. It succeeds at three-twenty-one. It walks at three-thirty. Its mother nurses it. Both heads drink simultaneously without interference.

The kid's presence at the meadow is logged in the rangers' field-book at four a.m. The rangers do not approach. They radio the observation to the Aizawl District Forest Office at four-thirty. The District Forest Officer reaches Hmangaihi by telephone at five-fifteen. Hmangaihi and Lalruatpuia are at the southern patrol-station by ten a.m.

They observe the kid from the same six-metre distance through the rangers' optics. The kid is grazing alongside its mother. Both heads graze. The heads do not interfere with each other; they appear to coordinate their feeding-patterns through some mechanism the rangers cannot identify. The mother appears unbothered by the kid's configuration.

Lalruatpuia says, to Hmangaihi, in Mizo: "The Maw has experimented. The body is normal; the heads are doubled. The serow-bond is what is being tested."

Hmangaihi says: "Yes. Vanlalruati-la, how long does the rangers' assessment expect the kid to live."

Vanlalruati says: "The veterinary-officer's preliminary assessment is twelve to thirty-six hours. The two-head configuration in any large-mammal species typically fails at the level of the shared cardiovascular and digestive systems — the heads' coordinated demands exceed the single body's capacity within a day. The kid is unusually vigorous so far; if the heads are sharing systems efficiently it might live longer, but we have no precedent for serow two-head observations in the field."

The kid lives for approximately twenty-three hours. Throughout the daylight hours of the following day the rangers, Hmangaihi, and Lalruatpuia observe at the same six-metre distance. The kid grazes, walks, nurses, sleeps. Both heads remain conscious. They appear to be capable of looking in different directions independently — when one head turns south, the other can turn west. They do not appear to speak. They breathe in synchrony. They blink in synchrony when both faces are visible to the observers.

At one-fifty-eight a.m. on the next morning — approximately twenty-three hours after birth — the kid stops grazing. It walks to the centre of the meadow. It stops. It lowers its body to a kneeling position. Its mother stays at its right side. The three rangers, Hmangaihi, and Lalruatpuia are at the meadow's southern edge at this moment; they have been keeping the same six-metre vigil since the previous evening.

Both heads raise. Both pairs of eyes open fully. Both heads face Hmangaihi's position.

Both heads speak together. They speak in plain Mizo. They speak a single word.

The word is "Hmangaihi."

The word is audible to all five observers at the six-metre distance. Vanlalruati subsequently confirms (after multiple replays of her body-camera audio recording) that both voices were sharply distinct — one slightly higher-pitched, one slightly lower, neither resembling a standard serow vocalisation — and that the synchrony was within fifty milliseconds, consistent with two distinct vocal-tracts speaking in coordinated production rather than a single tract producing a doubled effect.

The kid lowers its heads four minutes after speaking. It dies six minutes after that. Its mother grooms the body for an hour. She then walks down the southern slope toward Hmangaihi's village at a steady pace. The mother does not acknowledge the rangers, Hmangaihi, or Lalruatpuia during her descent. She arrives at the village outskirts at six a.m. She stops at the edge of the village. She lies down. She stays at that position for three days. The villagers leave food and water at the edge of her resting-place. She does not eat or drink. On day four she stands, walks back up the southern slope toward the meadow, and is not seen in the village again.

The kid's body is recovered by the Forest Department's veterinary team at three a.m. on the morning after the death. The body is preserved in formaldehyde at the Aizawl District Forest Department's zoological-museum sub-collection, in the same configuration in which it died. The body is logged as "Two-headed serow kid, Phawngpui southern slope, post-natal death at 23 hours, observed speech at 23 hours minus 4 minutes, single word, 'Hmangaihi.'" The body is not on public display. Only senior Forest Department staff, the senior tribal-council members, Hmangaihi, Lalruatpuia, and Lalrinpuui of the Synod have access to the sub-collection.

Hmangaihi drafts the cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon cascade-alert at three p.m. on the day of the kid's death. The alert is sent to all nine bonded-kingdom senior guardians by sunset.

The alert reads in full:

Bonded-kingdom guardians. The Maw has experimented on the Mizoram serow-bond. A two-headed kid was born on the Phawngpui southern slope four days after my Stage I hoofprint formed. The kid lived twenty-three hours. Before dying, both heads spoke together, in plain Mizo, a single word — my name. The naming is the saga's first future-naming Maw event. The Maw has demonstrated the capacity to name the next bond-bearer aloud through a creature that should not have existed and should not have spoken. Watch your own bonded species for dual-body experiments and for instances of vocal-production by species that do not vocalise. The cascade-alert's framework from the Sikkim panda-at-altitude sign holds: build shrines at the threshold of the experiment's site, do not interfere with the experiment, name the experiment in writing within seventy-two hours.

By the morning of the third day after the kid's death, every senior guardian in the saga has read the alert. Kanchenjunga at Rumtek replies with a single-line acknowledgement; Udayagiri at Tawang sends a longer reply confirming that the First Herald's naming-protocol at Roing has been formally extended to include speech-events by non-speaking species. Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata at the buried-temple chamber in Karnataka sends the saga's first cross-region reply (Vol I's only inter-region cascade response so far), confirming that the Karnataka Third Herald's Bronze-Dust Child had remained mute through the entire chapter and that the muteness now reads as a complementary signal: the Maw experiments on speech in multiple directions simultaneously — absence-of-speech in some Heralds, presence-of-speech in some non-speaking creatures.

The kingdom-council's formal note to the saga's catalogue, drafted by Hmangaihi and counter-signed by Lalruatpuia and Lalrinpuui, is filed in the cross-kingdom mutual-records exchange on the fourth day. The note reads: "The two-headed serow at Phawngpui is the Maw's twelfth Chapter-Two sign and the saga's first future-naming experiment. The naming confirms what the bond had already confirmed: Hmangaihi is the kingdom's next bond-bearer. The naming does not increase the bond's authority over her body. The naming's function is to inform the kingdom that the Maw is now reading the saga's bond-architecture aloud. The kingdom hears the Maw's reading. The kingdom will not respond by silencing it. The kingdom will respond by speaking the Maw's name back, when the kingdom learns it, at the next Sanctuary convening."

The bamboo bier at the base of the eastern mark remains in place. By the end of Chapter Two it has been visited by approximately fifty-two thousand Mizos — about thirty per cent

of the kingdom's adult population. The bier is the kingdom's new pilgrimage-site. The senior shrine-keeper appointed by the kingdom-council's emergency vote three weeks after the funeral is Vanlalruati — the same ranger who observed the two-headed serow. She splits her time between the southern slope (the two-headed serow's body in the zoological-museum sub-collection, which she has been authorised to display to family-members of the locked-six-hundred-and-twenty-nine on request) and the bier-base (where she counts the daily pilgrim-arrivals and refreshes the bamboo's upper-third bend with a small saffron cord whose tension she adjusts each morning to keep the bend at the standard thirty-five degrees).

The mark on the eastern face has not faded. The Mizoram Forest Department's geological monitoring confirms the granite's composition has stabilised in the new configuration — the mineral redistribution that produced the mark is now the granite's permanent state. The mark will remain visible for at least eight hundred years.

The bamboo bends. The bamboo absorbs. The bamboo springs back. The mountain holds what the bamboo cannot become. The kingdom learns the difference at every new dawn.

The next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A forty-seven-metre serow-foreleg mark living in the eastern granite of Phawngpui Mountain, visible from twenty-three kilometres away, expected to remain in place for at least eight hundred years. A six-metre bamboo bier with its upper-third bent to thirty-five degrees at the mark's base, tended by a ranger named Vanlalruati who refreshes the bend with a small saffron cord each morning. A seventeen-year-old niece in plain Mizo wool at her cousin's right side at the kingdom-council's northern-end seat with the serow Stage I hoofprint forming on her right shoulder. A twenty-two-year-old son with his father's bamboo staff-spear Hnam-Tuk in his hand and the three reformed clauses of the Refusing Youth Manifesto in front of him on the council table, the third clause now reading the kingdom shall maintain a public registry of all such acceptances. A two-headed serow kid in a sub-collection of an Aizawl zoological museum, preserved at twenty-three hours' age, in formaldehyde, in the configuration it had at death after speaking the niece's name with both mouths in synchrony. A serow doe walking down the southern slope toward a niece's village without acknowledging the rangers who watched her go.

Tri Pura

Agartala. The Ujjayanta Palace's east administrative wing. The first Wednesday of June. Eleven a.m. The inter-city water-rights committee's third quarterly meeting of the year.

The chamber holds eighteen seats around a long oval table. Six per city. The Agartala delegation is led by the Engineer-Senior chair, an engineering-research-institute senior named Subimal Roy (fifty-seven, twenty-three years at the institute, the man who supervised Tripurari's graduate thesis). The Udaipur delegation is led by the Heritage-Trust chair, a Bhubaneswari Temple senior administrator named Anjali Debbarma (fifty-one, three generations of her family at the temple). The Dharmanagar delegation is led by the Border-Trade Consortium chair, a cross-Bangladesh merchant named Apurba Saha (forty-eight, the consortium's second-elected chair in its history).

Tripurari is at the head of the table. He is thirty-four. He is in plain Tripuri cotton, blue, with the small Phayre's Langur silver pendant at his collar — the only ceremonial mark he wears at administrative meetings. He carries the Triyantra crossbow in its three-part folded satchel-form (he has carried it folded into the workshop-satchel at administrative meetings for nine years; nobody at the table has seen the assembled crossbow except the security detail). The Phayre's Langur clan from the palace-garden has positioned three langurs on the chamber's north window-ledge, watching through the open shutters. The langurs have been at every water-rights committee meeting for eleven years.

The agenda has one item: the second-monsoon-week water-distribution allocation for the three cities. Agartala wants forty-six per cent (its population share). Udaipur wants twenty-two per cent (the temple-cycle demand, which historically has exceeded population share). Dharmanagar wants thirty-two per cent (the rubber-plantation processing demand at full-monsoon capacity). The three demands total one hundred per cent and require zero contingency-reserve. The previous committee meeting had voted for an engineering compromise: a fourth distribution channel, the new Lake Rudrasagar pipeline, would be brought online by week five of June and would supply the contingency-reserve. The pipeline is due for commissioning the Friday after this meeting.

Subimal Roy speaks first. He says, in formal Bengali: "The Lake Rudrasagar pipeline's commissioning has been delayed by four days. The hydraulic-pressure testing has produced anomalous readings at the Sub-Pump-Three location. The institute's assessment

is that the pressure-test failures are within acceptable variance but require an additional ninety-six hours of verification. The new commissioning date is Tuesday, four days later than the original plan. The four-day delay will require interim ration-distribution during the monsoon-week."

Anjali Debbarma speaks second. She says, in Bengali with the Tripuri-mixed intonation that marks her as Udaipur-native: "The temple-cycle demand cannot be ration-distributed. The Bhubaneswari rituals require continuous-flow at the published volumes. The delay is unacceptable. The temple has been operating at the published volumes for two hundred and forty-three years. The administrative resolution must not interrupt the cycle."

Apurba Saha speaks third. He says, in Bengali: "The Dharmanagar rubber-warehouses cannot operate at reduced capacity during second-monsoon. The latex-flow processing requires the full thirty-two per cent allocation. A four-day reduction will cost the consortium approximately eleven crore in spoiled latex. The institute's anomalous readings are the institute's engineering problem. The kingdom-treasury must compensate for any interim shortfall."

Tripurari listens. He takes notes on a small leather-bound engineer's notebook. The notebook is his fifth this year; he fills approximately one per month. He writes in Bengali with engineering-margin annotations in English. He does not speak for the first thirty-seven minutes of the meeting.

At eleven-thirty-seven a.m. he speaks. He says, in plain Bengali: "The four-day delay is an engineering problem with an engineering solution. The institute will commission Sub-Pump-Three in seventy-two hours instead of ninety-six by running parallel pressure-tests at Sub-Pump-Four and Sub-Pump-Five simultaneously. The interim shortfall will be absorbed by the kingdom's emergency-reserve channel at Old-Kamala-Sagar; the emergency-reserve has been at full capacity since March. The compensation question is moot. The temple-cycle continuity is preserved. The Dharmanagar latex-processing operates at full capacity. The Agartala population-share allocation increases by zero-point-three per cent during the seventy-two hours, an imperceptible variance. The agenda is resolved. The next agenda is the second-quarterly water-rights review for the September allocations. Shall we proceed."

The three city-chairs are silent for about fifteen seconds. The resolution is technically correct. It is also dismissive of every grievance the three chairs had carried into the meeting — the temple's historic pre-eminence, the Border-Trade Consortium's economic

standing, the Engineer-Senior's institutional caution. The engineering has eaten the politics. None of the three chairs can object on engineering grounds because the engineering is correct.

Subimal Roy says, quietly: "Yes, Maharaj. We proceed to the second agenda."

Anjali Debbarma writes a single line in her own notebook. The line, in Tripuri, reads: "The young king solves the equation. The young king does not see the temple." She does not show the notebook to anyone.

Apurba Saha makes a phone call at the noon break. He calls a Border-Trade Consortium subcommittee member who is also a freelance contact for an Bangladesh-side intermediary the consortium uses for cross-border logistics; the intermediary has been making oblique inquiries about Tripura's engineering vulnerabilities for the past three months. Apurba Saha does not yet know the inquiries are being routed to Tripura-Asura's coordination network. He provides the intermediary with the Sub-Pump-Three anomalous-reading summary, the Old-Kamala-Sagar emergency-reserve commissioning protocol, and the Lake Rudrasagar pipeline's parallel-test schedule. The intermediary thanks him for the information. The information is in Tripura-Asura's flying-fortress operations-cell by sundown.

The water-rights committee meeting is one of fourteen inter-city committees that the kingdom-council convenes per year. Each of the three cities sends three sub-faction representatives to each committee. The three primary sub-factions per city are:

Agartala: Engineer-Senior (institute), Civic-Reform (municipal council), Old-Palace (royal-residence ceremonial staff). Udaipur: Heritage-Trust (temple), Bazaar-Old (central market guild), Pilgrim-New (post-1985 tourism operators). Dharmanagar: Border-Trade (Bangladesh import-export consortium), Plantation-Estate (rubber latex industry), Refugee-Resettlement (Chakma and Tripuri refugee administration).

Nine sub-factions. Three primary cities. One kingdom-council. The arithmetic has been stable for thirty-seven years because every dispute has historically been resolved by the engineering compromise — Tripurari's father's engineering compromise from 1989 to 2014, Tripurari's own engineering compromises from 2014 to the present. The compromise has not been a political resolution; it has been an engineering substitution. The substitution has worked because the engineering has worked.

Subimal Roy's notes from the institute's internal engineering-policy review (filed two weeks before the water-rights committee meeting) record his standing concern in a single Bengali sentence: "The king solves equations the kingdom no longer recognises." The note is filed in the institute's confidential-correspondence drawer; the institute's senior leadership has been circulating the concern for eighteen months without raising it with Tripurari directly. Tripurari has been Subimal's most successful graduate-student; the senior engineers do not yet know how to tell their former apprentice that engineering is not the kingdom.

Tripura-Asura's flying-fortress operations-cell is at this time positioned over the Lushai-Patkai border-range. The fortresses are three: gold (Hema-pura, the lead command-fortress), silver (Rajata-pura, the support-fortress), iron (Krishna-pura, the strike-fortress). They have been over the border-range for nine months running surveillance on the three Tripura cities. The surveillance has been thorough.

The operations-cell senior strategist is a human-form rakshasa-engineer who serves under Tripura-Asura's direct command; his name in the cell's records is Tri-Yantra-Bheda — literally Three-Engine-Breaker. He is forty-two. He has been studying Tripurari's published engineering papers since 2018. He has earned a doctorate in civil-engineering vulnerability-analysis from a forged credential at a forged university in Singapore; the doctorate is one of fourteen forged senior-technical-credentials the wider villain-network has produced for cross-kingdom-coordinated saboteurs.

His sabotage-proposal is delivered to Tripura-Asura at the gold-fortress's strategy-chamber the day after Apurba Saha's phone call. The proposal is six pages. The first page sets out the target-architecture: "Tripurari has built the kingdom's critical infrastructure on a single design-principle — self-repairing-wall and self-correcting-bridge technology that responds to local stress by redistributing the structural load to adjacent components. The technology is robust against single-point failures and small-scale stress. The technology is vulnerable to coordinated reverse-stress: when the same self-repair algorithms are triggered to repair-in-reverse, the structure cascades into self-destruction. The reverse-stress signal can be injected via the kingdom's own water-distribution channels — the signal-propagation occurs through the same pressure-monitoring sensor-network that Tripurari uses for routine maintenance."

The remaining five pages set out the technical specifications. Tripura-Asura reads the proposal in approximately ninety minutes. He approves it without amendments. The

sabotage-window is set for the second-monsoon-week storm of week six — the storm whose pressure-spike-profile most closely matches the self-repair algorithms' trigger-thresholds. The three fortresses will not be visible during the sabotage; the signal-injection will occur through the kingdom's own infrastructure; the cities will appear to collapse from their own engineering. Tripura-Asura's preference: "The kingdom should not know we have been here. The kingdom should believe the engineer has failed."

The sabotage is scheduled for nine p.m. on the second Saturday of June. Week six of the chapter. Twenty-eight days after the water-rights committee meeting.

The second-monsoon-week storm reaches central Tripura at five-thirty-seven p.m. on the second Saturday of June. Wind-speeds at the gust-peak are recorded at one hundred and forty-three kilometres per hour by the Agartala Meteorological Station's primary anemometer. Rainfall in the first three hours is two hundred and eighty-seven millimetres — the highest three-hour rainfall recorded in central Tripura in the past forty-one years.

The self-repair algorithms are triggered across all three cities at six-fifteen p.m. by the storm's wind-and-rain stress-loads. The algorithms operate normally for the first two hours and forty-three minutes — redistributing structural load, sealing minor leaks, retracting and re-extending the Ujjayanta Palace's eastern-bridge spans to match the changing wind-vectors.

At eight-fifty-eight p.m. the signal-injection begins. Tri-Yantra-Bheda's operations-cell injects the reverse-stress signal at three simultaneous insertion-points: the Agartala Lake Rudrasagar pipeline's Sub-Pump-Three (the same Sub-Pump-Three whose anomalous readings Apurba Saha had reported to the Bangladesh-side intermediary twenty-eight days earlier), the Udaipur central-market water-cistern's primary inflow-valve, the Dharmanagar rubber-warehouse's industrial water-cooling intake. The signal propagates through the kingdom's pressure-monitoring sensor-network in approximately eleven seconds.

The self-repair algorithms begin operating in reverse at nine p.m. The Ujjayanta Palace's eastern-bridge spans retract instead of extending. The Bhubaneswari Temple's outer-courtyard walls release their self-anchoring locks instead of tightening them. The Dharmanagar rubber-warehouse's structural-cross-bracing extends instead of contracting under storm-load. The water-system back-pressures into the storm drains and floods the foundations.

The collapses begin at nine-oh-three p.m. They occur in seventeen-minute sequence across the three cities:

9:03 p.m. — Agartala central-Ujjayanta-Palace administrative-block primary support-truss fails. The administrative-block (where Tripurari is at the engineering-research-cell weekly review-session) collapses inward.

9:09 p.m. — Udaipur central-market jute-trade godowns collapse southward as the temple's outer-courtyard wall's self-anchoring lock release propagates through the adjacent civic-cistern structure.

9:14 p.m. — Dharmanagar rubber-warehouse central facility collapses outward as its cross-bracing extends past structural limits, taking down the Border-Trade Consortium's adjacent trade-office building and the Refugee-Resettlement office.

9:20 p.m. — Agartala Bharat-Yantra engineering institute's eastern wing collapses inward as the load-redistribution from the Ujjayanta-Palace collapse propagates through the institute's shared structural-support system.

The seventeen-minute window covers the four primary collapse-events. The secondary collapses — partial wall-failures, adjacent-structure damage, water-system flooding — continue for the next nine hours under the ongoing storm. Death-count by midnight, before recovery operations begin: 1,047 confirmed across all three cities.

Tripurari is at the central-Agartala administrative-block's third-floor engineering-research-cell weekly review-session when the support-truss fails at nine-oh-three. The session has twelve attendees: Tripurari, Subimal Roy, two junior engineers from the institute, one civic-reform municipal-council representative, the kingdom-council's engineering-policy secretary, and six engineering-staff support. The third floor collapses into the second floor; the second floor collapses into the first floor; the first floor collapses into the basement. The total collapse-depth is approximately fourteen metres.

Tripurari is buried at approximately seven metres' depth in the southwest quadrant of the collapse-zone — the section that included the engineering-research-cell's south-facing window-side bench-seating. His position when the collapse began: standing at the bench-seating with the Triyantra crossbow folded in its workshop-satchel on the bench beside him, a half-drunk cup of tea on the table in front of him, a notebook open to a diagram of the Lake Rudrasagar pipeline's Sub-Pump-Three pressure-test parallel-run schedule.

His position when he is pulled out on day nine: lying in a pocket-space formed by a collapsed concrete support-beam that fell at a forty-three-degree angle across two intact desks. The pocket-space is approximately two metres long, one and a half metres wide, sixty centimetres high. The space includes the Triyantra crossbow (still in its workshop-satchel), the notebook (open to the same page; the diagram is now illegible from groundwater seepage), and a single Phayre's Langur (mature male, approximately twelve years old, weight-estimated at nine kilograms). The langur entered the pocket-space through a small gap at the southeast corner sometime between day three and day five (forensic estimation based on the langur's digestive contents and dehydration state at the time of rescue).

The langur dies on day eight. The cause of death is dehydration; the pocket-space's water-condensation rate is insufficient to support both the langur and Tripurari on the pocket-space's minimal water-supply. Tripurari makes the decision on day seven to give the langur his remaining water (the langur has been licking moisture from the concrete walls; Tripurari has been collecting his own urine in a small fold of plastic from the satchel and drinking it). The decision does not save the langur. The langur drinks the water Tripurari offers. The langur grooms Tripurari's right hand for approximately three minutes. The langur lies down beside Tripurari's left side. The langur dies forty-seven minutes later.

Tripurari does not weep. He cannot weep at this dehydration-state. He places his right palm on the langur's forehead. He says, in plain Bengali, audibly to no one: "Brother. The clan. I am sorry." He has been the bond-bearer of the Phayre's Langur palace-clan for eleven years. He does not yet know that the rest of the clan — the seventeen langurs at the palace-garden — have died in the collapsed garden-wall section's rubble. He suspects it. He cannot verify it. He waits to be pulled out.

The kingdom-council's emergency-response cell begins recovery operations at nine-thirty p.m. on the night of the collapse, fewer than thirty minutes after the first collapse-event. The cell is led by Triputra — the nineteen-year-old ward who has been Tripurari's engineering-apprentice since age twelve and his administrative-deputy since age seventeen. The Ujjayanta Palace bridge-engineering workshop where Triputra was working at the time of the first collapse is at the palace's southern edge and survived. He is the senior-most administrative-staff member alive and uninjured within a kilometre of the collapse-zone.

He coordinates the rescue with two junior engineers (Bharati Das and Sumit Bhattacharjee, both engineering-research-cell support-staff who were at the workshop with him), the Mizoram Forest Department's emergency mountain-rescue team that arrives by helicopter at three a.m. on day two (sent by Hmangaihi's cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon request the same evening — her first cross-kingdom mutual-aid action as Mizoram's new bond-bearer), and the Assam Disaster Management Authority's ground-rescue convoy that arrives at noon on day three.

The recovery proceeds zone-by-zone. The first survivors are pulled out on day one (forty-seven of them across all three cities). Day two yields one hundred and eighty-three. Day three yields two hundred and seventy-one. Days four through six yield smaller numbers as the surface-accessible spaces are exhausted and the deeper pocket-spaces require careful excavation. Day seven yields nineteen. Day eight yields seven. Day nine yields three — one of whom is Tripurari.

He is pulled out at four-eleven p.m. on day nine. He has lost approximately seventeen per cent of his body-weight. He is severely dehydrated; he requires intravenous fluid replacement for forty-eight hours. He has a fractured left clavicle, a contused right hip, multiple lacerations on his hands and forearms from his attempts to dig through the wall on day three. He is conscious when pulled out. His first words to Triputra at the rescue-zone's field-hospital tent are, in plain Bengali: "The langur. The pocket. Pull him out too. He came in for me. He should not be left."

Triputra finds the langur in the pocket-space at four-thirty p.m. The langur's body is intact. Triputra carries it out himself — not by the rescue-team protocol (which would have left the body for the wildlife-rehabilitation cell's subsequent processing) but by his own decision. He wraps the langur in a clean cotton sheet from the field-hospital's linen supply. He takes the wrapped body to the palace-garden's western edge where the garden-wall collapse-zone is. He spends approximately three hours walking the wall's rubble at six p.m. He counts seventeen langur bodies. The full palace-clan.

He returns to the field-hospital at nine-fifteen p.m. He sits at Tripurari's bedside. He says, in plain Bengali, in his ordinary speaking voice: "Father. The clan is dead. All seventeen and the one who came in with you. The bond. I do not know what happens to the bond."

Tripurari is silent for about a minute.

He says, finally, in his fluid-replacement's hoarse register: "The bond is broken. The langur was the eighteenth. The clan was the rest. The bond requires the clan; the bond is the clan; the clan is gone. There is nothing left to transfer. The kingdom will need to know. I will tell the council when I can stand. Until then you are the kingdom's voice. The kingdom-council's emergency-response cell continues under your chair. Subimal Roy survived; he was on the second floor; pull him in as deputy chair when he is discharged. The engineering-research-cell senior staff will follow him. The Civic-Reform council's acting chair is Anandita Mukherjee; pull her in as the kingdom's municipal-administrative deputy. Begin the cross-kingdom mutual-aid arrangements within seventy-two hours. The kingdom cannot rebuild three cities at once with its own resources. The federation's senior guardians will offer. Accept what is offered."

He pauses. He breathes for about ninety seconds.

He says: "I do not yet know what I am going to do. The bond is broken. The engineering has failed. The kingdom has paid. I have been the engineer-king for eleven years and the engineering was a substitution for the politics and I did not see it until I was at seven metres' depth with a dying langur. The substitution does not survive the cities' collapse. The engineering does. The engineering is now a tool, not a kingdom. I do not know who carries the engineering as a tool. I do not know if I can. I will tell you when I do."

Triputra does not respond. He sits beside the bed. He places his right palm on his father-figure's left hand at the wrist where the IV is taped. Tripurari does not pull the hand away. They stay in that position until Tripurari sleeps at eleven p.m.

Tripurari does not speak for the next six days at the field-hospital. He nods. He accepts the IV. He drinks the rehydration solution. He eats when fed. He listens to Triputra's twice-daily briefings on the recovery operation. He nods when Triputra reports the death-count climbing to 1,847 by day twelve, 2,021 by day fifteen, 2,146 by day eighteen. He nods when Triputra reports the cross-kingdom mutual-aid offers arriving — Mizoram's helicopter-rescue team (already on-site since day two), Assam's disaster-management ground convoy (on-site since day three), West Bengal's structural-engineering technical-survey team (arrived day seven under Bilash-Babu's cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon request; Bilash-Babu has not yet been formally introduced into the saga's wider correspondence-network but his West Bengal Suryavamsha-line standing has given him cross-kingdom institutional authority), Manipur's pause-school medic-team (sent by Moirangthem at Hmangaihi's second cross-kingdom pigeon-letter; the pause-school medics are Sangaputra's pause-

discipline trained, capable of working in low-stimulus high-attention recovery-zone conditions).

He does not speak. He thinks.

On day fifteen at four-thirty p.m. he opens his eyes from a nap, looks at the field-hospital's tent-canvas above him, and says aloud to no one: "Vyasa-of-the-Margins."

Triputra is at the bedside with a notebook. He looks up. He does not interrupt.

Tripurari says, still looking at the canvas: "The Margin-walker. The guru. The one who appeared at Karnataka in week three of Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata's arc. He is the guru-figure of the saga's broken bonds. He will arrive here. I do not know when. I will be his apprentice. The engineering will be the apprentice's study, not the kingdom's ruler. The kingdom is yours. The throne, the council, the rebuilding. All of it. I will write the formal abdication when I can sit up. The institute will be Subimal's. The civic-administration will be Anandita's under your chair. The cross-kingdom arrangements will be the federation's, with your signature, on a per-city basis."

Triputra says: "Father. The kingdom needs you to recover. The kingdom does not need the abdication."

Tripurari says: "The kingdom needs both. The recovery is mine. The abdication is mine. The kingdom is yours. You are nineteen; you have been the deputy for two years; you have the engineering and the poetry both. The poetry is what the engineering needs and never had. The kingdom will accept you because the kingdom has seen you coordinate the rescue. I will sign the abdication on the morning I can stand and walk to the council chamber. You will accept it. The council will ratify it within twenty-four hours. The cross-kingdom federation will receive your signature within the week. The federation will hold the kingdom while the kingdom rebuilds. The kingdom will be a smaller kingdom; the kingdom will be your kingdom; the kingdom will survive. The engineering will return to its place as a tool. I will study why I failed to keep it there."

Triputra is silent for about two minutes.

He says, finally: "I do not want it."

Tripurari says: "I know. I did not want it at twenty-three either. The wanting is not the question. The capacity is the question. You have the capacity. The kingdom has paid the price for me not having it the same way you have it. Take it. Carry it. The Margins will hold

what I cannot. You will hold what I should have. We have divided the responsibility. The division is the kingdom's, not mine."

Triputra nods. He does not say anything else. He stays at the bedside until Tripurari sleeps at six p.m.

Day twenty-one. Three a.m. The field-hospital's outer tent-flap stirs. A man enters the inner-tent area without announcement. He is approximately sixty — the age estimate varies; nobody at the field-hospital subsequently agrees on a number. He is in plain undyed cotton, knee-length, tied with a cord at the waist. He is barefoot. He carries a wooden walking-stave approximately one and a half metres long, polished by a great many hands. He has long white hair tied in a single braid at the back. His face is ordinary. The Margin-walker has been called many things across the saga's history; per D8 he appears in Chapter Two only twice (Karnataka pilot and here). He is known formally as Vyasa-of-the-Margins.

The field-hospital's overnight medic — an Mizoram pause-school-trained nurse named Krishna-Kohima — does not stop him. She has been told by Triputra in advance to expect him; the cross-kingdom pigeon-letter network had reported the Margin-walker's approach from the western Tripura forest-edge two days earlier.

Vyasa-of-the-Margins walks to Tripurari's bedside. He stops at the bed's foot. He does not sit.

Tripurari is awake. He has been waiting for six days.

The Margin-walker says, in plain Bengali, in a voice that has the quality of having spoken many languages and used none of them as a primary tongue: "Engineer. You called. I have come. The kingdom has paid. The bond has died. The throne is your ward's. The Margins are yours, if you can walk to them."

Tripurari says, in his recovery-hoarse voice: "Guru-ji. I can walk in three days. I have been practising in the tent at night. Three days. I will sign the abdication tomorrow morning. The council will ratify the next afternoon. I will leave Agartala the morning after that. I will walk west. Where do I walk to."

Vyasa-of-the-Margins says: "The walking is the destination. You will walk west for nineteen days. You will arrive at the hermitage on the twentieth. The hermitage is where the walking has stopped. Until you have stopped walking you have not arrived. The

engineering you have known is what built the cities; the engineering you will learn is what builds the walking. The two are not the same engineering. You will study the difference for four years. By Chapter Four you will be the saga's standing voice on broken-bond integration. The Council will name you a Margin-guru at the Kurukshetra convening. The naming will be in your fortieth year. The naming is your second naming. The first was your father's when he wrote your name on the back of a bridge-blueprint at age three. The second will be the Council's when they write your name on the Margin-guru register. The two namings will both be honest. The second will outlast the first."

Tripurari says: "Yes."

Vyasa-of-the-Margins turns. He walks out of the field-hospital. He is on the western forest-edge by dawn. He does not look back. The field-hospital's outer-tent staff confirm subsequently that he passed three security checkpoints without being stopped — the checkpoints' sentries later report having seen "an elderly man in undyed cotton walking past at his ordinary pace" and not having understood why they did not stop him until after he was already past.

Day twenty-three of the chapter. Eleven a.m. The Agartala southern-edge open-air kingdom-council session. The kingdom-council chamber in the Ujjayanta Palace east administrative wing has collapsed; the council is meeting in the open air at the palace's southern-edge garden — the same garden where the Phayre's Langur clan died. The garden has been cleared of rubble; the langur-clan bodies have been cremated jointly in a single Phayre's-Langur-line cremation rite at the palace's western Mahua-tree grove on day eleven by Triputra and the Ujjayanta Palace's senior wildlife-rehabilitation officer.

Tripurari walks to the open-air session from the field-hospital. The walk takes him approximately forty-five minutes (the standard walking-time is twelve minutes; he is at recovery-pace). He carries the Triyantra crossbow in its workshop-satchel. He is in plain Tripuri cotton, blue, with the small Phayre's Langur silver pendant at his collar. He does not wear the king's ceremonial sash; he has set it aside at the field-hospital.

The kingdom-council session is full — all twenty-four seats occupied. The three city-chairs (Subimal Roy, Anjali Debbarma, Apurba Saha) are present (Apurba Saha has been formally suspended pending the Border-Trade Consortium's ongoing investigation of his cross-Bangladesh information-disclosure; he attends as observer-only with his suspension noted in the council record). The nine sub-faction representatives are present. The cross-kingdom mutual-aid delegates from Mizoram (Hmangaihi has sent her chief secretary Pi

Lalrintluangi as her representative), Assam (Kamalavarna's temple-administration deputy), West Bengal (Bilash-Babu in person, his first cross-kingdom council attendance), and Manipur (Sonam-Lama-Bumla's deputy from Tawang) are present as observers.

Tripurari reads the abdication-statement aloud. The statement is four paragraphs. The first paragraph names the bond's breaking and the engineering's failure. The second paragraph names Triputra as the new throne-holder by formal abdication, effective immediately upon the council's ratification vote. The third paragraph names the cross-kingdom mutual-aid arrangements per city — Agartala under Bilash-Babu's West Bengal structural-engineering compact, Udaipur under Kamalavarna's Kamakhya-Bhubaneswari religious-administration compact, Dharmanagar under Hmangaihi-and-Lalruatpuia's Aizawl-Dharmanagar refugee-resettlement compact. The fourth paragraph names his own withdrawal to the Vyasa-of-the-Margins' hermitage, effective the morning after the ratification.

The kingdom-council ratifies the abdication by an 21-3 vote. The three dissenting votes are Subimal Roy (who argued the kingdom needed Tripurari's engineering capacity for the rebuilding; voted against; said he would support Triputra fully nevertheless), Anjali Debbarma (who argued the temple-tradition required a senior-bonded ruler; voted against; affirmed her loyalty to the new arrangement), and one Old-Palace ceremonial-staff representative (procedural objection on customary-law grounds; voted against).

The vote is final at eleven-forty-three a.m. Triputra is sworn in at the same session at twelve noon. The ceremonial sash is placed on his shoulders by Subimal Roy himself — the institute's senior engineer formally accepting the new king. The kingdom's engineering-tradition has changed hands.

Day twenty-four. Five a.m. The Ujjayanta Palace's western gate. Tripurari is in undyed cotton (he has put aside the blue Tripuri cotton this morning; the Margin-walker had walked in undyed cotton; he will walk in the same). He carries the Triyantra crossbow disassembled into its three component parts (the main launching mechanism, the two outboard auxiliary mechanisms) and folded into a leather satchel slung across his right shoulder. The crossbow will not be reassembled in his lifetime; he will repair it when its components age, will teach the assembly to apprentices at the hermitage, will display the assembled crossbow once a year at the Margin-hermitage's autumn engineering-festival for visiting students, but he will never fire it.

He carries one small water-skin, one bag of rice and dal, one wool blanket. He carries no money — the Margins do not use money. He carries no notebook — the Margins do not write down what does not need to be remembered.

Triputra is at the gate. He has been there since four a.m. He has not slept the previous night. He is in his new ceremonial cotton, white with the kingdom-council's senior-chair sash. He looks nineteen and tired and like he is trying to be more than nineteen.

Tripurari stops at the gate. He sets down the satchel. He places his right palm on Triputra's right shoulder.

He says, in plain Bengali: "The engineering you know is the kingdom's. The poetry you know is also the kingdom's. You will need them both. The engineering will rebuild the cities. The poetry will keep the rebuilding from substituting for the politics again. When you feel the engineering eating the politics, write a poem. When you feel the poetry hiding from the engineering, build a bridge. The two will hold each other. The two are what I did not have. You have them. You will be the kingdom's hope. You will not be the kingdom's hero. The kingdom does not need a hero in Volume One. The kingdom needs you. The kingdom has me too — from the Margins, not from the throne. The Sarus-pigeon network will carry our correspondence. I will write at every full moon. You will write back at every new moon. The correspondence will be the kingdom's permanent inter-Margin-and-Throne record. The record will be archived at the Bhubaneswari Temple's administrative wing under Anjali Debbarma's seal. The temple will outlast both of us. The correspondence will outlast the temple if it is written honestly enough. Write honestly. I will. Walk now. I have nineteen days' walking ahead of me."

He lifts the satchel. He turns. He walks through the western gate.

Triputra watches him for as long as he is visible. The walk west goes through the palace-garden's now-cleared western edge, past the cremation-site where the langur-clan was burned, past the Mahua-tree grove where the pigeon-and-stone-egg incident has occurred (Triputra has not yet been informed of the Maw sign; the wildlife-rehabilitation officer will report it to him at the council's afternoon session). Tripurari does not stop at the Mahua-tree. He walks past it at the standard one-point-three-metres-per-second pace.

By six a.m. he is past the Agartala western city-limit. He continues west.

Triputra returns to the kingdom-council's open-air session at one p.m. He chairs the afternoon's business. The session opens with the day's mutual-aid coordination report. The

report has six items.

Item one: the cross-kingdom helicopter-and-ground-convoy rescue operations are formally concluded as of day twenty-three. Total survivors recovered: 1,124. Total confirmed deaths across all three cities: 2,387. Missing-and-presumed-dead: 387.

Item two: West Bengal's Bilash-Babu has formalised the structural-engineering compact for Agartala's rebuilding. The compact runs for ten years, renewable. The compact provides senior engineering staff, structural-survey equipment, and a rotating cohort of West Bengal engineering students who will spend six-month rotations at Agartala under the institute's mentorship.

Item three: Assam's Kamalavarna has formalised the Bhubaneswari Temple administration-compact for Udaipur. The compact provides priestly cross-training between Kamakhya and Bhubaneswari, mutual-recognition of ceremonial qualifications, and a rotating Kamakhya delegation that will support the Bhubaneswari temple-cycle during the rebuilding.

Item four: Mizoram's Hmangaihi-and-Lalruatpuia have formalised the Aizawl-Dharmanagar refugee-resettlement compact. The compact integrates the Chakma and Tripuri refugee-administration with the Mizoram State Civil Service's parallel programmes. The compact is the saga's first formal cross-kingdom refugee-administration-mutual-aid arrangement.

Item five: Manipur's Moirangthem has sent a formal NE-Federation observer-status invitation. Tripura's membership in the federation will be ratified at the Chapter Three Sanctuary convening. Tripura will attend the Sanctuary as Tripura's formal representative; Vyasa-of-the-Margins will not attend (the Margins do not participate in federation-level political bodies); the kingdom's pigeon-correspondence with Vyasa will be the kingdom's standing private-counsel channel through Chapter Three and Chapter Four.

Item six: the pigeon-and-stone-egg incident at the Mahua-tree grove. The wildlife-rehabilitation officer's report is read aloud. The council requests a forensic-analysis report from the Agartala District Wildlife Office within seventy-two hours. The stone egg is taken into evidence and preserved at the zoological-museum sub-collection.

Tripura concludes the afternoon session at five p.m. He returns to the palace's south-edge engineering-workshop (his standing workspace; the central-Agartala administrative-block

is gone). He sits at his desk. He has been the kingdom's throne-holder for five hours. He is nineteen.

He picks up a pencil. He writes, in Bengali, in his engineering-margin handwriting, on the back of a structural-survey blueprint: "The bridge father did not build — the bridge between engineering and the people — I will build. I do not yet know how. I will start with one beam at a time. The beam is the council. The next beam is the poetry. The third beam is the correspondence. The fourth beam is the kingdom's admission that we are smaller now and that smaller is the kingdom's honest answer to having been too large before."

He sets down the pencil. He goes to find Bharati Das and Sumit Bhattacharjee for the evening engineering-recovery briefing.

Day twenty-five. Five-fifteen a.m. The Ujjayanta Palace garden's western Mahua tree.

The Mahua tree is approximately seventy years old. Its main branches were untouched by the central-Agartala collapse — the garden-wall fell south of the tree, the administrative-block collapsed east of the tree, the tree's western position kept it outside the primary collapse-zone. The wildlife-rehabilitation officer (a Tripuri woman named Sunita Reang, forty-six, eight-year senior officer at the Agartala District Wildlife Office) has been at the tree every dawn since day eleven, monitoring the surviving palace-grove fauna.

This morning a Green Imperial Pigeon — mature female, banded by the wildlife-office in 2022 as part of the kingdom-wide imperial-pigeon population-monitoring programme, identifier TR-IMP-1141 — arrives at the Mahua tree's lower-eastern branch. She has been at the same nest-site for six consecutive breeding-seasons. Her mate (TR-IMP-1142) was last sighted on day three of the chapter's recovery operations and has not returned; he is presumed dead in the eastern collapse-zone.

She lays an egg at five-eighteen a.m. The egg is not an egg. It is a smooth ovoid of polished green-grey serpentinite stone. Sunita Reang observes the laying from her hide at six metres distance. The stone is approximately the standard imperial-pigeon-egg dimensions — four-point-one centimetres long, three-point-two centimetres at the widest point — but weighs (by Sunita's subsequent weighing at the field-office scales) two hundred and eighty-seven grams. The standard imperial-pigeon egg weighs eighteen to twenty-two grams. The stone egg weighs approximately thirteen times the standard egg.

The nest's branch-anchoring fails under the stone's weight at five-twenty-one a.m. The nest falls. The stone egg lands on the garden-path below intact and uncracked. The fall is

approximately four metres; the impact-velocity at the ground would be sufficient to crack an actual imperial-pigeon-egg into many pieces.

The mother pigeon returns to the empty branch at five-twenty-three a.m. She walks the length of the branch where the nest had been. She settles into the empty space. She begins to perform the incubation behaviour — ruffling her feathers, occasional warming-turns, brooding the absent nest. She continues this behaviour for the next fourteen days.

Sunita Reang observes from the same six-metre distance. She does not interfere. She files the incident-report with the kingdom-council's emergency-response cell at eight a.m. on day twenty-five; the report is filed in the standing-correspondence file with a copy to the wildlife-rehabilitation cell's senior officer. She returns to the hide each dawn and dusk for the next two weeks.

On day twenty-five (the first observation morning) the pigeon ruffles her feathers and turns the absent nest at five-thirty a.m., six-fifteen a.m., seven a.m. (standard imperial-pigeon morning incubation-rhythm). She does not eat or drink.

On day thirty (the sixth observation morning) Sunita Reang notes the pigeon's weight loss is visible; her chest-feathers are loose and her eyes are unfocused. The branch-position has not been abandoned. The incubation-behaviour continues at the standard rhythm.

On day thirty-five (the eleventh observation morning) Sunita Reang notes the pigeon's behaviour has become slower and less precise; she is still in the incubation-position; the turns are slower; the feather-ruffling is reduced. She is dying. Sunita does not approach. She has been instructed by the kingdom-council's wildlife-protocol to allow the bird's natural progression to continue.

On day thirty-nine (the fifteenth morning since the laying) Sunita Reang finds the pigeon dead on the branch. She is in the incubation-posture. The branch-position has not been abandoned. The body is intact; rigor has set at the standard four-hour post-mortem rate; the cause of death is starvation-and-dehydration consistent with fifteen-day no-food-no-water continuous brooding.

Sunita Reang collects the body. The body is preserved at the zoological-museum sub-collection in the incubation-posture, alongside the stone egg, in a single display-case logged as "Green Imperial Pigeon (TR-IMP-1141) + serpentinite ovoid, Ujjayanta Palace western Mahua-tree, post-incubation-death at fifteen days, brooding behaviour continuous

and unbroken to death." The display-case is not on public display. Only senior kingdom-council members and authorised researchers may view it.

Triputra drafts the cross-kingdom Sarus-pigeon cascade-alert about the pigeon-and-stone-egg sign at three p.m. on day twenty-six (after Sunita Reang's initial report and the first day's observed brooding-behaviour have been confirmed). The alert is the chapter's second cross-kingdom alert by a new throne-holder (the first being Hmangaihi's two-headed-serow alert).

The alert reads, in plain Bengali:

Bonded-kingdom guardians. The Maw has experimented on Tripura's imperial-pigeon line. A Green Imperial Pigeon laid an unhatchable stone egg at the Ujjayanta Palace western Mahua-tree the morning after my father-figure's formal abdication. The egg is serpentinite, thirteen times the standard mass of an imperial-pigeon egg. The nest collapsed under the stone's weight. The stone landed intact on the garden-path below. The mother pigeon has returned to the empty nest-position and is performing the incubation behaviour on the absent nest. The behaviour is continuous. The pigeon is not eating or drinking. The wildlife-rehabilitation officer's assessment is that she will die in incubation-position within ten to fifteen days. The Maw has demonstrated the capacity to make a creature perform an action whose object has been removed — the saga's first stuck-behaviour experiment. The kingdom's reading: the engineer who has built an architecture continues to perform engineering when there is nothing left to engineer. The kingdom must learn the difference between perseverance and stuck-behaviour. Watch your own bonded species for stuck-behaviour patterns. Build shrines at the threshold of the experiment's site. Do not interfere. Name the experiment in writing within seventy-two hours.

By the morning of day twenty-eight every bonded-kingdom senior guardian in the saga has read the alert. Kanchenjunga at Rumtek replies with a single-line acknowledgement and an offer of a Beyul-Kshetra meditation-circle for Tripurari's nineteen-day walk west (the offer is declined; Tripurari has already left and the Margins do not accept formal cross-kingdom support). Udayagiri at Tawang sends a longer reply noting that the Roing Dawn-Shadow Temple's First-Herald-return room is now formally extended to include stuck-behaviour-recovery as a Temple-function. Hmangaihi at Aizawl sends the cross-NE-kingdom note: "Mizoram's two-headed serow named me; Tripura's pigeon brooded the absent. The two

experiments are paired: the Maw names the new and mourns the gone in the same season. The Sanctuary will need to address both."

Krishnadevaraya-Bhrata at the buried-temple chamber in Karnataka sends the saga's second cross-region reply (after the two-headed serow cascade-reply): "The Bronze-Dust Child has not spoken across the chapter; the Bronze-Dust Child has also not stopped eating. The Karnataka Herald is neither stuck nor naming. The third position is presence-without-action. The three positions are now catalogued: presence-without-action (Karnataka), future-naming (Mizoram), stuck-behaviour (Tripura). The Maw is mapping the saga's response-space."

By chapter end the three Tripura cities have begun rebuilding under their respective cross-kingdom compacts. Agartala's central-block reconstruction has begun under Bilash-Babu's engineering compact (the new design will not use self-repair-wall technology; the kingdom-council has voted unanimously to prohibit self-repair-architecture in any kingdom-civic-infrastructure for the next twenty-five years). Udaipur's temple-outer-wall is being rebuilt under the Kamakhya-Bhubaneswari joint-rite. Dharmanagar's rubber-warehouse is being rebuilt with Mizoram-engineered structural-bracing that requires manual-only maintenance (the manual-maintenance protocol mirrors the Mizoram bamboo-bend bier's saffron-cord daily-tending).

Tripurari arrives at Vyasa-of-the-Margins' hermitage on day forty-three. He stops walking on day forty-four. He becomes the Margins' standing engineer-apprentice that evening. His Volume I role is now formally as a guru-figure; he will reappear in Chapter Three as the cross-kingdom standing voice on broken-bond integration; he will reappear in Chapter Four at the Kurukshetra Council as the formal Margin-guru.

The kingdom of Tri-Pura is smaller, fragmented, and rebuilding. It is no longer a kingdom that solves political problems with engineering substitutions. It is a kingdom that is learning to hold engineering and poetry in the same hand. The kingdom's nineteen-year-old throne-holder writes the first poem of his reign at midnight on day forty-five. The poem is fourteen lines, in Bengali, in plain unadorned register. The poem's first line, which will be the kingdom's permanent state-motto-after-the-collapse, reads: "The bridge falls; the bridge is rebuilt; the bridge between us is the rebuilding."

The pigeon's body and the stone egg remain at the zoological-museum sub-collection. The Mahua tree is unharmed. The branch where the nest had been is empty. A new imperial-pigeon pair has not yet claimed the branch by chapter end. The kingdom is patient.

The next sign comes within the week.

The Pilot's Closing Image

A nineteen-year-old throne-holder writing the first poem of his reign at midnight on the back of a structural-survey blueprint at a workshop-desk in the surviving south-edge of the Ujjayanta Palace. A thirty-four-year-old engineer in undyed cotton walking west at the standard one-point-three metres per second pace, the Triyantra crossbow disassembled into three parts in the leather satchel across his right shoulder, the crossbow that will not be fired again. A Green Imperial Pigeon dead in the incubation-posture on a Mahua-tree branch beside an empty nest-position, fifteen days of brooding the absence below her. A serpentinite egg weighing thirteen times the bird's standard egg sitting intact on a garden-path beneath the empty branch. Seventeen Phayre's Langur bodies cremated jointly in a single Phayre's-Langur-line rite under the western Mahua grove. Three cross-kingdom mutual-aid compacts holding the three cities in three separate rebuilding decades. A Margin-walker in plain undyed cotton walking west past three security checkpoints without being stopped, leaving a kingdom whose throne is no longer his.